

2pt

Fate's Edge

GM Guide

June 9, 2026

Contents

Preface	11
I Foundations	13
1 Introduction: The Weight of Choice	14
1.1 A World Alive with Consequences	14
1.2 Core Philosophy: Narrative First	14
1.3 Risk as the Engine of Drama	15
1.4 Characters Who Change the World	15
1.5 Your Toolkit	15
1.6 How to Use This Book	16
1.7 The GM as Player: A Philosophy	17
1.7.1 What Makes the GM's Role Fun	17
1.7.2 What to Let Go	17
1.8 A Framework, Not a Prescription	17
1.9 Session Zero: The Foundation of Play	18
1.9.1 Core Philosophy to Share with Players	18
1.9.2 Sample Session Zero Checklist	18
1.10 Begin the Journey	20
2 Running the Game: Core Procedures	21
2.1 How to Think in Fate's Edge	23
2.1.1 The Core Loop (In Practice)	24

2.1.2	Your Defaults	24
2.1.3	What You Are <i>Not</i> Doing	24
2.1.4	What You <i>Are</i> Doing	24
2.1.5	A Useful Reframe	25
2.2	Narrative Time: Rounds, Turns, Scenes, and Arcs	25
2.3	The Core Resolution Cycle	26
2.4	Position & Difficulty Value	27
2.4.1	DV 3 as Default	27
2.4.2	When to Worsen Position	27
2.4.3	The Golden Rule	28
2.4.4	Example: Using SB to Escalate a Scene	28
2.4.5	Outcome Matrix	28
2.4.6	Story Beats: The Engine of Drama	29
2.4.7	Failing Forward with SB	30
2.5	Over-Stack Rule	31
2.5.1	When Does Over-Stack Trigger?	31
2.5.2	What Counts as a Structural Advantage?	32
2.5.3	What Happens When Over-Stack Triggers?	32
2.5.4	Examples	32
2.5.5	Design Intent	33
2.6	Learning Through Examples	33
3	Managing Resources	36
3.1	Supply Timer : The Pulse of Survival	36
3.1.1	Supply Timer States	37
3.1.2	When to Advance the Supply Timer	37
3.1.3	Clearing Supply Segments	37
3.2	Fatigue: The Weight of the World	37
3.2.1	Fatigue Effects	38
3.2.2	Clearing Fatigue	38
3.2.3	Fatigue $\rightarrow$ Harm Conversion	38

3.3	Boons: The Currency of Resilience	39
3.3.1	Earning Boons (GM Reminders)	39
3.3.2	Boon Economy (Quick Reference)	39
3.3.3	Spending Boons (Player Options)	40
3.3.4	Anti-Fishing Measures (GM Guidance)	40
3.4	Followers and Assets: Power Beyond the Self	40
3.4.1	Followers: On-Screen Allies	40
3.4.2	Assets: Off-Screen Influence	42
3.5	Terrestrial Patrons: Favors and Influence	43
3.5.1	How Terrestrial Patrons Work	43
3.5.2	Clearing Terrestrial Obligation	43
3.5.3	Asset Slots and Patron Tier	43
3.5.4	Example Terrestrial Patrons	44
3.5.5	Running Terrestrial Patrons	45
3.6	Player Trusts: Shared Legacy	45
3.6.1	Forming a Trust	45
3.6.2	Tiered Buy-In for Trust Slots	46
3.6.3	Upkeep and Delegation	46
3.6.4	Trust Assets in Play	47
3.6.5	Dissolving a Trust	47
3.6.6	Trust Quick Reference	47
3.6.7	Mandate Timer (0–6)	48
3.6.8	Crisis Timer (0–6)	48
3.7	Combat Resource Management	48
3.7.1	Supply in Combat	48
3.7.2	Fatigue in Combat	49
3.7.3	Follower Combat Integration	49
3.8	Narrative First: The Fiction Is the Ledger	49
3.9	Echo Characters: Managing Multi-Character Switching	49
3.9.1	Core Principles	50

3.9.2	The Downtime Log	50
3.9.3	Crisis Timer for Offscreen Characters	51
3.9.4	Return Mechanics	52
3.9.5	Optional: Buddy System	52
3.9.6	Player Guidelines (for GM to communicate)	52
3.9.7	Full Cross-Reference	52
4	Running a Currency-Free Game	53
4.1	Why Fate’s Edge Has No “Money”	53
4.1.1	Design Goals	53
4.2	XP as the Universal Resource	53
4.2.1	GM Guidance on XP Pricing	54
4.3	Temporary “Scrip” for Mercantile Campaigns	54
4.3.1	How the Scrip Timer Works	54
4.3.2	Example: Scrip Timer in a Port City	55
4.4	Differences from Traditional Currency Systems	55
4.5	Caveats and Things to Consider	55
4.6	Running a Currency-Free Game – Practical Tips	56
4.7	Example Session: The Merchant’s Dilemma	56
4.8	Final Thought	56
II	Magic and Scenarios	58
5	Magic and Backlash	59
5.1	The Role of Magic in Your Game	59
5.1.1	Patron as Co-Star	59
5.2	Adjudicating Magic at the Table	60
5.3	Story Beats and Backlash (GM Tools)	66
5.4	Managing Obligation and Corruption	67
5.5	Summoning (GM-Facing)	68
5.6	Cantors and Corruption (GM Guidance)	69

5.7	Ritual Magic (GM Advice)	72
5.8	Psionics (Optional) – GM Sidebar	74
5.9	Quick Reference Tables (GM Only)	74
6	Running Scenarios	76
6.1	GM Mindset: Co-Creating Drama	76
6.2	Preparing a Scenario: The 15-Minute GM Sprint	76
6.3	Running the Scene: The 90-Second Loop	77
6.4	Key GM Techniques	78
6.4.1	The Three-Timer Rule	78
6.4.2	Story Beats Spend Menu	79
6.4.3	Handling Player Creativity	79
6.4.4	Visible Pressure: Making Timers Matter	80
6.5	Common Pitfalls and Fixes	80
6.6	Rookie GM Comfort Dials	80
6.7	Scenario Types: Adapting the Loop	81
6.7.1	Social Encounters	81
6.7.2	Travel Legs	81
6.7.3	Magical Experiments	82
6.8	Ending the Scenario: Leave Hooks, Not Loose Ends	82
6.9	The GM’s Sacred Trust	82
III	Campaign and Tools	83
7	Campaigns, Timers, and Consequences	84
7.1	Foundational Principles for Campaign Design	84
7.1.1	Set Situations, Not Plots	84
7.1.2	Design Timers, Not Every Element	85
7.1.3	Read Your Player Sheets	85
7.1.4	Use Obligation as a Story Engine	85
7.1.5	Embrace the Cascade	85

7.1.6	Let Timers Be Visible	86
7.1.7	Ask Questions, Then Use the Answers	86
7.1.8	Design for Your Tier	86
7.2	Core GM Mechanics	87
7.2.1	Difficulty Values (DV)	87
7.2.2	Position	87
7.2.3	Outcome Matrix	87
7.2.4	Resources: Boons and Story Beats	88
7.3	Campaign Tools	88
7.3.1	The Crown Spread (Session Zero)	88
7.3.2	Timers: The GM's Primary Tool	90
7.3.3	Factions and Fronts	91
7.3.4	Rival Parties	92
7.4	Complications and Hazards	92
7.4.1	Using Story Beats for Complications	92
7.4.2	Hazard Timers	93
7.4.3	Social Hazards	93
7.4.4	Magical Hazards	93
7.5	Running Travel as a Medieval Trek	93
7.5.1	Lead with Weather, Not Distance	93
7.5.2	Maps Are Lies; Guides Are Truth	93
7.5.3	Hospitality as a Resource	94
7.5.4	The Travel Timer as Mood Tracker	94
7.5.5	Genre Shifts Through Borders	94
7.5.6	Traveling Without a Map	94
7.5.7	Roles on the Road	94
7.5.8	Encounters and Events	95
7.5.9	Supply and Depletion	95
7.5.10	Weather and Terrain Modifiers	95
7.5.11	Foraging and Subsistence	95

7.6	Pacing and Arc Structure	96
7.6.1	Session Energy Management	96
7.6.2	Arc Length by Tier	96
7.6.3	Between Sessions: The GM's Sacred Trust	96
7.6.4	The Three-Timer Rule	97
7.7	The Finale: Calling or Forcing the Crown	97
7.7.1	The Finale Procedure	97
7.7.2	Twist Collision (Finale Clause)	97
7.8	Legacy Conversion: Epilogue	98
7.8.1	The Legacy Bond	98
7.8.2	Character Arc Management	98
7.9	Quick Start Campaigns	99
7.9.1	The Sunstone Gambit (Tier I–II, 4–6 sessions)	99
7.9.2	The Dying Sun (Tier III–IV, 6–8 sessions)	99
7.10	Campaign Worksheet	99
7.11	Narrative First: The World Remembers	100
8	Tier IV and V: Running Epic Adventures	101
8.1	What Changes at Tier IV–V	101
8.2	Natural Scaling: The Boon Economy Does the Work	101
8.3	Do Not Inflate Difficulty Values	103
8.4	Failure Must Matter	103
8.5	Using Bonds as the Primary Boon Engine	104
8.6	Designing High-Tier Scenes	104
8.7	Pacing and Scope	105
8.8	Caveats and Warnings	105
8.9	Tools for Managing Boon Scarcity	106
8.10	Optional Epic Tools (Brief)	107
8.11	Sample High-Tier Scenario: The Dying Sun	108
8.12	Final Thought	108

9	Advanced GM Techniques	110
9.1	Advanced Story Beat Management	110
9.2	Mastering the Deck of Consequences	111
9.3	Adjudicating Thresholds	112
9.4	Faction Grand Strategy	113
9.5	Advanced Timer Design	114
9.6	Designing High-Tier Custom Content	115
9.7	Running Mythic Scenarios (Tiers IV–V)	116
9.8	Managing Cross-Patron and Invoker Conflicts	117
9.9	Player-Managed Modules at High Tiers	117
9.10	Advanced Complex Scenarios	118
9.11	When to Say Yes, No, and Yes, But – Advanced Rulings	118
IV	Lore and Reference	120
10	The Known World: A Lore Compendium	121
10.1	A Note on Subgenres and Travel	123
10.2	Acasia — "The Broken Province"	123
10.3	Aelaerem (Halflings) — "Hearth & Hollow"	124
10.4	Aeler (Dwarves) — "Crowns & Under-Vaults"	125
10.5	Aelinnel (Gnomes) — "Stone, Bough, and Bright Things"	126
10.6	Black Banners — "Condotta & Crowns"	127
10.7	Ecktoria — "Marble & Fire"	128
10.8	Linn — "Skerries & Storm-Oaths"	129
10.9	Mistlands — "Bells, Salt, and Breath"	130
10.10	Silkstrand — "City of Bridges & Dyewater"	131
10.11	Theona — "Three Greens, No Ninth"	132
10.12	Thepyrgos — "City of a Thousand Stairs"	133
10.13	Ubral — "The Stone Between Spears"	134
10.14	Valewood — "Empire Under Leaves"	135

10.15	Vhasia — "The Fractured Sun"	136
10.16	Viterra — "The Hedge-Law Realm"	137
10.17	Ykrul (Orcs) — "Wolf Standards, Winter Camps"	138
10.18	Zakov — "Salt & Serpent"	139
10.19	Other Regions (Brief)	140
10.20	Using This Compendium at the Table	140
A	Quick Reference and Tables	141
	Appendix A: Core Reference Tables	142
	Appendix B: Optional Rules and Tactical Tools	145
	Appendix C: Deck and Magic Reference	148
	Appendix D: Campaign Management	150
	Appendix E: Safety and Inclusivity	151
	Appendix F: Rival Party Generator	152
	Appendix G: One-Page GM Screen Summary	155
	Appendix H: Sample Deck Reading (Example)	157
	Appendix I: Session Zero Checklist Handout	158
B	Using Expansions: A Guide for the Overwhelmed GM	159
B.1	The First Rule: You Own the Expansions, They Don't Own You	159
	B.1.1 The Three Questions to Ask Before Opening Any Expansion	159
	B.1.2 The 10% Rule	159
B.2	A Taxonomy of Expansions (What They're Actually For)	160
B.3	The Hybrid Adventure: How to Cook with Leftovers	161
	B.3.1 Example: The Tournament of the Broken Crown	161
	B.3.2 The Hybrid Recipe	161
B.4	Managing Player Expectations	161
	B.4.1 The "Yes, But Later" Rule	161
	B.4.2 The Expansion Session Zero	162
B.5	Cross-Expansion Synergy (When Two Books Work Better Than One)	162
	B.5.1 Antisynergy: When Not to Mix	162

B.6	Practical Tools: The Expansion Integration Checklist	163
B.6.1	Pre-Session (30-60 minutes)	163
B.6.2	During Session (At the Table)	163
B.6.3	Post-Session (5 minutes)	163
B.7	DM's Cheat Sheet: Quick Reference by Page Count	163
B.8	Adversary Templates	166
B.8.1	Generic Adversaries	166
B.8.2	Archetypal Adversaries	167
B.8.3	Using These Templates in Play	169

Preface: A Guide for Guides

“The road remembers. Every broken wheel leaves a mark, every lit lamp bears witness. The only question is: what will you leave behind?”

— Dusana of the Raven Road

Welcome, Game Master. You hold a book that is not a novel to be read cover-to-cover, but a toolkit to be consulted, a set of lenses to be put on and taken off as the light changes. *Fate’s Edge* gives you dice, timers, and a simple resolution loop. What it does not give you is a script. That is your job, and this guide is here to make that job easier — not harder.

How This Book Is Organized

The chapters are arranged from the essential to the optional. Do not feel you must read everything before your first session.

- **chapter 1** — The philosophy of consequences, safety tools, and Session Zero. Read this first.
- **chapter 2** — The core loop, Position, Difficulty, Story Beats, and the infamous “three-timer guideline”. This is the engine room.
- **chapter 3** — Supply, Fatigue, Boons, Followers, Assets, and Terrestrial Patrons. Skim the first half; save the rest for later.
- **??** — Running a world without coin counting. The table “When to Charge What” (??) is pure gold.
- **chapter 5** — Adjudicating spells, backlash, and dangerous tags. Keep the Dangerous Tags table bookmarked.
- **Chapters 6–10** — Example play, survival advice, campaign timers, high-tier play, and advanced techniques.
- **chapter 10** — The Known World. Read only the region where your campaign starts.
- **Appendix A** — Core tables, optional rules, rival generator, and the one-page GM screen (section A). Print the screen. Use the rival generator (section A) when you need a quick antagonist.

A Reading Plan for New GMs

You do not need to master 200 pages to run a great session. Here is what you actually need:

1. Read **chapter 1** (safety, philosophy, Session Zero).
2. Read **chapter 2** up to section 2.3 — the resolution cycle, Position, DV, and the Story Beat spend menu.
3. Read **section 1.7** — practical “now what?” advice.
4. Print the one-page GM screen (section A) and the Outcome Matrix (Table A.1).
5. Keep the Difficulty Ladder (Table A.2) and Harm levels (Table A.3) at hand.
6. Run the Quickstart adventure (“The Lantern at Dusk”) before opening any other chapter.

Everything else — faction turns (??), the Crown Spread (??), epic tier (chapter 8), domain management — is waiting for you when you finish your first arc. Do not try to use it all at once.

The 10% Rule

From ?? (and echoed in Appendix A): pick *one* subsystem from this book and use it tonight. Next session, pick another. The game will not collapse if you never use the Deck of Consequences (section A) or the travel timers (section 7.5). The game *will* collapse if you try to track every timer, every faction, every threshold effect, and every player-managed module at once.

What This Book Is Not

It is not a prescribed curriculum. It is not a contract. It is a set of lenses — put them on when you need focus, take them off when they blur the story. The Golden Rule (see chapter 1) applies to the GM as much as to the players: when in doubt, make a ruling that keeps the story moving. Default to DV 3, Position Controlled, and let the dice fall.

Acknowledgments

This guide stands on the shoulders of every GM who ran a session, forgot a rule, improvised a consequence, and still made the table laugh or gasp. Thank you for doing that work. Now go light a candle, shuffle the deck, and let the road unfold.

— *The Grey Wanderer*
Castra Ferrum, Year of the Iron Harvest

Part I

Foundations

Chapter 1

Introduction: The Weight of Choice

Welcome, Game Master. You hold a unique role in **Fate's Edge**. You are not a solitary storyteller, nor a neutral referee. You are the **weaver of consequences**, the architect of a living world, and the guide on a path where every choice echoes. Your task is to breathe life into a realm of ancient magic, fallen empires, and vibrant cultures—and then let that world respond to the players' ambitions.

Power demands a price. The past never truly sleeps. One decision can reshape a nation or end an age. From the marble forums of Ecktoria to the mist-drenched fens of the Mistlands, the world is alive with stories. Your job is to provide the stage, set the stakes, and embrace the ripple effects of player agency.

1.1 A World Alive with Consequences

In **Fate's Edge**, the fiction is the final authority. The rules are not chains on your imagination, but tools to give weight to your stories. They help you adjudicate risk, track progress, and ensure that both success and failure drive the narrative forward.

Think of yourself as a conductor. The players provide the melody with their characters' actions. You provide the harmony and rhythm with the world's response. The rules are your sheet music—a guide to create a cohesive, dramatic piece, but one that allows improvisation.

Your judgment is the cornerstone of the game. If a rule doesn't serve the moment, change it. If a player's creative idea deserves to succeed, make it work. Your goal is a collaborative story that everyone helps create.

1.2 Core Philosophy: Narrative First

At the heart of **Fate's Edge** is a simple idea: **mechanics serve the story**. A dice roll is never just pass/fail. It changes the fictional landscape.

- **Clean Success** – The plan works as intended.
- **Success with SB** – You get what you want, but the world pushes back.
- **Partial** – You make progress, but the situation remains unresolved.
- **Miss** – You fail, and the situation escalates.

This ensures every roll matters. The story never stalls; it evolves.

1.3 Risk as the Engine of Drama

Fate's Edge is built on **meaningful risk**. Safety is boring. When characters have something to lose—reputation, allies, ideals, life—their actions become heroic or tragically memorable.

Your primary tool for managing risk is the **Story Beat (SB)** economy. When the dice show a **1**, the world reacts. The GM gains SB to introduce complications, escalate threats, or reveal hidden dangers. **Important:** SB are generated on *any* roll that produces a 1, whether the overall roll succeeds or fails. They are not punishment; they are fuel for an unpredictable, responsive narrative.

Example: A successful sword swing defeats an opponent. A Story Beat spent could mean the blade is notched, or that the defeat draws a more powerful foe. The drama continues.

1.4 Characters Who Change the World

Character growth in **Fate's Edge** is not about accumulating abstract power. It is **meaningful growth** rooted in the story. Players earn **Experience Points (XP)** by engaging with challenges and complexities. They spend XP to improve capabilities, acquire assets (a ship, a spy network), or unlock cultural talents.

Thus, advancement ties directly to narrative. A character becomes a legendary commander by leading armies, not by grinding monsters. A wizard masters forbidden lore by surviving backlash. As GM, you curate this growth, presenting challenges that make evolution feel earned and impactful.

1.5 Your Toolkit

To help guide the story, **Fate's Edge** provides interconnected tools:

- **Dice Pool:** Attribute + Skill d10s. 6+ = Success. 1 = Story Beat (SB) for you. Compare successes to Difficulty Value (DV) set by stakes.
- **Position & Effect:** Position (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate) defines stakes of failure. Effect (Limited/Standard/Great) describes what a clean success achieves.
- **Timers:** Visual trackers for ongoing challenges (e.g., 4-segment lock, 8-segment faction rise).
- **Deck of Consequences (optional):** A standard deck to generate thematic complications when SB are spent. Suits suggest nature of trouble.

These tools are designed to be learned quickly and used intuitively, getting out of the way so you and your players focus on the story.

1.6 How to Use This Book

This guide is for running the game.

- Early chapters cover core principles and basic procedures.
- Later chapters dive into advanced systems (conflict, travel, long-term play).
- Final sections provide guidance for high-tier campaigns, world-building, and the Amaranthine Sea setting.
- Appendices offer practical advice and a collection of tools and tables.

You don't need to memorize everything. Use this book as a reference. The most important chapters to internalize are those on core philosophy (this chapter) and basic action resolution (see SRD 2).

Quick Reference: Where to Find It

Use this one-page guide to jump straight to the rules you need at the table.

Safety Tools: Lines, Veils & X-Card

Fate's Edge explores mature themes – conflict, loss, horror, betrayal, and difficult choices. The table must always feel safe. Use these three simple tools.

X-Card (by John Stavropoulos). Any player (including the GM) can draw an “X” or say “X” when uncomfortable. The described content is **removed from the fiction** – no questions, no explanations. The scene is retconned or redirected.

Lines. A hard boundary: content that will not appear at all. Examples: “No sexual violence,” “No harm to children,” “No body horror.” Players name their Lines before the campaign; the group honors them.

Veils. A soft boundary: content that can happen “off screen” or fade to black. The event is acknowledged but not described. Example: “A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit.” Veils let you acknowledge mature themes without forcing players to roleplay through them.

How to Use.

- Establish Lines and Veils in Session Zero. Write them down where everyone can see.
- Keep an X-Card visible (printed card, drawn X, or digital symbol).
- Remind players they can use the X-Card at any time, even mid-sentence.
- When the X-Card is used, pause, rewind if needed, and move on. Do not interrogate.
- The GM is also a player; they may use the X-Card for their own comfort.

- Respect the tools. If someone calls an X-Card, trust they had a good reason.

These tools are not about censorship – they are about **consent**. They allow the table to tell darker, more intense stories because everyone knows they can tap out. A safe game is a game that can go to the edge.

1.7 The GM as Player: A Philosophy

Unlike a board game, where the GM enforces fixed rules, **Fate’s Edge** invites you to **play to find out what happens**. You are not protecting a pre-written plot. You are throwing complications, asking questions, and reacting to player choices with genuine curiosity.

1.7.1 What Makes the GM’s Role Fun

- **Surprise:** When players invent a solution you never considered, celebrate it. Let it change the story.
- **Power with Purpose:** Your resources (SB, timers) are not weapons – they are narrative levers. Using them well feels satisfying.
- **Collaborative Discovery:** You do not know how the scene will end any more than the players do. That uncertainty is the game’s heartbeat.

1.7.2 What to Let Go

- **The need to be “fair” in every roll:** Fairness lives in the fiction, not the dice. It is fair that a desperate roll fails spectacularly.
- **The fear of “losing”:** You cannot lose. Your goal is to make the story memorable, not to defeat the players.
- **The obligation to have all answers:** Say “I don’t know – what do you think?” then build on their answer.

1.8 A Framework, Not a Prescription

Before you build your campaign, internalize this truth: **You own the game. The game does not own you.**

Fate’s Edge provides a library of tools – timers, fronts, travel procedures, faction turns, the Crown Spread, and many more. You are not expected to use all of them. In fact, you are encouraged to use only what your table needs *right now*.

The 10% Rule

As the Grey Wanderer says: *“A single page, well-used, is worth more than a library of unopened tomes. Pick one thing from one expansion. Use it tonight.”*

The same applies to this chapter. Start with:

- **Timers** – always useful.
- **The Crown Spread** – for session zero.
- **One front** – to give the world a pulse.

Ignore faction turns, legacy bonds, and travel sub-systems until they become relevant. Add them when you feel ready, not because the book says they exist.

Discard what doesn’t serve your table. Your campaign will not collapse if you never use the “Timer Relationships” section. It will not break if you skip the faction turn. The rules are here to serve you – not the other way around.

1.9 Session Zero: The Foundation of Play

Before the first dice roll, before the first scene, gather your players for a **Session Zero**. This is where you build the shared understanding that makes **Fate’s Edge** sing.

1.9.1 Core Philosophy to Share with Players

- **Optimal play = most fun.** Spending Boons, embracing failure, and courting Patron attention leads to better stories. There is no “winning” except an unforgettable session.
- **Player-GM contract:** “We are co-creators, not adversaries.” The GM frames pressure; the players drive the fiction. No one is trying to “beat” anyone else.
- **Resource mindset: Boons are not XP tokens.** Spend them. Hoarding Boons for conversion starves the table of drama and leads to less engagement.
- **Patron expectation:** Patrons are allies who demand payment—**embrace it**. Obligation is plot, not punishment. When a Patron calls, a story hook arrives.

1.9.2 Sample Session Zero Checklist

Use this checklist to guide your conversation. Write down the answers where everyone can see them.

1. **Lines & Veils:** What content is off-limits (Lines) or only implied (Veils)?
2. **Tone:** Cinematic action? Grim survival? Political intrigue? Dark horror? Mix of several?
3. **Campaign length:** One-shot, short arc (3–6 sessions), or long campaign (12+ sessions)?
4. **Character hooks:** Each player shares one goal and one fear for their character.
5. **Patron interest:** Which Patrons (if any) are already watching the party?
6. **Starting situation:** Where does the story begin? (Use the Crown Spread – see ?? – or a simple opener.)

7. **House rules:** Any optional subsystems (Threat Pool, Deck of Consequences, etc.) you plan to use?
8. **Scheduling & attendance:** How often do you meet? What happens if a player misses a session?

Taking thirty minutes for Session Zero will save hours of mid-campaign friction and give you a richer, more invested table.

Flavor is Free (Even for Mundane Actions)

Players and GMs: In **Fate's Edge**, **flavor is free** – and it applies to **all descriptive actions**, not just magic.

Add details, cultural touches, and atmospheric flourishes without spending resources or rolling dice. Want your Vhasian duelist to parry with a flourish from royal fencing schools? Go ahead. Want to describe the eerie silence of a Valewood ruin when searching for clues? Perfect.

Encourage players to narrate even mundane successes. For example:

- “I reload my crossbow with a practiced flick of the wrist – the bolt seats with a satisfying *click*.”
- “While the guard checks the other door, I slip the lockpick back into my sleeve and smile innocently.”

Flavor enriches narrative and makes the world feel real. It doesn't change mechanical outcomes, but it defines the *how* and the *why*. The GM should encourage this and reciprocate.

Mechanics determine success or failure; flavor determines the story we tell about it.

A Guide for Veterans: Fate's Edge in a Nutshell

If you're experienced with other RPGs, here's a quick translation of how **Fate's Edge** handles common concepts:

Traditional RPG Concept	Fate's Edge Approach	
Ability Scores & Skills	Attributes (Body, Wits, etc.) + Skills (Melee, Lore, etc.) form a dice pool.	
Skill Checks	Roll Attribute+Skill pool. Count successes (6+). Compare to DV. Any 1s give GM SB.	
Hit Points / Health	Harm Track for injuries. Fatigue for exhaustion. Consequences are narrative and mechanical.	
Combat Rounds	Fiction-first. Actions resolved by narrative timing, not rigid initiative.	
Spell Slots / Mana	Magic uses the same core system. 1s generate SB. Powerful spells may require extra time or risk.	
Saving Throws	Roll Attribute+Skill to resist (e.g., Body+Resolve vs. poison).	
Experience & Leveling Up	Gain XP through play. Spend to increase Attributes/Skills, buy Talents, or acquire Assets. Growth is player-directed.	

The key difference is a consistent, unified mechanic applied across all challenges, focused on narrative outcomes.

1.10 Begin the Journey

Your role is a privilege and a creative challenge. You are a facilitator, a fan of the players, and the keeper of a world that will challenge and surprise them. Trust the rules to handle tension, trust your players to drive the story, and trust yourself to weave it all together.

Now, take a breath. Shuffle the deck. Let the dice fall.

It's time to guide the edge of fate.

Chapter 2

Running the Game: Core Procedures

Running Fate's Edge — Core Procedures in Brief

Your Job: Frame pressure, track consequences, let the fiction move forward.

Default Settings DV = 3 · Position = Controlled · One short Timer

The Core Loop (every meaningful action)

1. Player declares intent & approach (Attribute + Skill)
2. You state Position & set relevant Timers
3. Player rolls d10s; count **Successes (6+)** & **Story Beats (1s)**
4. Compare to DV → use **Outcome Matrix**
5. Apply consequences & update the fiction

Outcome Matrix (what you do)

- **Clean Success** ($S \geq DV$, $SB=0$) → intent achieved, no complication
- **Success with SB** ($S \geq DV$, $SB>0$) → intent achieved, spend SB for a twist
- **Partial** ($0 < S < DV$) → progress made, player gains 1 Boon
- **Miss** ($S = 0$) → no progress, player gains 2 Boons, spend SB to escalate

Story Beats (SB) – spend them to create drama

- **1 SB:** Minor – noise, tick a timer, small setback
- **2 SB:** Moderate – alarm raised, lose advantage, worsen Position
- **3+ SB:** Major – reinforcements, scene shift, break an asset

Golden Rule

When in doubt, make a ruling that keeps the story moving.

Set DV=3, Position=Controlled, ask for the roll, and resolve with the Outcome Matrix.

Position (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate) = How risky is this action? – determines severity of failure and re-rolls.

Effect (Limited/Standard/Great) = How much do you achieve on a success? – determines scope, scale, or quality.

Example: Disarming a trap – Limited Effect lets one person cross, Standard lets two, Great lets all four.

Selling the Action – When Players Give You Gold

“Don’t just tell me you swing your sword. Show me the dust in your eyes, the tremble in your arm, the desperate prayer you whisper to the Traveler.” “And don’t just paint a pretty picture – show me what your character risks, fears, or loves in this moment.”

When a player **sells the action** – not by piling on adjectives, but by revealing what their character cares about, what they stand to lose, or why this moment matters – you have permission to give them a mechanical edge. This is a reward for **roleplay investment**, not vocabulary.

How to Rule It

- **Basic description:** “I attack the goblin.” – No bonus.
- **Tactical description:** The player uses the environment, positioning, or a clever tactic. *Example:* “I feint high, then drive my shoulder into the goblin’s shield, shoving it aside to open its flank.” → **Improve Position by one step** (e.g., Controlled → Dominant) for this roll.
- **Character-driven description:** The player states a stake, invokes a bond, reveals a fear, or makes a hard choice visible. *One heartfelt sentence counts more than a paragraph of adjectives.* *Example:* “I think of my mother, who died because I wasn’t brave enough. I won’t let that happen again. I plant my feet and dare the goblin to come through me.” → **Improve Position by one step and bank 1 Story Beat** (or upgrade Effect by one step, your choice).

What Counts (and What Doesn’t)

Counts:

- Stating a clear stake (“If I fail, my sister doesn’t eat.”)
- Invoking a bond mid-action (“I owe Marcus my life. I’m not letting him face this alone.”)
- Revealing a fear or hope tied to the roll (“I’m terrified of fire, but I grab the beam – the children are behind me.”)
- Making a hard choice visible (“I could run, but I don’t. Running is what got me exiled.”)

Does not count:

- Piling on adjectives (“gleaming,” “mighty,” “ancient”) without stakes.
- Passive sensory laundry lists (“the cold wind, the wet stones, the dim light”).
- Repeating the same florid description for every roll.

Guidelines for Fair Play

- **No penalty for plain speech.** Never punish a player who is tired, shy, or simply prefers quick resolution. The bonus is a gift, not a tax.
- **Be consistent.** Reward genuine investment, not vocabulary. A quiet player who delivers one honest sentence deserves the bonus as much as an eloquent storyteller.
- **Let the fiction guide the bonus.** A desperate, reckless action described with real stakes might upgrade Effect but worsen Position – the mechanics should mirror the fiction.
- **Invite quiet players.** Ask leading questions: “What’s at stake for your character right now?” or “What are you afraid will happen if you fail?” Gentle prompts help shy players find their moment.
- **Group “selling.”** If the whole table contributes to describing a group action (a coordinated ambush, a joint ritual), grant the bonus to the primary roller or give each participant a small benefit (e.g., a one-time +1 die).

Example

Basic: “I sneak past the sentry.” (No bonus, roll as normal.)

Tactical: “I wait for the wind to rattle the shutters, then pad across the wet cobblestones – heel-toe, heel-toe – keeping the stack of barrels between me and the sentry’s gaze.” The GM nods: “Great. Because you’re using the wind and the barrels, roll at **Dominant Position**.”

Character-driven: “My little brother is in that camp. I’ve hidden from every fight since we left home – but not this time. I creep forward, not quiet anymore, because he needs to know someone came for him.” The GM: “That’s the heart of it. Roll at **Dominant Position**, and I’ll bank a Story Beat to make his reaction matter.”

The dice still decide success or failure. But a well-told action makes the story richer – and earns the player an edge when the dice fall.

2.1 How to Think in Fate’s Edge

Running **Fate’s Edge** is less about adjudicating difficulty and more about managing momentum. Your primary job is not to block success, protect outcomes, or simulate realism—it is to **frame pressure, track consequences, and let the fiction move forward**.

If you catch yourself asking “How hard should this be?” you are already one step behind. Instead ask:

- What is at stake right now?
- What happens if this goes wrong?
- What pressure is already in play?

The rules exist to answer those questions—not to replace them.

2.1.1 The Core Loop (In Practice)

Every meaningful action follows the same simple loop:

1. **Player declares intent and approach.**
2. **You state Position and set any relevant Timers.**
3. **The roll resolves the moment.**
4. **You apply consequences and update the fiction.**

Do not search for the “right roll.” If the action matters, the procedure applies.

2.1.2 Your Defaults

When in doubt, trust the fiction. The system will follow. Fall back on these defaults:

- **DV:** 3
- **Position:** Controlled
- **Consequence:** Fatigue, time pressure, or exposure
- **Timers:** One short timer tied to the scene

Escalate only when the fiction demands it.

2.1.3 What You Are *Not* Doing

You are *not*:

- calling for rolls to gate progress
- inflating difficulty to “challenge” the players
- protecting NPC plans from disruption
- hiding information behind unnecessary checks

If the players act decisively, the world must respond decisively.

2.1.4 What You *Are* Doing

You *are*:

- stating Position clearly and confidently
- letting partials move the story forward
- spending Story Beats to make failure interesting
- allowing success to create new problems

The game works best when nothing stalls.

2.1.5 A Useful Reframe

Think of each scene as a **pressure engine**:

- Dice create outcomes
- Timers track fallout
- Story Beats fuel escalation
- Boons reward risk

Your job is to keep that engine turning—not to decide where it ends.

Let the procedures do the work. Your attention belongs on the fiction.

2.2 Narrative Time: Rounds, Turns, Scenes, and Arcs

Fate's Edge measures time by narrative weight, not real seconds. Use these shared definitions to keep the table aligned.

Round Spotlight turns for all participants in a conflict (including Actions, Moves, and Reactions). A round ends when everyone present has had an opportunity to act.

Turn Spotlight for an individual player: one Action and one Move (see ?? in the SRD). Turns are the basic unit of player agency.

Significant Time Three or more rounds of structured conflict, or any period outside of combat where extended effort is required (e.g., a ritual, a chase, or several hours of travel). Use Significant Time to trigger long-term timers and downtime actions.

Scene A unit of narrative play covering a specific conflict, location, or situation. Equivalent to a D&D “encounter” (but avoid that comparison; a scene may be social, exploratory, or a montage). A scene ends when its central question is resolved.

Session One play session (typically 3–6 hours). A session may contain one major scene or several smaller scenes, and ends with Experience Point awards and timer updates.

Arc A complete story arc (3–6 sessions) that advances character goals, resolves a major front, and moves a campaign timer. At the end of an arc, the GM may call a Crown Spread or trigger a finale.

Significant Time in Play When the fiction calls for Significant Time (e.g., performing a ritual, climbing a cliff, or resting for an hour), the GM may:

- Advance a relevant timer by 1 segment.
- Allow the party to clear 1–2 Fatigue (if conditions allow).
- Call for a single roll to represent the entire extended effort (DV set by the scope of the task).

2.3 The Core Resolution Cycle

When a player rolls, they engage the world through risk, consequence, and discovery.

1. **Declare Action & Approach:** Player states intent, Attribute + Skill.
2. **Set Difficulty Value (DV):** Based on narrative stakes.
3. **Establish Position:** Dominant, Controlled, or Desperate.
4. **Roll Pool of d10s.**
5. **Count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).**
6. **Check Against DV** using Outcome Matrix.
7. **Apply Outcome:** Clean Success, Success with SB, Partial, or Miss.
8. **Spend SB** for complications and twists.

Clean Success. The action succeeds as intended. No Story Beats generated unless specified. Fiction advances cleanly.

Success with SB. Action succeeds but generates **Story Beats**. Success stands; cost is GM spending those SB, ideally applied to the inciting action or its immediate consequences.

Miss. Action fails and generates **Story Beats**. GM uses those SB to introduce complications, advance opposition, or shift the situation against the character.

Partial Success (GM Adjudication). A Partial indicates progress but not full resolution. How that manifests is determined by the GM, based on context, scale, and narrative stakes.

Partial results may:

- Improve the character's **Position** on a follow-up attempt
- Reduce the effective **DV** of the next roll
- Achieve the goal at reduced scale or limited duration
- Succeed fully but generate a **Story Beat** as cost or complication
- Reveal information or create a new opportunity instead of immediate resolution

Guiding Principle. Partial results represent *meaningful progress*. Convert progress into advantage, resolution, or complication, depending on what best serves the fiction.

Position Effects

Position Mechanical Effect

Dominant	May re-roll one failure (die < 6).
Controlled	Default state; no re-rolls.
Desperate	Must re-roll one success (die 6+), keeping second result.

Difficulty Ladder – Beginner Focus

DV When to Use

2	Routine: clear path, no pressure, almost guaranteed.
3	Default: mild challenge, some risk – use most often.
4	Hard: serious opposition, bad angle, or strong resistance.
5+	Extreme: major boss encounters or dramatic gambles.

2.4 Position & Difficulty Value

Position and DV are your primary dials for setting stakes and difficulty. They work together but answer different questions:

- **DV (Difficulty Value)** – How *hard* is the task? (2 = routine, 3 = pressured, 4 = hard, 5+ = extreme)
- **Position** – How *risky* is the attempt? (Dominant = safe, Controlled = balanced, Desperate = dangerous)

2.4.1 DV 3 as Default

Unless the fiction clearly indicates otherwise, start at **DV 3**. This gives a roughly 50–60% success rate for an average pool (4–6 dice) and leaves room for partials and misses. **Do not inflate DV to “challenge” players** – use Position, Timers, and SB spends instead.

2.4.2 When to Worsen Position

Worsen Position when the fiction puts the character at a disadvantage:

- Exposed or surrounded → Desperate
- Rushed or distracted → Controlled or Desperate
- Surprised or ambushed → Desperate

Never worsen Position just to make a roll “harder.” Position is about **narrative danger**, not arithmetic.

2.4.3 The Golden Rule

Golden Rule

When in doubt, make a ruling that keeps the story moving.

If you cannot remember a rule, set DV = 3, Position = Controlled, and ask the player to roll. Resolve the outcome with the Outcome Matrix. You can look up the rule after the session.

2.4.4 Example: Using SB to Escalate a Scene

Spending SB for Drama (The Bridge)

The party is negotiating a narrow mountain bridge. A rival mercenary captain demands a bribe.

- **Player rolls a Partial.** The GM gains 2 SB.
- **GM spends 1 SB:** “The captain leans on his sword – you notice his hand creeping toward the hilt. *Tensions rise.*” (Tick a new timer: **Tempers Flare** [4].)
- **GM spends the second SB:** “A loose stone falls from the bridge and splashes into the river far below. The captain’s archers nock arrows. **Position worsens to Desperate.**”

The player still succeeded in negotiating a lower toll, but the GM used SB to introduce escalating pressure and a visible timer. The scene now crackles with danger.

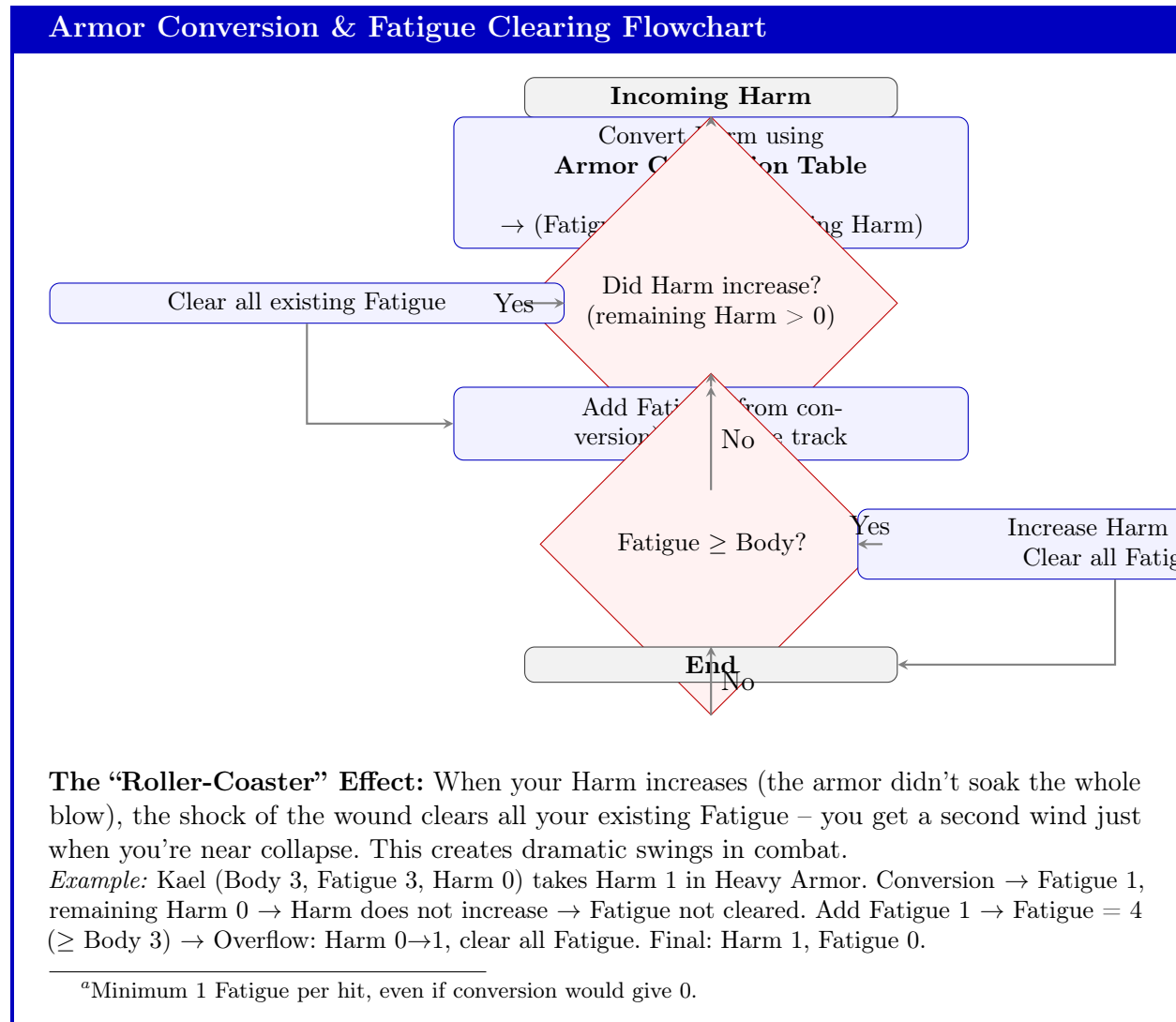
2.4.5 Outcome Matrix

Outcome Matrix

Roll Result	What Happens
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB = 0	Clean Success – intent achieved, no complication.
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB > 0	Success with SB – intent achieved; GM spends SB for complication.
0 < Successes < DV	Partial – progress with complication; player gains 1 Boon.
Successes = 0	Miss – no progress; GM escalates with SB; player gains 2 Boons.

Tip

Remind players that they can spend 1 **Boon** before a roll to increase Effect by one step.



2.4.6 Story Beats: The Engine of Drama

Every time a player rolls a 1, you gain Story Beats (SB). These are narrative tools, not punishments.

SB Spend Menu	
SB Cost	Simple Complications
1 SB	Minor: noise, distraction, small setback, lost gear, tick a 4/6 timer +1.
2 SB	Moderate: alarm raised, new threat enters, lose advantage, worsen Position.
3+ SB	Major: reinforcements, scene shifts, stakes escalate, break an asset.

2.4.7 Failing Forward with SB

- **On Clean Success:** Use SB to add texture. The hero wins, but something changes.
- **On Success with SB:** The hero gets what they wanted *and* you spend SB to add further cost or threat.
- **On Partial:** Use SB to make the complication sharper.
- **On Miss:** Spend SB to escalate the situation.

Lane Marker: One Complication per Roll

When in doubt, spend SB on *one* clear complication instead of many small ones. Name it plainly – “Guard Alerted”, “Floor Cracked”, “Oath Owed” – and move on.

Be **aggressive** with Story Beats, but never arbitrary:

- Do not hoard SB – unused pressure is wasted momentum.
- Do not invent contrived consequences that ignore the fiction.
- Spend SB to *sharpen what already matters*, not to add noise.

A single, well-chosen complication should change the situation, not just decorate it.

NPCs Don't Track Fatigue or Boons

Reminder: Non-player characters (NPCs) do *not* track Fatigue or Boons. These resources are reserved for player characters. If a talent, rite, or ability says it causes an NPC to lose Fatigue or Boons, **replace that effect with a narrative consequence** appropriate to the fiction.

Examples:

- Instead of “target loses 1 Boon”, say: “The target hesitates — they lose their next action.”
- Instead of “target marks 1 Fatigue”, say: “The target staggers, winded. Their next attack is at **Desperate Position**.”
- Instead of “target loses 1 Boon and marks 1 Fatigue”, say: “The target drops their weapon (disarmed) and stumbles back one range band.”

Why this matters: Fatigue and Boons are player-side currencies for tension and momentum. Giving them to NPCs adds bookkeeping without narrative payoff. Convert any such effect into a **positional shift**, a **lost action**, a **disarm**, or a **new complication** (tick a timer, add a Story Beat).

Golden Rule: When a player uses an ability that would drain an NPC's resource, ask yourself: “What interesting thing happens instead?” Then make it happen.

NPC Special Abilities: SB as Narrative Events

Instead of giving NPCs complex abilities with their own dice rolls, **spend Story Beats (SB) to trigger narrative events**. This keeps the spotlight on player rolls while making NPCs feel dangerous and dynamic.

Example SB Spends for NPC Special Abilities

SB Cost	Narrative Event (NPC Ability)
1 SB	<i>“The cultist’s eyes burn. A wave of heat washes over you — mark 1 Fatigue (fiction: near miss).”</i>
1 SB	<i>“The bandit captain roars a challenge. Your next attack against him is at Desperate Position.”</i>
2 SB	<i>“The spider skitters up the wall and drops onto your back — you are Grappled until you break free (Body+Athletics DV 3).”</i>
2 SB	<i>“The shaman completes a chant. A zone of darkness swallows the torches — all attacks inside are Desperate.”</i>
3 SB	<i>“The drake breathes a cone of frost. Everyone in Near range, test Body+Athletics (DV 3) or take Harm 2.”</i>
3 SB	<i>“The ghost passes through you. You forget one prepared spell or talent until the end of the scene (player’s choice).”</i>
4+ SB	<i>“The lich raises its hand. A bolt of green light strikes [player name] — test Spirit+Resolve (DV 5) or be Paralyzed for 1 exchange.”</i>
4+ SB	<i>“The siege weapon fires. Everyone in a Far zone must take cover (test Wits+Survival DV 4) or take Harm 3 (crushing).”</i>

How to use this table:

- When an NPC would use a special ability, look at its threat level (TL) and the fiction.
- **Spend SB** from your pool (earned from player 1s) to trigger the effect.
- **Narrate first** — describe what the NPC does, then call for a player roll or apply a consequence.
- **Don’t roll for the NPC.** The player always rolls to resist or avoid.

Design note: This keeps NPCs lightweight (no separate ability rolls) and makes SB a direct tool for escalating danger. The players see you spend SB — they know something bad is happening, and the tension rises.

2.5 Over-Stack Rule

The Over-Stack rule prevents excessive accumulation of advantages from trivial sources while rewarding meaningful preparation. It ensures that a scene starts with tension, not a stacked deck that trivializes every obstacle.

2.5.1 When Does Over-Stack Trigger?

Over-Stack is checked **once, at scene framing** — the moment the GM says “Scene begins.” Advantages gained **during** the scene (e.g., a well-placed **Setup** action, an Asset activated mid-scene,

a clever improvised maneuver) never trigger Over-Stack.

If the party enters a scene with **3 or more structural advantages** (see below), the GM may apply Over-Stack **once** for that scene.

2.5.2 What Counts as a Structural Advantage?

Structural advantages are benefits that come from **pre-scene preparation** and are still active at the moment the scene starts. These include:

- **Two or more active scene-long buff spells or rites** on the party (e.g., [FORTIFY], [VEIL]).
- **An unused Follower Initiative** carried over from a previous scene (i.e., the follower is present but hasn't acted yet).
- **An Asset activation** that applies a mechanical bonus at scene start (e.g., "My spy network delayed the patrol" — the patrol is now at a disadvantage).
- **The opponent is Surprised, Trapped, or otherwise disadvantaged** by prior setup (e.g., you scouted the ambush point and prepared an escape route).
- **A ritual completed before the scene** that directly affects the scene's conditions (e.g., a consecrated circle, a warding).

Do NOT count as structural advantages:

- A single buff or spell (one is fine).
- Advantages created **during** the scene (e.g., knocking an enemy prone, taking cover).
- Flavor or roleplay preparations (e.g., "I sharpened my sword" — no mechanical benefit).
- Followers who are actively participating on-screen (they are characters, not structural advantages).

2.5.3 What Happens When Over-Stack Triggers?

The GM chooses **one** of the following effects:

- **Increase Difficulty:** Start one named obstacle or challenge at **+1 DV** (e.g., the already well-guarded door now has DV 4 instead of 3).
- **Bank a Story Beat:** The GM gains **+1 SB** to spend during the scene (representing narrative pushback).

This penalty applies only once, regardless of how many advantages beyond the third the party has.

2.5.4 Examples

- **Valid Over-Stack:** The party has cast [FORTIFY] on everyone, activated a Safehouse Asset ("guards are bribed"), and a Follower Initiative left unused from a previous scene. That's 3

structural advantages. The GM decides the gatekeeper's suspicion is higher (+1 DV to the Persuasion roll).

- **No Over-Stack:** The party enters a room quietly, then uses a **Setup** action to knock over a brazier, creating a distraction. The distraction was created **during** the scene — no Over-Stack applies.
- **Optional Choice:** The GM may choose **not** to apply Over-Stack if the scene is already difficult or if the players' preparation is particularly creative. The rule is a dial, not a mandate.

2.5.5 Design Intent

Over-Stack exists to:

- **Discourage pre-scene buff stacking** without eliminating preparation entirely.
- **Reward improvisation** — advantages created during the scene are always free.
- **Keep scenes tense** — a single small penalty prevents the party from trivializing every obstacle before dice are rolled.

It works alongside the game's other resource pressures (upkeep, downtime, Obligation) to make preparation a meaningful choice, not an automatic win button.

2.6 Learning Through Examples

This section walks the same situation through multiple passes, adding one rule at a time. Use it as a mental template when you improvise.

Example 1: Core Loop Only

Example 1 – No SB, No Boons

Lyra tries to sneak past a guardian in a narrow hallway. (Agility + Stealth = 5d10).

GM: normal risk, DV 3, Controlled Position.

Roll: 3, 5, 6, 7, 9 → 3 successes (6,7,9).

DV 3 with 3 successes = **Success**.

GM: "You slip past the guardian quietly. You're in position behind it if you want to act."

Example 2: Add Story Beats Only

Example 2 – Adding Story Beats

Same situation. Lyra rolls 5d10: 1, 4, 6, 6, 8.

Successes: 3 (6,6,8). One 1 → 1 SB for GM.

DV 3 with 3 successes = **Success** with 1 SB.

GM spend (1 SB = Minor): “You get past the guardian, but your cloak snags and tears. The sound echoes – the next room has a -1 Position penalty for stealth checks.”

Example 3: Add Boons Only

Example 3 – Adding Boons

Later, Lyra scales a loose stone wall (Athletics + Agility = 4d10). DV 3.

Roll: 2,3,4,5 → 0 successes = **Miss**.

GM awards **2 Boons**. “You slip and land hard, taking 1 Harm. Mark 2 Boons – you can use them later to turn the tide.”

Next attempt, Lyra spends 1 Boon to re-roll a die, turning failure into success.

Example 4: Putting It Together

Example 4 – SB + Boons + Position

The party flees as the tower collapses. A crumbling staircase blocks the exit.

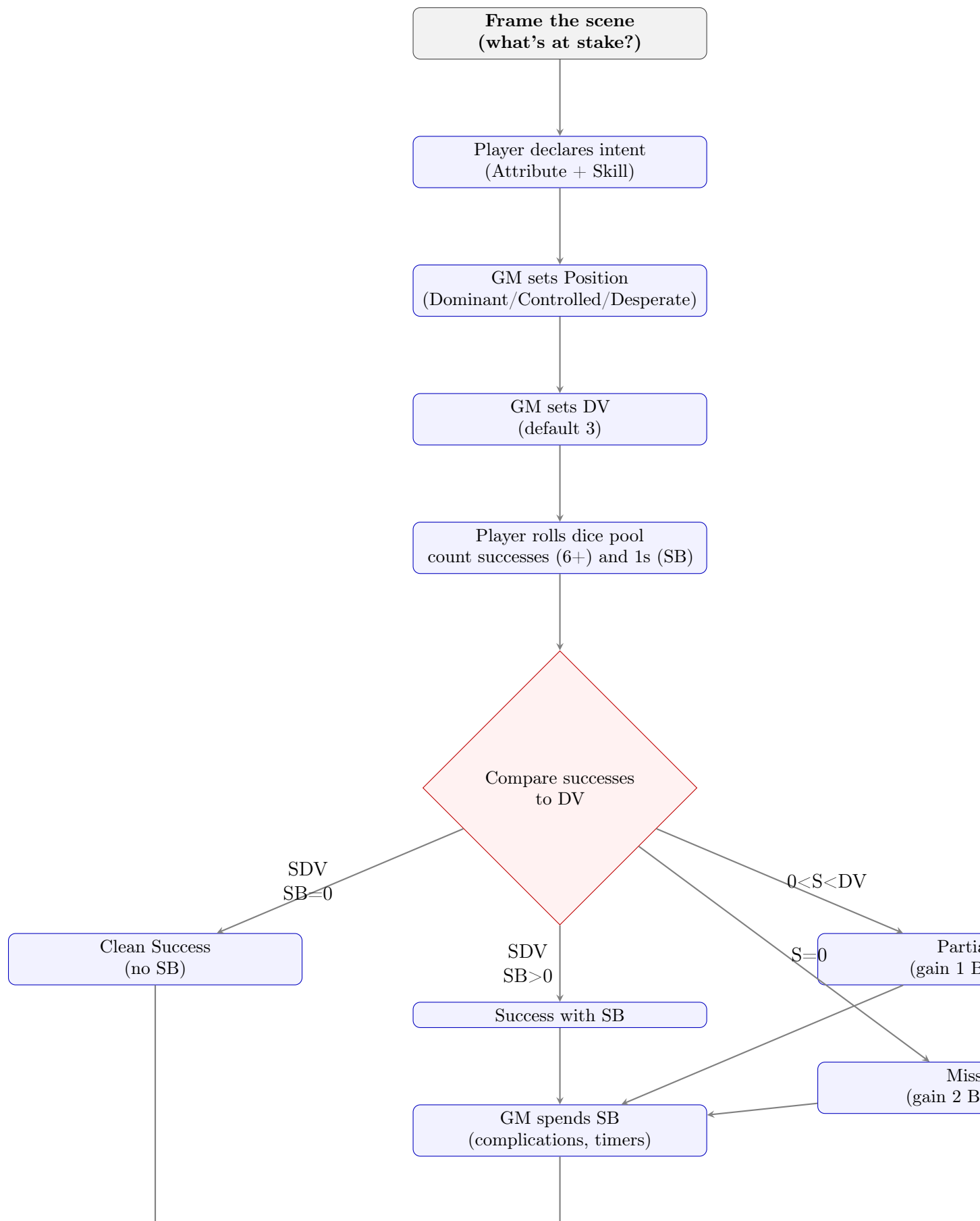
GM: “Desperate. DV 4 to get everyone across safely.”

Lyra leads, rolling 6d10 (Agility + Athletics + help): 1,2,6,7,7,9.

4 successes vs DV 4 = Success. 1 rolled 1 = 1 SB to GM. Desperate Position.

GM: “You all make it across, but the last step collapses behind you. I spend 1 SB: your exit path is gone. You’ll need a new way out.”

Lesson: Even on a success, SB let you bend the fiction toward drama without erasing the player’s win.



Chapter 3

Managing Resources

Philosophy of Resources

Resources are not there to hoard – they are tools to create drama.

- **Spend Boons freely.** Hoarding them for XP conversion starves the table of tension and robs players of their safety net.
- **Let Fatigue build.** Fatigue is not punishment; it is the rising tide that forces hard choices and heroic comebacks.
- **Obligation is plot, not punishment.** When a Patron calls in a debt, a story hook arrives. Embrace it.

The most memorable sessions come from characters spending their last Boon on a desperate re-roll, staggering forward under three Fatigue, or accepting a Patron's demand that changes everything.

In **Fate's Edge**, resources are narrative levers, not inventory lists. From the last sip of water in sun-scorched wastes to the fragile loyalty of a Ykrul war-band, every resource tells a story, and every story demands its price. As GM, you are the keeper of these threads—the weaver of scarcity and abundance. This chapter shows how to manage the systems that fuel mortal ambitions and epic campaigns.

3.1 Supply Timer : The Pulse of Survival

The **Supply Timer** tracks the party's access to essentials: food, water, gear, and logistical support. It is a shared party resource—a narrative lever that tightens tension when characters are isolated, pursued, or cut off from civilization.

Segments Filled	Narrative Effects
0 (Full)	Well-equipped and prepared; no penalty.
1 (Low)	Minor complications: bland rations, damaged arrows, thinning waterskins.
2 (Dangerous)	Each character gains Fatigue 1 as scarcity takes its toll.
3 (Empty)	Severe penalties: starvation, dehydration, equipment failure imminent.

Table 3.1: Supply Timer conditions and their narrative effects

3.1.1 Supply Timer States

3.1.2 When to Advance the Supply Timer

The Supply Timer advances when the world turns against the party's preparations:

- Extended travel through hostile lands without proper provisioning (see **Travel Framework**, Chapter 9 of the Player's Guide or SRD Section 41).
- The GM spends **2+ Story Beats** on logistics failures or environmental hardships.
- The party chooses to travel light for speed or stealth.
- Failed **Survival** or **Craft** rolls related to hunting, foraging, or repair.

3.1.3 Clearing Supply Segments

The timer recedes when the party finds respite:

- Reaching civilization resets the timer to *Full*.
- A group **Survival** check (Wits + Survival, DV 2) in favorable conditions clears 1 segment.
- Downtime spent in relative safety removes 1 segment.
- Successful provisioning (a good hunt, a discovered cache) can reduce segments.

Example. A week-long sea passage with uncertain winds. A failed **Navigation** roll causes the GM to spend 2 SB – filling two segments as supplies spoil. The party is now at *Low Supply*. A second failed roll fills another segment – *Dangerously Low*. Fatigue sets in. The sea gnaws at their endurance.

3.2 Fatigue: The Weight of the World

Fatigue represents the cumulative toll of journeying through a world that rarely offers comfort: exhaustion that seeps into bones, hunger that hollows cheeks, strain that clouds judgment.

The Roller-Coaster Effect

Taking Harm clears Fatigue temporarily – the shock of a wound can jolt a character back into action. This creates a natural "roller coaster" of tension:

Example: Kael is at Fatigue 3 (Desperate, –2 dice). A goblin stabs him for Harm 1. The Harm conversion procedure: first convert Harm → Fatigue (none, light armor), then apply remaining Harm – which clears all Fatigue. Kael's Fatigue drops to 0, but his Harm increases to 1. He is wounded but suddenly clear-headed, ready to fight back.

Use this effect to create dramatic swings: a character near collapse who takes a wound and finds a second wind. It keeps combat unpredictable and rewards players who embrace risk.

3.2.1 Fatigue Effects

Each point of Fatigue worsens the character's **Position** by one step (Dominant → Controlled → Desperate). If already Desperate, each additional Fatigue instead imposes a **–1 die penalty** on all rolls. Penalties from Fatigue and Harm **stack**.

Fatigue Level	Effect
1	Position worsens one step (Dominant → Controlled → Desperate)
2	If already Desperate, –1 die; otherwise Position worsens
3	–2 dice (if already Desperate from Fatigue)
4+	Collapse, KO, or spiritual break (incapacitated)

Table 3.2: Fatigue progression and associated mechanical effects

3.2.2 Clearing Fatigue

Recovery requires genuine respite:

- A **short rest** (quiet watch, food/water) removes **2 Fatigue**.
- A **full night's rest** in safety removes **all Fatigue**.
- Fatigue cannot be removed while the party is at *Dangerous* or *Empty Supply*.
- Medical attention (**Presence** + **Medicine**, DV 2) during downtime can remove an additional 1 Fatigue.

Narrative note: Fatigue is not only physical – it can reflect mental strain, grief, or spiritual exhaustion. A failed ritual might leave a caster at Fatigue 2 from metaphysical backlash alone.

3.2.3 Fatigue → Harm Conversion

Each character has a Fatigue track equal to their **Body** attribute. When the track fills:

1. Increase **Harm** by one level (0→Harm 1, Harm 1→Harm 2, Harm 2→Harm 3).
2. Clear all Fatigue.

This conversion can occur multiple times in a scene. (See the *Player's Guide* for full Harm rules.)

3.3 Boons: The Currency of Resilience

Boons are narrative tokens earned by embracing risk. They reward *failure with opportunity* – the silver lining in clouds of defeat.

Why You Should Spend Boons – The Math of Fun

Hoarding Boons for XP conversion leads to less engagement and lower fun scores.

Every Boon you hold is a dramatic moment waiting to happen:

- Re-rolling a critical failure turns despair into triumph.
- Improving Position before a risky roll turns a Desperate gamble into a Controlled chance.
- Activating an Asset brings your character's network into the story.

XP from Boons is a trickle (max 2 per session). The real reward is *agency*. The player who spends Boons shapes the story; the player who hoards them watches from the sidelines.

As GM, remind players: "You have 3 Boons. What will you spend them on?" When a player sits on 5 Boons, gently suggest they use one before the scene ends. A spent Boon is a moment of player power. An unspent Boon is wasted potential.

3.3.1 Earning Boons (GM Reminders)

- On a **Partial** (1 Boon) or **Miss** (2 Boons) with meaningful consequences.
- Through clever or risky roleplay that drives the story.
- Via bond-driven actions with intricate descriptions.
- At GM discretion for exceptional collaborative play.

Limit: At most **2 Boons** from failures per character per scene. Repetition of the same approach with the same stakes does not award additional Boons.

3.3.2 Boon Economy (Quick Reference)

- **Holding cap:** Maximum 5 Boons.
- **Carryover:** At the end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of 2 (excess lost).
- **Conversion:** Once per session during downtime, convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (max 2 XP per session via conversion).

3.3.3 Spending Boons (Player Options)

Players may spend 1 Boon to:

- Re-roll a single die (after seeing the pool).
- Activate an on-screen Asset.
- Improve Position by one step before a roll.
- Power certain Rites or abilities as described in their text.

Substituting Fatigue for Boons (Optional) If a player has no Boons remaining, they may substitute **1 Fatigue** for 1 Boon *once per scene*. This represents pushing through exhaustion for a last chance. The GM may veto if the fiction does not support it.

3.3.4 Anti-Fishing Measures (GM Guidance)

- **Once/Scene Cap:** At most 2 Boons from failures per character per scene.
- **Repetition Rule:** Same approach + same stakes in the same scene cannot award another Boon.
- **Position Gate:** *Dominant* tests with trivial fallout do not award Boons.

Design note: Boons reward narrative risk, not repeated failure.

3.4 Followers and Assets: Power Beyond the Self

Players can invest XP in **Followers** (on-screen allies) and **Assets** (off-screen resources). These are story agents with their own motivations and risks. The following sections present simplified, low-bookkeeping systems that avoid numeric timers while preserving meaningful consequences.

3.4.1 Followers: On-Screen Allies

Followers are bought with XP and tracked by a **Cap** (maximum assist bonus). Cost = Cap² XP; downtime 1–3 days to recruit.

Follower States Instead of numeric timers, track a follower's **Loyalty** and **Fitness** as one of three states each.

Change states when the fiction demands it (e.g., after a failed mission, a moral compromise, or taking damage). No rolls required.

Assisting in Scenes

State	Mechanical Effect
<i>Loyalty</i>	
Faithful	Normal assist, independent actions available
Strained	Assist at -1 die; may refuse risky orders
Broken	Follower leaves or becomes hostile
<i>Fitness</i>	
Ready	Full function
Hurt	Assist at -1 die; no independent actions
Down	Incapacitated; requires rescue or medical care

Table 3.3: Follower Loyalty and Fitness states

- Assist dice equal $\min(\text{Cap}, \text{helper's relevant Skill})$.
- Total assist from all sources capped at **+3 dice** (the *Exceptional Coordination* talent allows +4 from one follower).
- Only one follower may assist a given action.

Follower Independent Actions Once per scene, **one** follower may take a small independent action (party-wide limit). Examples:

- **Scout & Signal** – Change an ally's next action to *Dominant*.
- **Distract & Draw** – Reduce a threat/hunt/escape timer by 1 tick.
- **Fetch & Carry** – Move a small object through danger.

Cost: Mark **Exposure** +1 or worsen **Fitness** one step (Ready → Hurt → Down) on that follower.

Followers as Successors A Follower (Cap 3+) can become a **successor** if the player's main character retires, dies, or ascends. This is the core of the Legacy Engine (see ?? in the full GM Guide).

Follower Upkeep and Risk

- Each downtime, pay XP equal to Cap **or** spend a scene tending the relationship.
- Neglect → Loyalty worsens one step (Faithful → Strained → Broken).
- If the GM spends **2+ SB** on an action you take with assistance, they may worsen Loyalty or Fitness on the follower instead of other consequences.
- **Off-Screen Capability:** Once per downtime, a Cap 3+ follower can solve a significant problem but generates **1 SB** for the party (the GM describes the resulting complication).

3.4.2 Assets: Off-Screen Influence

Assets are titles, safehouses, spy rings, charters. They do not act in scenes directly but change the fiction between sessions.

Tier	Cost and Examples
Minor	4 XP (1 day) – safehouse, small shop, local contact
Standard	8 XP (1 week) – noble title, spy ring, workshop
Major	12 XP (1 month) – city license, fortress lease, regional network

Table 3.4: Asset tiers, acquisition cost, and representative examples

Asset Status Assets have a single unified **Status** that describes their overall health and usability.

Status	Effect
Flourishing	+1 die on rolls involving the asset, +1 Yield
Stable	No modifier
Strained	–1 die on asset-related rolls, no Yield
Collapsed	Non-functional; requires quest or major downtime to restore

Table 3.5: Asset Status levels and their effects

The Status worsens when the asset is neglected, attacked, or suffers a public failure. It improves through dedicated downtime actions or successful missions that benefit the asset.

Using Assets

- **Off-Screen Effect:** Use once per session for free (the quiet work between adventures).
- **On-Screen Activation:** Spend 1 Boon to use the asset dramatically in a scene.
- **Downtime Activation:** Pay 2 XP or 1 Boon to activate an asset at campaign start or during downtime.
- The asset must have plausible scope for the intended effect.

Asset Upkeep Each downtime:

- **Efficient (higher XP, less time):** Cost = $\max(1, \frac{\text{Acquisition XP}}{3})$. Minimal effort.
- **Intensive (lower XP, more time):** Cost = 1 XP. Requires a dedicated downtime action with significant personal involvement.
- Failure to pay → Status worsens one step (Flourishing → Stable → Strained → Collapsed).

3.5 Terrestrial Patrons: Favors and Influence

Not every patron is a cosmic entity. Powerful mortals—nobles, crime lords, generals, merchant princes, and the old families of the Vilikari—can act as **terrestrial patrons**. They offer tangible aid (escorts, legal protection, supplies, even ongoing Assets) in exchange for favors and loyalty.

3.5.1 How Terrestrial Patrons Work

When a character accepts a favor from a terrestrial patron, start an **Influence Timer** with the patron's name (e.g., "Prefect Marcellus's Influence [4]"). Mark one segment each time the character accepts a significant favor. When the timer fills, the patron calls in the debt – a mission, a political favor, or a direct demand.

The party also tracks a separate **Obligation** tally for each terrestrial patron, exactly as they would for a supernatural Patron (see 5.4). Each accepted favor adds +1 Obligation. Exceeding Obligation Capacity (Spirit + Presence) causes Fatigue exactly as with cosmic Patrons.

Refusing to honor the debt turns the patron into an enemy. The GM may advance associated *Crisis* timers or introduce complications.

Use Influence Timers Aggressively

Influence timers are story fuel. Call them in at the worst possible moment:

- **Early (1–2 segments):** A messenger arrives with a "reminder." Small favor.
- **Mid (3–4 segments):** A significant service is demanded.
- **Full (5–6 segments):** The patron calls in the debt at a critical moment – refusal means enmity.

Influence that is never called is wasted potential.

3.5.2 Clearing Terrestrial Obligation

Obligation to a terrestrial patron is cleared by performing **tasks** for the patron. The GM sets the scope:

- **Minor task** (deliver a message, pay a bribe): clears 1 Obligation.
- **Significant task** (escort a caravan, break a siege): clears 2 Obligation.
- **Major task** (assassinate a rival, broker a treaty): clears 3+ Obligation.

Each task becomes a story hook.

3.5.3 Asset Slots and Patron Tier

A terrestrial patron's power determines how many Assets they can support and at what cost. Each patron has a **Tier** (Minor, Major, or Paramount) that sets their Asset capacity.

Patron Tier	Reach	Asset Slots	Max Asset Size
Minor	Local (one city or canton)	2 slots	Standard Asset (8 XP)
Major	Regional (multiple provinces)	4 slots	Major Asset (12 XP)
Paramount	International (across the Amaranthine)	6 slots	Major Asset (12 XP)

Table 3.6: Terrestrial Patron Tiers and Capacity

Asset Slot Costs When a terrestrial patron grants an Asset in exchange for Obligation (rather than XP), the cost in Obligation segments is:

Asset Type	Minor Patron	Major/Paramount Patron
Minor Asset (4 XP value)	2 Obligation	2 Obligation
Standard Asset (8 XP value)	4 Obligation	3 Obligation
Major Asset (12 XP value)	—	4 Obligation
Follower (Cap 2)	2 Obligation	2 Obligation
Follower (Cap 3)	4 Obligation	3 Obligation

Table 3.7: Asset Costs by Patron Tier

A Minor Patron cannot grant Major Assets — their reach is too short. A Paramount Patron is rare; examples include the Matron of Silkstrand, the Federate King of the Vilikari, or the High King Beneath the Peaks.

3.5.4 Example Terrestrial Patrons

Sample Terrestrial Patrons

Patron	Tier / Assets / Debt Trigger
Prefect Marcellus (Ecktorian commander)	Major (4 slots). Safe passage, food, guards. Debt: dangerous mission behind enemy lines.
Censor Cassia (judicial authority)	Minor (2 slots). Legal immunity, archive access. Debt: expose a political rival.
Khatun Sarnai (Ykrul chieftain)	Major (4 slots). Remounts, safe camp, guides. Debt: blood-price or raid on a rival clan.
Mistress Ilvar (Silkstrand crime lord)	Minor (2 slots). Black Bazaar access, cutpurses. Debt: public assassination.
House Contarini (Vilikari Archivolt)	Major (4 slots). Forged charters, legal immunity. Debt: retrieve a lost seal from a rival.
The Ragman (Silkstrand underworld)	Paramount (6 slots). Smuggling routes, night-boats, stolen goods. Debt: a favor that cannot be named.

3.5.5 Running Terrestrial Patrons

- Track each patron's Influence Timer and the party's Obligation visibly.
- When a player asks for a favor, state the cost: "That's worth one segment and +1 Obligation. Are you willing?"
- When an Influence Timer fills, give a hook that fits the patron's personality.
- If the party refuses, tick a *Crisis* timer or introduce a complication.
- Patrons compete. If the party owes Obligation to two rival patrons, those patrons will eventually demand conflicting loyalties.

3.6 Player Trusts: Shared Legacy

A **Trust** is a shared pool of XP that players contribute to, used to acquire and maintain **party-owned Assets and Followers**. Trusts represent a collective enterprise—a mercenary company, a trading guild, a spy network, a religious order.

3.6.1 Forming a Trust

Any player may contribute XP to the Trust pool. Contributions are voluntary and cannot be withdrawn. The Trust has no individual owner; spending from the pool requires majority agreement.

3.6.2 Tiered Buy-In for Trust Slots

A Trust is not a single Asset — it is a **container** that can hold multiple Assets and Followers. The Trust’s capacity is determined by its **Tier**, which players purchase collectively.

Trust Tier	Cost (Total XP)	Asset Slots	Max Asset Size
Tier I (Local)	8 XP	2 slots	Standard Asset (8 XP)
Tier II (Regional)	16 XP	4 slots	Major Asset (12 XP)
Tier III (International)	32 XP	6 slots	Major Asset (12 XP)

Table 3.8: Trust Tiers and Capacity

Upgrading a Trust Players may upgrade a Trust to the next Tier by paying the **difference** in XP (e.g., from Tier I to Tier II costs an additional 8 XP, contributed collectively). Upgrading requires a downtime scene where the Trust formalizes its new charter, expands its operations, or absorbs a rival organization.

What a Trust Can Buy Once the Trust has capacity, players may spend XP from the Trust pool to acquire Assets and Followers that belong to the Trust as a whole.

Cost	Benefit
4 XP	Minor Asset (shared safehouse, workshop, contact network)
8 XP	Standard Asset (guild charter, spy ring, fortress lease)
9 XP	Follower (Cap 3, loyal to the Trust, not any single PC)

Table 3.9: Trust Expenditures

Each Asset or Follower consumes one Asset Slot. A Trust cannot exceed its slot capacity.

3.6.3 Upkeep and Delegation

Each downtime, the Trust must pay upkeep for its Assets and Followers using the standard rules (1 XP or a scene per asset/follower).

Alternatively, the Trust may **delegate upkeep** to a **Cap 5 Follower**:

- The Cap 5 follower can manage up to **4 Asset Slots** (any combination of Assets and Followers).
- The follower’s own upkeep covers the delegated Assets — no separate XP cost.
- **Risk:** If the follower becomes *Strained* or *Broken* (Loyalty), all delegated Assets worsen one step or are lost until the follower is restored.

3.6.4 Trust Assets in Play

Assets and Followers acquired through a Trust belong to the **party as a whole**. Any member may activate them by spending their own Boons, following the normal Asset rules (see ??).

Trusts and Terrestrial Patrons

A Trust is a natural **counterpart** to a terrestrial patron relationship. A party that owes Obligation to House Contarini might form a Trust to manage the safehouses and informants the House provides. Conversely, a party that builds a Trust independently may eventually become a terrestrial patron themselves — a Minor patron with 2 Asset slots, offering favors to lesser allies.

The GM may allow a Trust to **absorb** a terrestrial patron relationship: if the party retires their individual Obligation to a patron by paying XP from the Trust pool, the patron becomes a Trust Asset rather than a personal debt. The patron's Influence Timer continues, but the obligation is now collective.

3.6.5 Dissolving a Trust

If the party disbands, remaining XP in the pool is lost. Assets may be transferred to individual characters who pay the XP cost (or accept Obligation to a Terrestrial Patron to cover the difference). Followers loyal to the Trust may scatter, become independent NPCs, or be absorbed by a patron.

3.6.6 Trust Quick Reference

Trusts Summary

Forming:

- Players contribute XP collectively.
- Purchase Trust Tier (8/16/32 XP) for slot capacity.

Capacity by Tier:

- Tier I (8 XP): 2 slots, max Standard Asset
- Tier II (16 XP): 4 slots, max Major Asset
- Tier III (32 XP): 6 slots, max Major Asset

Upgrading:

- Pay difference to next Tier (requires downtime scene).

Spending:

- Use Trust XP to buy Assets and Followers (4/8/9 XP).
- Each consumes one slot.

Upkeep:

- Pay 1 XP or 1 scene per asset/follower per downtime.

- Or delegate to a Cap 5 follower (manages 4 slots).

Activation:

- Any Trust member spends their own Boons to activate.

3.6.7 Mandate Timer (0–6)

Tracks the party's public legitimacy.

- **High Mandate:** Allies seek them out, resources flow, doors open.
- **Low Mandate:** Suspicion, bureaucratic obstacles, support withers.

Advance the timer when the party gains renown (clean victories, public accolades) or loses face (scandals, broken oaths).

3.6.8 Crisis Timer (0–6)

Tracks the opposition's growing strength.

- **Rising Crisis:** Complications escalate, enemies grow bolder.
- **Managed Crisis:** Breathing room, opportunities to strike back.

Advance the timer when the party fails key objectives, ignores looming threats, or the GM spends SB on faction escalation.

Example. If the party brokers a peace treaty, advance *Mandate* by 1. If they assassinate a rival leader but leave evidence, advance *Crisis* by 1. When either timer reaches 6, trigger a major faction response (a summons, an assassination attempt, a public trial).

3.7 Combat Resource Management

In combat, resource management takes on desperate urgency.

3.7.1 Supply in Combat

- **Intense Combat:** GM may spend 1 SB to worsen Supply by one step (e.g., Stable → Strained).
- **Prolonged Engagement:** Each hour of sustained combat worsens Supply one step.
- **Ammunition Depletion:** Ranged weapons may run low, requiring scavenging actions (e.g., **Craft** roll to recover arrows).

3.7.2 Fatigue in Combat

- Characters apply Fatigue penalties as described in 3.2.
- Reaching Fatigue level 4+ during combat causes immediate collapse (incapacitated).
- Fatigue cannot be cleared during active combat.

3.7.3 Follower Combat Integration

- Followers assist using their Cap (see 3.4.1).
- Spending **2+ SB** in combat can worsen a follower's Loyalty or Fitness.
- Followers can take combat-relevant independent actions (cost: worsen Fitness one step).
- After a follower acts twice in a high-risk combat scene, worsen their Exposure or Fitness.

3.8 Narrative First: The Fiction Is the Ledger

In Fate's Edge, arrows, rations, and waterskins are tracked only in the fiction that surrounds them. Mechanics engage only when those resources become scarce enough to matter. The focus remains always on **narrative tension** – the gnawing hunger, the fading light, the last arrow – not sterile bookkeeping.

Abstracting Coin and Time. Routine expenses and petty bribes are handled narratively ("You have enough coin from past jobs to cover a week's stay"). For major expenses (bribing a corrupt official, outfitting an expedition, buying a rare magical component), players may spend **XP** in place of coin (1 XP = a substantial sum). Use the "XP as currency" rule sparingly; it should feel like a meaningful sacrifice, not a tax.

GM Reminder. When a player asks "Do I have enough arrows?" the answer is almost always "yes" until it becomes dramatically interesting to say "no." Similarly, track Supply only when the party is isolated, pursued, or in a hostile environment. Let the world breathe with its own needs and abundances. And when the dice say the world pushes back against mortal plans – **listen to what they tell you about the price of ambition.**

3.9 Echo Characters: Managing Multi-Character Switching

Players may choose to temporarily step away from their current character and play another, while their first character continues to act offscreen. This is called an **Echo Character**. The optional rules in the Player's Guide give the player-facing procedure; this section provides the GM's mechanical framework for tracking offscreen characters, applying consequences, and maintaining narrative continuity.

3.9.1 Core Principles

- Players **choose** when their character steps offscreen.
- Offscreen characters remain active in the fiction and can still affect the world.
- Absence creates **opportunity and risk**, not punishment.
- The world reacts to characters even when unseen.

3.9.2 The Downtime Log

Each session a character is offscreen, the player completes a simple **Downtime Log**. The GM records the outcomes and may introduce one consequence per log.

Log Structure

The player declares:

1. **Resource Action:** How the character maintains connections or standing (e.g., sends a letter, pays a retainer, visits a contact offscreen).
2. **Project Action:** One goal or project advanced (e.g., researches a ritual, trains a follower, builds a contacts list).
3. **Event Response:** How the character reacts to unseen events or threats (e.g., avoids a patrol, hides from a rival, investigates a rumor).

Tier-Based Project Limits

Players may advance up to a certain number of projects per downtime based on their character's Tier:

- Tier I–II: 1 Project
- Tier III–IV: 2 Projects
- Tier V: 3 Projects

GM Response

For each Downtime Log, the GM:

- Notes the fictional outcome of each declaration.
- May assign **one meaningful Consequence** (complication, shift, or new opportunity) that will affect the character when they return.

Consequences should be specific and story-driven, not punitive. Examples:

- *“Your contact has moved; you’ll need to find them again.”*

- “The rival you avoided now knows your general location.”
- “Your project succeeds, but you lost a valuable resource in the process.”

3.9.3 Crisis Timer for Offscreen Characters

Each offscreen character tracks a private **Crisis Timer [6]**. This timer represents mounting pressure, danger, or narrative trouble that accumulates while the character is away.

When to Tick the Crisis Timer

Tick the Crisis Timer +1 when:

- The player’s Downtime Log includes a **failed** or **partial** outcome (GM discretion).
- The GM spends **2+ Story Beats** on offscreen events related to that character.
- The character ignores an obvious threat or obligation (e.g., refuses a Patron’s demand while offscreen).
- The character is *In Peril* (status declared by player at start of absence).

When the Crisis Timer Fills

At 6 segments, the character faces a **major offscreen crisis**. The GM describes what happens, and the player must address it upon return. Examples:

- A rival captures the character’s ally or asset.
- The character is wounded or cursed (apply Harm 1 or a Condition).
- The character loses a valuable resource (String, Asset tag, or follower Loyalty).
- A Patron calls in a debt in an especially inconvenient way.

After the crisis, reset the Crisis Timer to 0. The crisis should create a story hook, not remove the character from play.

Reducing the Crisis Timer

Players may reduce the Crisis Timer by:

- Spending **1 Boon** (on their active character) to send aid or a message.
- Accepting a **Devil’s Bargain** that introduces a complication on their active character.
- Having another player’s active character interact with the offscreen character’s situation (e.g., “I send a scout to check on them”).

The GM may also reduce the timer by 1 if the player’s Downtime Log shows proactive risk management.

3.9.4 Return Mechanics

When a player brings an Echo Character back to active play:

1. The returning character gains **2 Boons** for narrative re-entry (a burst of momentum).
2. The player rolls **Wits + Spirit** (DV 3) to reestablish presence. On a success, they reintegrate smoothly. On a failure, the GM applies one additional consequence (e.g., they arrive off-balance, or a complication follows them).
3. The GM reveals any Consequences accumulated during absence, and the player must address unresolved plot threads.

3.9.5 Optional: Buddy System

If multiple players have offscreen characters, they may nominate a **Buddy** (another player with an active character) to help track Downtime Logs and Crisis Timers. The Buddy gains **+1 additional Boon** for the session for this support role (this Boon does not count toward the session cap).

3.9.6 Player Guidelines (for GM to communicate)

Share these with players who wish to use the system:

- Declare offscreen goals with clear fictional intent.
- Treat absence as character growth, not disappearance.
- Expect absence to create tension, opportunity, and drama.
- Keep your Downtime Log brief (one sentence per action).

3.9.7 Full Cross-Reference

For player-facing rules on Echo Characters (how to declare absence, what a Downtime Log is, and the benefits of returning), see the Player's Guide, Chapter ???. The player version omits Crisis Timers and GM consequence mechanics; those are your tools as GM.

Chapter 4

Running a Currency-Free Game

4.1 Why Fate’s Edge Has No “Money”

In many role-playing games gold, silver, or credits are the primary levers for power: better gear, bribes, training time, and so on. Fate’s Edge flips that model. All character growth, acquisition of assets, and even the purchase of services are measured in **experience points (XP)**. The only exception is a short-term “scrip” that can be used for flavor in mercantile-heavy campaigns, and even that is modeled as a timer rather than a true currency pool.

4.1.1 Design Goals

- Keep the focus on narrative risk and reward, not on bookkeeping.
- Make every XP expenditure a meaningful story decision.
- Allow the GM to inject scarcity or abundance through timers and narrative pressure, not through price lists.

4.2 XP as the Universal Resource

Every time a character gains XP they are earning a narrative token that can be spent in three broad ways:

1. **Character Advancement** – increase attributes, learn new rites, or buy talents (see the Player’s Guide).
2. **Asset Acquisition** – purchase Followers, Assets, or other long-term benefits (cost = XP, see Chapter 3.4).
3. **Immediate Effect** – spend XP in place of coin for a single, dramatic purchase (e.g., bribing an official, buying a rare component, hiring a guide). The GM decides the XP cost based on the fictional weight of the item or service.

Because XP is earned through play (Boons, Milestones, Acts of Service, etc.), spending it always feels like a trade-off: “Do I improve my sword arm now, or do I secure a safehouse for the next arc?”

4.2.1 GM Guidance on XP Pricing

When a player asks, “Can I buy X with XP?”, use the following rubric:

- **Trivial (flavor, no mechanical benefit)** – 0 XP (just narrate it).
- **Minor (small advantage, one-time use)** – 1–2 XP (e.g., a night’s lodging, a simple tool, a rumor).
- **Moderate (noticeable edge, reusable)** – 3–5 XP (e.g., a decent weapon, a safehouse for a week, a minor title).
- **Major (significant power, long-term impact)** – 6–10 XP (e.g., a fortress lease, a noble title, a spy ring).
- **Epic (campaign-shaping)** – 11+ XP (e.g., a regional trade monopoly, a city-wide charter, a legendary artifact).

Adjust these numbers to match the power level of your campaign; the key is that the cost should feel like a meaningful sacrifice, not a routine expense.

4.3 Temporary “Scrip” for Mercantile Campaigns

Some groups enjoy the feel of buying and selling goods in a bustling market. Rather than tracking actual coin, introduce a **Scrip Timer** that represents the party’s liquidity in the local economy.

4.3.1 How the Scrip Timer Works

- The timer has a number of segments equal to the typical daily wage for a common laborer in the setting (e.g., 4 segments = 4 days of work).
- When the party earns money (selling loot, completing a job, finding a treasure), the GM advances the timer by the appropriate number of segments.
- When the party spends money on goods, services, or bribes, the GM retreats the timer by the same amount.
- If the timer reaches zero, the party is *broke* and must find work, barter, or rely on patronage before they can make further purchases.
- If the timer fills completely, the party is *flush* and can afford minor luxuries without XP cost (the GM may grant a small narrative benefit, such as a favorable rumor or a temporary asset).

Because the timer is a shared resource, it creates natural tension: a successful heist might fill the Scrip Timer, but a failed negotiation could drain it just as the party needs to buy supplies for the next leg of the journey.

4.3.2 Example: Scrip Timer in a Port City

- The port's daily wage is 2 silver; we set the Scrip Timer to 4 segments (8 silver total).
- The players sell a smuggled crate for 3 segments (6 silver). The timer moves from 0/4 to 3/4.
- They need to hire a guide and buy provisions costing 2 segments. The timer retreats to 1/4.
- Later, a storm destroys their cargo; they lose 1 segment (representing lost investment) and are now at 0/4 – broke. They must take on an odd job or call in a favor before they can purchase anything else.

Note that the Scrip Timer never interacts with XP directly; it is purely a narrative tool for market flavor. If the group prefers to avoid even this abstraction, simply treat all purchases as XP expenditures and skip the timer.

4.4 Differences from Traditional Currency Systems

- **No Price Lists** – Instead of looking up a cost in a table, the GM judges the fictional weight of the item and assigns an XP value.
- **XP is Earned Through Play** – Characters cannot “farm” gold by grinding encounters; XP comes from story milestones, Boons, Acts of Service, and meaningful failures.
- **Scarcity is Narrative, Not Mechanical** – A shortage of money is felt through a low Scrip Timer or a high Obligation timer, not through a character's empty purse.
- **Encourages Creative Solutions** – Players are more likely to barter, offer favors, or use assets when they lack XP, leading to richer role-playing.

4.5 Caveats and Things to Consider

- **Avoid XP Inflation** – If you award XP too freely, players will be able to buy anything they want, removing tension. Keep XP gains tied to meaningful story beats.
- **Watch for “XP as Coin” Abuse** – Some players may try to spend XP on every minor convenience. Remind them that the **XP-as-currency** rule is for *major* expenses only; routine costs (food, lodging, cheap gear) should be handled narratively.
- **Balance Scrip Timer Size** – A timer that is too large makes money feel meaningless; too small makes the party constantly broke. Adjust the segment count to match the average wealth level of the setting.
- **Communicate the Trade-Off** – When a player spends XP on a purchase, explicitly state what they are giving up (e.g., “Spending 4 XP means you won't be able to raise your Weapon skill this arc”). This reinforces the decision-making nature of the system.
- **Use Timers for Other Resources** – Supply, Fatigue, Obligation, Mandate, Crisis, etc., all follow the same timer-based philosophy. Treat money the same way if you want a unified feel.

4.6 Running a Currency-Free Game – Practical Tips

GM Tips for a Currency-Free Table

- **Start with a Clear XP Economy** – Explain at Session Zero that XP is the only measurable wealth and that spending it is a story decision.
- **Use the Scrip Timer Sparingly** – Only introduce it when the market is a focal point of the story; otherwise, hand-wave purchases as “you have enough from recent work.”
- **Reward Creative Barter** – If a player offers a service, a favor, or an asset in lieu of XP, treat it as a valid transaction and adjust timers or obligations accordingly.
- **Keep Track of Major XP Spending** – A simple note on the GM screen (e.g., “Spent 6 XP on a safehouse – reduces future Mandate gains by 1”) helps you see the long-term impact of purchases.
- **Let the World React** – When the party spends a lot of XP on gear, have NPCs notice their newfound wealth (or lack thereof) and adjust their attitudes, leading to new plot hooks.

4.7 Example Session: The Merchant’s Dilemma

1. The party completes a smuggling run and earns 8 XP. They decide to spend 5 XP to purchase a modest warehouse (Asset tier: Minor). Their XP pool drops from 8 to 3.
2. The warehouse gives them a +1 bonus to any *Trade* or *Smuggle* roll made from that location.
3. Later, they need to bribe a customs officer. The GM declares the bribe costs 2 XP (moderate expense). The party spends it, leaving them with 1 XP.
4. With only 1 XP left, they cannot afford a rare component for a rite. Instead, they approach a local alchemist and offer to guard his shop for a night (a favor). The GM accepts, and the alchemist provides the component at no XP cost, but adds a small Obligation to the alchemist’s faction.
5. At the end of the session, the GM awards 2 XP for a successful Milestone (the smuggling run) and 1 XP for an Act of Service (guarding the shop). The party ends with 4 XP, ready for their next investment.

This flow shows how XP drives every meaningful purchase, how the Scrip Timer can be used for market flavor without breaking the XP-centric core, and how narrative alternatives (favors, obligations) keep the game fluid and engaging.

4.8 Final Thought

Treating XP as the universal currency shifts the focus from “how much gold do I have?” to “what story do I want to buy with my hard-earned experience?” As GM, your job is to make those choices feel weighty, to keep the timers ticking, and to let the world react to the players’ decisions—whether

they are spending XP on a mighty fortress, a humble meal, or a favor that will echo later in the campaign. Embrace the freedom, watch the tension rise, and let the players' ambitions shape the world, one XP at a time.

Part II

Magic and Scenarios

Chapter 5

Magic and Backlash

In **Fate’s Edge**, magic is not a clean art practiced in sterile towers. It is a **dangerous negotiation with forces beyond mortal comprehension**. As the GM, your role is to make magic **feel weighty, thematic, and alive with risk**. This chapter provides tools for adjudicating magical actions, managing consequences, and keeping the story at the forefront.

*For player-facing rules (spellcasting, Rites, Invoker symbols, Cantor songs, etc.), see the **Player’s Guide**. This chapter focuses on your role as GM.*

5.1 The Role of Magic in Your Game

Magic in Fate’s Edge is:

- **Consequential** – Every spell changes the fiction, for good or ill.
- **Risky** – Even success may generate Story Beats (SB) that you spend to complicate the moment.
- **Thematic** – Backlash should reflect the elements and Patrons involved.
- **Creative** – Reward inventive uses, but keep scope within the players’ tier.

Your primary job is not to block magic, but to **frame costs, apply consequences, and escalate drama**. When a player wants to cast a spell, ask:

- What do they want to achieve?
- Which elements or Patrons are involved?
- What is at stake if it goes wrong?

5.1.1 Patron as Co-Star

Patrons are not just sources of power – they are **co-stars** in the story. How you deploy them depends on your campaign’s length and tone.

Passive Patrons (Long Campaigns) In campaigns that run 20+ sessions, let the players accrue Obligation slowly. The GM narrates consequences only when thresholds are breached (e.g., reaching capacity, triggering a Patron Intrusion). The Patron remains a distant, ominous presence – a slow boiler.

Active Patrons (Short Campaigns / One-Shots) In short arcs (3–6 sessions) or one-shots, the GM should look for hooks aggressively. Offer bargains, push the Obligation spiral, and have the Patron appear in dreams, omens, or via intermediaries **every session**. The goal is to make the price of power immediate and visible.

Use this table to calibrate Patron involvement:

Campaign Length	Patron Style	How Often They Interfere
One-shot (1–2 sessions)	Hyperactive	Every scene, via SB spends or direct demands
Short arc (3–6 sessions)	Active	Once per session, often as a Devil's Bargain
Mid arc (7–15 sessions)	Pacing	Every 2–3 sessions; Obligation builds slowly
Long campaign (16+ sessions)	Passive	Only at thresholds or major story beats

The Simulation Insight Players enjoy being **tempted, not forced**. Offer a Patron's aid as a choice: "You can succeed automatically, but your Patron will ask for something later. Do you accept?" This turns Obligation from a punishment into a dramatic lever.

5.2 Adjudicating Magic at the Table

Setting Difficulty Value (DV) and Position

Use the standard DV ladder (2–5+), but consider magical specifics:

DV for Magic	
DV	When to Use
2	Routine cantrip, minor sensory effect, no opposition.
3	Standard combat spell, small environmental change, contested but fair.
4	Complex working, area effect, strong opposition, dangerous ritual.
5+	Legendary magic, rewriting reality, binding a major Outsider.

Position for Magic

- **Dominant:** Caster has ritual preparation, rare components, or surprise.

- **Controlled:** Standard casting under normal conditions.
- **Desperate:** Caster is wounded, rushed, or in an anti-magic zone.

Position affects the severity of backlash (see 5.3).

Quick Reference Table: DV by Spell Scope

Scope	Example	DV
Cantrip	Light a candle, sense magic	2
Combat	Fire bolt, force shield	3
Ritual (small)	Find a lost object, speak with a spirit	4
Ritual (large)	Summon a storm, teleport across a region	5+
Epic	Raise a dead army, rewrite a law of reality	6+ (with quest)

Range Bands for Magic

Spells and effects have natural range limits based on their tags and fiction. Use these guidelines:

Range Band	Typical Spells
Close	Touch, personal aura, short cone.
Near	Same room/zone, thrown magics, most combat spells.
Far	Across a battlefield, line of sight without obstacles.
Absent	Ritual scrying, long-distance teleportation (requires setup).

Adjusting Range: A spell can be extended one band by increasing DV by 1, adding a SB, or requiring an extra action. Extreme range (e.g., scrying a distant city) should be a ritual, not a single roll.

Handling Creative Player Ideas

When a player tries something unexpected:

1. Listen to the description. What do they want to achieve?
2. Ask for the tags or elements involved. If none, help them add one.
3. Set DV and Position based on scope and risk (see 5.2).
4. Clearly state the stakes: "If you fail, the spell will backfire and also alert the guards."
5. Let the dice decide, then spend SB to make the outcome interesting.

When in Doubt

A spell's power is not measured by how many dice it rolls, but by **how much it changes the story**. Use this rule of thumb:

- **Minor change (1 TAG):** The player's intent affects only themselves or a single object. Examples: *Light*, *HEAL*, *Veil* (self only). DV 2–3.
- **Moderate change (2 TAGS):** The spell affects a whole zone, creates a significant advantage, or bypasses a notable obstacle. Examples: *Area + Force*, *Barrier* across a doorway. DV 3–4.
- **Major change (3+ TAGS):** The spell rewrites the situation, solves a major problem outright, or introduces a new faction/ally/threat. Examples: *Teleport* across a city, *Summon* a Cap 3 spirit, *Transform* a person into a beast. DV 5+ and often a ritual.

If the player's description would *skip over a scene* (e.g., "I teleport us past the entire fortress"), that's a major change – require components, a timer, or a steep cost. If it would only *add flavor* (e.g., "I make my eyes glow red"), that's free. Let the fiction guide the DV, not a pre-computed formula.

Dangerous TAGS – When Magic Rewrites the Story

Some spell effects are so profound that they cannot be treated as ordinary TAGS. They **break the normal physics of the scene, skip over significant narrative obstacles, or permanently alter characters or the world**. These are **dangerous TAGS** and they incur **+2 DV** instead of the usual +1.

Why Are Some TAGS Dangerous?

- **Narrative Bypass:** A single roll should not invalidate an entire scene or challenge. *Teleport* past a castle wall, *Gate* to another continent, or *Transform* a boss into a mouse – these erase established fiction.
- **Lasting Consequences:** Effects that create permanent changes (resurrection, true polymorph, rewriting memory) demand a higher price.
- **Reality Strain:** The Weave (or whatever magical substrate you use) resists extreme manipulation. Dangerous tags represent that resistance.
- **Patron Attention:** Acts of cosmic magnitude attract the notice of powerful entities – a cost reflected in the higher DV.

Common Dangerous TAGS (Non-exhaustive)

Table 5.1: Dangerous TAGS and Why They Are Dangerous

TAG	Category	Why Dangerous (Narrative Impact)
Leap	Space/Motion	Teleports a person or object across range bands (Near → Far) without traversing the space. Can bypass walls, guards, or entire obstacles.
Fold	Space/Motion	Short-range teleport that can ignore physical barriers (e.g., through a locked door).
Gate	Space/Motion	Creates a two-way portal between distant locations. Can bypass entire adventures.
Gravity	Space/Motion	Alters local gravity – flight, crushing weight, or throwing enemies into the sky. Scene-rewriting.
Create	Creation	Brings a permanent (or long-lasting) object into existence from nothing. Circumvents resource scarcity.
Summon	Creation	Calls a creature (Cap 3+) that can fight, scout, or solve problems independently. Adds a new actor to the scene.
Transmute	Transformation	Changes one substance into another (lead → gold, stone → flesh). Economic or structural game – changer.
Animate	Transformation / Creation	Gives life to inanimate objects – a statue that fights, a rope that ties itself. Adds a persistent minion.
Transform	Transformation	Changes a creature's form permanently (or for a long duration). Polymorph, petrification, lycanthropy.
Dominate	Mind	Takes total control of a sapient creature's actions. Removes player/NPC agency.
Rewind	Time	Reverses time locally – undoes an action, a death, or a scene. Extreme narrative power.
Resurrect	Life/Death	Brings a dead character back to life. Undermines mortal stakes.

How to Decide If a Player's TAG Is Dangerous

When a player proposes a spell, ask yourself three questions:

1. **Does this effect skip over a significant obstacle or scene?** If the spell would allow the party to bypass a challenge that you intended to be a whole scene (e.g., "I teleport us into the vault" instead of "I pick the lock, evade the guard, and disable the trap"), it is **dangerous**.
2. **Does this effect permanently change the character, a major NPC, or the setting?** If the change is not easily reversible by mundane means (e.g., turning a guard into a frog, erasing a memory, raising a corpse), it is **dangerous**.

3. **Does this effect introduce a new major asset or remove a major threat with a single roll?** If the spell would instantly defeat a boss ("I transform Garrick into a mouse"), destroy a fortress ("I collapse the mountain"), or create a powerful ally ("I summon a dragon"), it is **dangerous** – and likely requires a ritual, not a single action.

Edge Cases

- **Leap** used to jump a chasm that would otherwise require an Athletics roll – **not dangerous** (that's a minor bypass).
- **Leap** used to teleport past a locked gate, a patrol, and a guard post – **dangerous** (bypasses multiple obstacles).
- **Summon** calling a Cap 1 rat to scout a room – **not dangerous** (minor utility).
- **Summon** calling a Cap 3 demon to fight a boss – **dangerous** (adds a major combatant).

GM Principle When in doubt, **rule in favor of the story**. A dangerous tag is not a prohibition – it is a **higher cost**. Tell the player:

“That effect is powerful enough to reshape the scene. It’s a dangerous tag, so the DV will be +2 higher than usual. On a failure, the backlash will be severe. Are you sure you want to try?”

This keeps player creativity alive while ensuring magic feels weighty and consequential.

Healing Magic (GM Ruling)

Healing in **Fate’s Edge** is deliberately gated. **HEAL** restores **Fatigue** quickly and safely; restoring **Harm** requires more power, more risk, and often a narrative price. This keeps injuries meaningful while still allowing magical support.

HEAL Restores Fatigue, Not Harm. When a player uses a cantrip (or a free-form casting) with only the [HEAL] tag, it removes **1 Fatigue** from the caster or a touched ally.

- **DV:** 2 (cantrip speed)
- **Action:** 1 action
- **Risk:** None inherent – the GM may still spend Story Beats (from any 1s on the roll) for thematic color (e.g., a scar that tingles, faint spiritual attention).

This is the "bandage and breath" of magical healing – reliable, fast, and low-risk.

Healing Harm Costs More. To restore **1 level of Harm** (e.g., Harm 1 → 0, or Harm 2 → 1), the player must either :

1. Accept a **+2 DV modifier** on the spell, or
2. Use [HEAL] together with **at least one other appropriate tag**, such as:
 - [PURIFY] – for poison, disease, or corruption
 - [STRENGTHEN] – for broken bones or torn muscles
 - [CLEANSE] – for curses or magical wounds

The GM may increase the DV further for exceptionally severe injuries:

Wound Severity	DV Adjustment
Minor Harm (level 1)	no extra
Serious Harm (level 2)	+1 DV
Critical Harm (level 3)	+2 DV (often requires a full ritual)

Requiring a second tag also makes healing a **full two-action spell** (Weave then Cast) unless the caster has a talent that compresses casting (e.g., *Effortless Casting*).

Complications – Story Beats as Narrative Cost. When a player rolls to heal Harm, any 1s on the roll generate Story Beats (SB) for you. Spend these SB to introduce **thematic complications** – the healing works, but the world pushes back.

Spend SB on Healing Complications

SB Cost	Example Complication
1 SB	The wound leaves a visible scar; the patient feels a strange hunger for a day.
2 SB	A minor spirit of injury is attracted – it watches the patient for a scene.
3 SB	The healing draws a Patron’s curiosity: mark +1 Obligation or advance a Corruption timer.
4+ SB	A nearby corpse briefly animates, or the patient remembers a forgotten trauma.

These complications **do not undo the healing**. They add story. A scar is a memory; a Patron’s interest is a future hook. Healing in Fate’s Edge is never trivial.

Non-Magical Healing – Quick Reference. Even without magic, characters can recover:

- **First Aid (Wits + Medicine, DV 3):** Stabilizes a dying character (prevents Harm progression). Does not heal Harm.
- **Short Rest (1 hour):** Clears 1 Fatigue.
- **Full Night’s Rest (safe haven):** Clears all Fatigue and, with medical care, may restore 1 Harm per day of rest.

Design Note for GMs.

- **Fatigue is common, Harm is rare.** Keep the party moving by letting them clear Fatigue easily. Harm should feel earned and expensive to remove.
- **Let the cleric (or healer) shine.** A Runekeeper of the Oath of Flame or a Cantor with healing songs should be able to heal Harm – at a cost that makes the table pause.
- **Use the SB menu above as inspiration, not a straitjacket.** A scar that aches in cold weather, a debt to a spirit of mercy, or a public miracle that attracts unwanted attention – all are fair game.

Example in play:

Marcus (Harm 1) asks Kestra to heal him. Kestra uses [HEAL] + [PURIFY] and accepts the +2 DV, rolling against DV 5. She succeeds, but rolls two 1s. The GM spends 2 SB: "The wound closes, but a faint scar remains – and you feel a pair of cold eyes watching from the shadows. Something in the fog took notice."

5.3 Story Beats and Backlash (GM Tools)

Every time a player rolls a 1 on a magical action, you gain Story Beats (SB) as described in 2.3. Spend them to create backlash – complications that fit the magic's element and the fiction.

SB Spend Menu for Magic

Spend SB on Magical Complications	
SB Cost	Example Backlash
1 SB	Minor flare, eerie sound, brief sensory distortion, gear lightly scorched.
2 SB	Backlash harms an ally (Fatigue 1), spell draws attention, caster loses balance (Position -1).
3 SB	Patron omen, secondary target affected, magical feedback (Harm 1 to caster).
4+ SB	Reality warps – zone gains a temporary tag, Patron manifests a demand, a new threat appears.

Creating a Choice with SB

One of the most powerful GM moves is to spend SB to offer a **hard choice** – not just a consequence.

Example: The player succeeds on a ritual to divine an enemy's location. The roll generates 2 SB. The GM spends them:

"You see the enemy's camp clearly – but your Patron's symbol glows hot on your hand. **You can have the vision for free, or you can let the spell fizzle and keep your Obligation unchanged.** If you accept the vision, mark +2 Obligation and your Patron will demand a task. What do you choose?"

This turns a success into a narrative fork, not a punishment.

Elemental Backlash Examples

Use these to color your complications:

Element	Sample Backlash
Fire	Smoke, heat exhaustion, small secondary fire, blinding flare.
Water	Flooding, slippery footing, emotional surge, dampness ruining supplies.
Earth	Tremor, dust cloud, immobilizing stone grip, cracked floor.
Air	Sudden gust, deafening thunder, scatters important items, voice lost.
Fate	Prophetic nightmare, doors close, a crucial option disappears.
Luck	Allied misfortune, fragile success, random complication.
Life	Overtgrowth, healing surge on enemy, parasitic plants.
Death	Ghostly whisper, chill, memory loss, premature decay.

Backlash Severity by Position

Position	Backlash Severity on Partial/Miss
Dominant	Minor – one SB complication, manageable cost.
Controlled	Moderate – 1–2 SB complication, temporary setback.
Desperate	Severe – 2–3 SB complication, lasting consequences or Harm.

5.4 Managing Obligation and Corruption

Players track their own Obligation and Corruption as described in. **Your job is to enforce thresholds and frame Patron intrusions as story hooks, not punishments.**

Obligation Overflow and Patron Intrusions

When a character exceeds their Obligation Capacity (Spirit + Presence):

- For each segment over capacity, mark 1 Fatigue (player does this).

- If they exceed **double capacity**, clear all Fatigue, mark Harm 1, and trigger a **Patron Intrusion** – a narrative demand or complication from the Patron.

Examples of Patron Intrusions

- The Patron appears in a dream: "Do this task for me, or else."
- A rival servant of the same Patron arrives to collect a debt.
- The Patron's mark becomes visible on the character's skin, causing social trouble.
- A faction aligned with the Patron forcibly recruits the character.

Corruption as a Narrative Track

Corruption (Cantors, Pact-Whisperers) fills from pushes, resonant rites, and your SB spends. When the timer fills (see 5.6):

- Apply the Patron's "benefit and burden" (see Patron tables in the **Player's Guide**).
- Reset the timer to the character's Tier minimum.
- If the player chooses **Embrace Corruption**, give them a permanent thematic quirk (not a pure penalty).

5.5 Summoning (GM-Facing)

For full summoning mechanics, see the **Player's Guide** (Pact-Whisperer). Here are your key responsibilities.

What to Watch For

- **Leash ticking:** Tick the Leash whenever the spirit takes Harm, acts against its nature, the summoner splits focus, or the spirit crosses a [WARD] (test DV = Cap).
- **Boon Finesse:** Players may spend 1 Boon once per round to clear 1 tick (before the Leash fills).
- **Quick Commands:** Simple orders (attack nearest, hold, fetch) do not cost the summoner's action. Complex commands do.

When the Spirit Acts on Its Own

On a Miss, or when the Leash fills, the spirit acts once according to its nature before departing (or turning hostile). The spirit's independent action should be **interesting** – not just damage. Use the table below for inspiration.

d6 Spirit Whims Table

d6 Spirit's Independent Action	
1	Reveal a Secret: The spirit blurts out a hidden fact about a PC or NPC – true, embarrassing, or dangerous.
2	Break Something: The spirit shatters a mundane object (a lantern, a rope bridge, a crucial tool).
3	Lead Astray: The spirit moves a short distance and creates a false trail, forcing the party to waste time.
4	Call for Help: The spirit summons a minor ally (a rat swarm, a will-o'-wisp, a lesser elemental).
5	Curse a PC: The spirit leaves a lingering mark (–1 die on one skill until the next sunrise).
6	Bargain: The spirit offers a deal: "Release me now, and I'll tell you where the treasure is hidden."

Spirit Specializations (Quick Reference)

If a player develops a bonded spirit, you may grant one specialization from this list:

- **Combat:** +1 Harm melee, ignore first Harm on attacks.
- **Scout:** Stealthy; Cap 1 carries 2 kg, Cap 3 carries 10 kg.
- **Utility:** Simple tasks (carrying, opening doors).
- **Shield:** Interpose; convert Harm to Fatigue.

5.6 Cantors and Corruption (GM Guidance)

Cantors use Songs (Low Rites) with a Corruption Timer . Your main tasks:

- Track the Corruption Timer only when the player marks it (they manage it per).
- On a fill, impose the last Patron's benefit & burden (from Patron tables in the **Player's Guide**). Remember that the player then **sets their current Corruption segments to their Tier** (minimum 1). This means high-Tier Cantors always carry a trace of past blooms – use that as a story hook.
- Spend SB to represent social fallout, Patron omens, or magical residue from their performances. For example, a Cantor who Pushes a song in a crowded tavern might generate a rumor timer or attract the attention of a witch-hunter.

Inspire Chorus

Once per scene, a Cantor can shift all allies' Position +1 for one exchange. If they use it again in the same scene, they mark toward Corruption accumulation (usually 1 segment). This is a non-stacking aura; only the best shift applies.

Chorus Cults (Optional)

If a Cantor performs a **Resonant Rite** (a Song performed with dramatic intent, witnessed by 10+ people, and dedicated to a specific Patron) they may found a **Chorus**. This grants a minor follower benefit (see 3.4), but they must mark Obligation to the Cult's Patron (the patron of the Resonant Rite sung) each session they use it.

Managing a Chorus Cult:

- Define the benefit concretely with the player. Good examples: +1 die to Performance once/session, a single rumor per session, or +1 Boon when singing in public.
- Track the cult's health with a **Schism Timer [4]**. Tick it when the player ignores the cult (no contact, refuses a request) or when the cult's demands go unmet. On a full timer, introduce a fracture: a rival sect, false rumors, or alliance with a Patron's enemy.
- Use the Obligation to the Patron as a debt. When it fills, the Patron may demand a service that involves the cult – such as a ritual performance, a pilgrimage, or silencing a troublesome follower.
- When the Cantor experiences a Corruption bloom, have the cult react. They may be inspired (temporary benefit upgrade) or terrified (temporary penalty). This makes the bloom matter to the faction, not just the character.

Corruption Blooms as Narrative Levers

A Corruption bloom is not a punishment – it is a **character metamorphosis**. Use the Patron's benefit and burden to create roleplaying moments:

- The burden (e.g., "cannot refuse a request for a song") should complicate the Cantor's life in interesting ways. Enforce it gently but consistently.
- Let the benefit be genuinely useful (e.g., +1 die to resist fear or a new thematic sense). This encourages players to embrace blooms rather than fear them.
- After a bloom, ask the player to describe a physical or behavioral change (feathers in hair, a second shadow, a musical tic). Record it on the character sheet. These changes accumulate, making high-Tier Cantors visibly strange.

Patron's Dedication (Cantor)

Prerequisite: Cantor's Path.

Cost: 4 XP.

Effect: You bind your voice to a single Patron (choose one when you take this talent). Your Corruption timer is always keyed to that Patron – it never resets to a different Patron's table when you bloom. Whenever you would gain Corruption from any source, you mark it on this same timer.

Downside (Rivalry): Singing a Song (Low or Standard Rite) of any other Patron is treacherous. When you do so, your Position for that song is worsened by one step (Dominant → Controlled, Controlled → Desperate). This penalty applies even if the song would otherwise be instant or free.

Note: This talent does not prevent you from learning or knowing Rites of other Patrons – it merely reflects the jealousy of your chosen Patron and the strain of divided loyalty.

Resonant Rites – Ruling Guidelines

A player may attempt a Resonant Rite to found a cult or simply as a powerful performance. Use these guidelines:

- The performance requires at least 10 witnesses who are actively paying attention (not just passing by).
- The player must describe the performance in at least moderate detail – what they sing, how they move, what Patron they invoke.
- On a successful Lore + Performance roll (DV 3, Position Controlled), the rite is resonant. On a failure, the crowd is unimpressed; the GM may impose a social complication (e.g., heckling, a rival performer).
- A Resonant Rite always advances the Corruption Timer (mark 1 segment). If the timer fills, the bloom occurs during the performance – describe the Patron’s touch manifesting in front of the audience.

Song Weaver and Compatibility

When a player with Song Weaver wants to combine two Songs, you decide compatibility. Use these heuristics:

- **Thematically compatible:** both songs affect healing, both affect movement, both target spirits, etc.
- **Same Patron:** songs from the same Patron are always compatible (they share a thematic resonance).
- **Player justification:** If the player can give a compelling narrative reason why two songs work together, allow it.

When combined, the player makes a single Lore + Performance roll. If successful, both Song effects occur with +1 Effect (e.g., longer duration, larger area, or +1 die to a related roll). If the roll fails, neither Song takes effect, and the GM gains 1 SB (the discordant notes draw unwanted attention).

High Cantor and Instant Standard Rites

High Cantor is a powerful talent. Keep these points in mind:

- A Cantor with High Cantor can sing a Standard Rite (from any Patron they have learned) as an instant action. No delay. This does not require a Push unless they want an extra effect.
- They may still Push the instant Song for +1 Effect at the usual cost (1 Fatigue, mark Corruption). This means a High Cantor can, for example, cast Lay on Hands instantly and also Push it to heal an extra point of Fatigue.

- Because Standard Rites often cost Obligation for Runekeepers, the Cantor bypasses that cost entirely. This is intentional – their cost is Corruption and potential social fallout. Let them enjoy the power, but remind them that public displays of potent magic attract attention.

Steady Voice (Optional Talent)

The **Steady Voice** talent (2 XP, Player's Guide) allows a Cantor to Push a Song by marking 1 additional Fatigue instead of a Corruption segment (once per scene). This is a safety valve for low-Spirit Cantors. Use it to let a player avoid an untimely bloom, but then apply pressure through Fatigue management (e.g., they are now Fatigued 2 and must rest).

Final Advice

The Cantor's power is **flexibility and speed**. Their weakness is **Corruption accumulation and social visibility**. Lean into both:

- Give them opportunities to sing for crowds, but also introduce hecklers, rivals, or inquisitors who take notes.
- Let Corruption blooms change their relationships – old allies may become wary; new contacts may seek them out as oracles.
- Use Chorus Cults to tie the Cantor to a community that needs protection, guidance, or rescue. Cults are story engines, not just free bonuses.

“The Cantor's voice is a candle in the dark. It illuminates, but it also draws the eye of things that hunt by light. Let them sing. Let them bloom. Let their chorus become legend – or a warning.”

— The Grey Wanderer, *The Grey Wanderer's Grimoire*

Rival Factions: A neglected Chorus can become a rival faction (see 9, *Advanced GM Techniques*). They may split into a competing sect, spread false rumors about the Cantor, or even ally with a Patron's enemy. Use this to generate long-term plot hooks.

5.7 Ritual Magic (GM Advice)

Rituals are powerful but slow. Use them for effects that are too big for a single roll.

Setting DV for Rituals

- **Low Ritual (DV 3–4):** 10–15 minutes, affects a room or small area.
- **Standard Ritual (DV 4–5):** 30 minutes, affects a building or a scene.
- **High Ritual (DV 5+):** Hours, affects a district or narrative turning point.

Using Helpers

Helpers can reduce DV by 1 each (max -2) or absorb 1 SB of backlash. They must have relevant skills (Arcana, Lore, etc.). Interrupting a helper may disrupt the ritual.

Pacing and Interruption

If a ritual is interrupted, treat as a Miss on the casting roll (see 2.3). You may also:

- Advance a doomsday timer.
- Summon an unexpected entity.
- Damage a needed component.

Components as Devotion (Even with a Symbol/Codex/Thiasos)

A common player question: "I already have a Patron's Symbol / Codex / Thiasos – why should I hunt for rare components?"

Answer: Because components are **offerings**. They show the Patron that you are willing to invest time, resources, and risk. Even when a Symbol or Codex technically allows a ritual without physical materials, **acquiring components voluntarily can reduce Obligation or earn the Patron's favor.**

Use this rule of thumb:

- **Ritual with no components (just Symbol/Codex):** Normal DV, normal Obligation cost.
- **Ritual with common components (herbs, salt, a candle):** Reduce Obligation by 1 (minimum 0).
- **Ritual with rare or dangerous components (a phoenix feather, a drop of troll blood, a whispered secret):** Reduce DV by 1 **and** clear 1 segment of existing Obligation to that Patron (once per session max).
- **Ritual with a truly legendary component (the crown of a dead king, a tear from a goddess):** The Patron may waive all Obligation for that ritual – and even grant a free Boon.

This gives players a meaningful choice: use the easy, costly path (Symbol/Codex) or invest legwork to earn the Patron's good will. It also turns component hunting into adventure hooks.

5.8 Psionics (Optional) – GM Sidebar

Adjudicating Psionics

Psionics is power without intermediaries – no Patrons, no symbols. As GM, ensure it feels precise yet costly.

Core Principles:

- Set DV by precision, not raw power. Clear intent = lower DV.
- **Generate SB frequently** – mental strain, sensory bleed, NPC suspicion. Psionics generates SB quickly; be prepared to spend them on interesting complications.
- Respect consent: unwilling minds always resist.
- On Partial, offer hard choices: surface thoughts only, emotional truth without context.
- Distinguish from spellcraft: psionics excels at direct influence, not environmental change.

Example Backlash: headache, nosebleed, fleeting vision, target becomes aware of intrusion, caster loses focus (Fatigue 1).

5.9 Quick Reference Tables (GM Only)

Spend SB for Magical Complications

SB	Effect
1	Minor flare, noise, caster off-balance (–1 die next action).
2	Backlash harms an ally (Fatigue 1), draws attention, Position –1.
3	Patron omen, magical feedback (Harm 1), new timer (e.g., "Leaking Energy").
4+	Reality warp, Patron manifestation, scene shifts (fire, flood, etc.).

Elemental Backlash Quick Picks

Element	Minor (1–2 SB)	Major (3+ SB)
Fire	Smoke, sparks	Uncontrolled fire, explosion
Water	Slick floor, damp	Flooding, emotional storm
Earth	Dust, tremor	Collapse, binding
Air	Gust, ringing ears	Hurricane, deafness
Fate	Option closes	Prophecy becomes fixed
Luck	Small misfortune	A friend suffers the failure
Life	Overgrowth	Parasite, fever
Death	Chill whispers	A ghost manifests

Patron Intrusion Examples

Patron Type	Sample Intrusion
Everflame (Oath)	"Prove your purity – destroy that heretical text."
The Traveler	"You must guide a lost soul to their destination."
Inquisitor Prime	"Report any unsanctioned magic you witness."
Malachai	"Curse someone weaker than you before dawn."

Final GM Reminder

Magic is a narrative engine. Use Story Beats to create drama, not to punish. When in doubt, let the spell work and complicate the result. The world should react – but always in a way that keeps the story moving.

“Set the DV low. Spend SB to make the cost visible. Let the fiction lead.”

Chapter 6

Running Scenarios

A scenario is a self-contained unit of play with a clear stake, meaningful choices, and visible pressure. Your goal as GM is not to control the outcome, but to **shape the pressure** so that player decisions create memorable consequences. This chapter distills Fate’s Edge into actionable GM techniques for facilitating scenarios—from preparation to execution—using the system’s core tools: Story Beats, timers, and player agency.

6.1 GM Mindset: Co-Creating Drama

Before rolling dice, internalize these principles. They transform rule enforcement into collaborative storytelling.

GM Core Principles

- **Narrative primacy:** Mechanics serve the story. When in doubt, choose what creates the most dramatic consequence or interesting choice.
- **Pressure over punishment:** Use Story Beats to escalate tension (e.g., “The ritual advances”) not to penalize players (“You lose 2 HP”).
- **Fail forward:** Every roll changes the situation. A Miss isn’t “nothing happens”—it’s “the alarm sounds and guards converge.”
- **Player agency first:** Offer costs, timers, or complications instead of saying “no.” (“You can try, but it will take time—tick the Ritual Timer +1.”)
- **Your preparation is invisible magic:** Between-session work turns random encounters into meaningful episodes. Players never see the strings—only the music.

6.2 Preparing a Scenario: The 15-Minute GM Sprint

Effective scenario prep focuses on **pressure points**, not plots. Do this before each session:

1. **Identify the stake:** What is the players' *immediate* goal? (e.g., "Retrieve the Sunstone before the ritual completes.") Write it as a question: "Can they get the Sunstone in time?"
2. **Set 1–3 visible timers:** Use the Three-Timer Rule (see 6.4.1) to track progress/opposition. Label them clearly: *Ritual Completion* [6], *Guard Patrols* [4].
3. **Prepare 2–3 flexible situations:** Not scripts, but pressure cookers with clear stakes and timers. Example:
 - *Situation:* "The Sunstone is on a pedestal in the collapsing chamber. The ceiling cracks ominously."
 - *Timer:* *Chamber Collapse* [8] (ticks on Partial/Miss inside chamber)
 - *Stakes:* Succeed = get Sunstone; Fail = take Harm 1 + timer advances.
4. **Seed player hooks:** Review Bonds/Complications. Ask: "How does this situation threaten what they care about?" (e.g., A player bonded to the Scholar Mira? The rival Captain Voss taunts them about her fate.)
5. **Check complication debt:** Note unresolved Complications from last session—they add +1 SB to the first scene.

Scenario Prep Checklist

Stake phrased as a yes/no question
 1–3 visible timers named and sized (4/6/8/10)
 2–3 flexible situations (stake + timer)
 At least one player hook per PC
 Complication debt noted (adds SB to Scene 1)

6.3 Running the Scene: The 90-Second Loop

Every meaningful player action follows this GM procedure. *Internalize this loop—it's your engine.*

1. **Declare intent and approach:** "What do you want to do, and how?" (Player states Attribute+Skill)
2. **Set Position and DV:**
 - **Position:** Dominant (advantage), Controlled (normal), Desperate (high risk). Default: Controlled.
 - **DV:** 2 (routine) to 5+ (extreme). Default: 3 (pressured). *Never inflate DV to "challenge"—use Position instead.*

Announce: "Controlled, DV 3. On a Miss, the guard hears you."
3. **Roll and count:** Pool = Attribute+Skill d10s. Successes: 6–9 = 1, 10 = 2. Count 1s for Story Beats (SB).
4. **Apply Outcome Matrix:**
 - Successes $\geq$ DV, SB=0: Clean Success—intent achieved, no complication.
 - Successes $\geq$ DV, SB>0: Success with SB—intent achieved; GM spends SB.

- $0 < \text{Successes} < \text{DV}$: Partial—progress; player gains 1 Boon.
- $\text{Successes} = 0$: Miss—no progress; player gains 2 Boons; GM spends SB.

Remember: A Partial moves the story forward. A Miss always escalates.

5. **Spend Story Beats:** Use the SB Spend Menu (see 6.4.2) to introduce complications that *change the situation*. Tie spends to visible outcomes: “I spend 2 SB—the alarm blares and two guards rush in (tick Guard Patrols +2).”
6. **Describe the new situation:** End with one sentence stating the new fiction: “The chamber shudders as dust rains from the ceiling—Ritual Completion is now at 5 of 6.”

Between-Session Checklist

1. **Update timers:** Tick faction, travel, or campaign timers based on last session’s outcomes.
2. **Check complication debt:** Note unresolved player Complications; they add +1 SB to the next session’s first scene.
3. **Prepare 2–3 flexible situations:** Not scripts, but situations with a clear stake and a timer.
4. **Review player goals:** Look at Bonds, Patron obligations, and personal arcs. Seed at least one hook per player.
5. **Refresh your memory:** Re-read the session summary from last time (ask a player to recap if you didn’t write one).

6.4 Key GM Techniques

These are the levers you pull to shape pressure. Practice them until they’re instinctive.

6.4.1 The Three-Timer Rule

At any given time, maintain **at most three active timers** in a scene. More creates cognitive overload and dilutes tension. Name them and tick them *aloud* where players can see.

1. **Situation Timer:** Tracks progress toward the scene’s immediate goal (e.g., *Chamber Collapse* [8], *Persuade the Duke* [6]).
2. **Counter-Clock:** Tracks opposition pressure (e.g., *Guard Patrols* [4], *Ritual Completion* [6]).
3. **Campaign Timer:** Tracks long-term front pressure (e.g., *Cult Influence* [6], *Sun’s Fading* [10]).

Merge redundant timers (e.g., two “guard arrival” timers become one). Retire timers that resolve naturally. *Example:* In a negotiation scene:

- Situation Timer: *Reach Agreement* [6] (ticks on Partial in Persuade rolls)
- Counter-Clock: *Duke’s Patience* [4] (ticks when players ignore social cues)

- Campaign Timer: *Noble Feud Spreads* [8] (ticks between sessions based on faction actions)

6.4.2 Story Beats Spend Menu

Spend SB to introduce complications that *escalate pressure or reveal truth*. Match SB cost to narrative impact—never spend more than needed.

SB Cost	Effect
1	Minor pressure: Noise, distraction, tick a 4–6 segment timer +1, worsen Position by one step. <i>Example:</i> “Your foot scrapes a loose stone—the guard looks up (tick Guard Alert +1).”
2	Moderate setback: Alarm raised, lose cover/advantage, lesser foe appears, split the party briefly. <i>Example:</i> “The guard calls for backup—two more arrive (new timer: Reinforcements [6]).”
3+	Serious trouble+: Reinforcements arrive, key gear breaks, major twist shifts the scene, authority arrives, environment changes dramatically. <i>Example:</i> “The chamber ceiling groans—a 10-ton block begins to fall (Chamber Collapse now at 7 of 8).”

Pro tip: One strong beat (e.g., 3 SB for reinforcements) creates more drama than three weak beats (1+1+1 SB for noise). Be generous—unused SB is wasted momentum.

6.4.3 Handling Player Creativity

When players propose unexpected solutions:

- **Say “Yes, but” not “no”:** Offer a cost, timer, or complication. (“You can try to bribe the guard—but it will take time. Make a Persuade roll, and on a Miss, the guard alerts his captain.”)
- **Use Setup/Assist actions:** Let non-specialists contribute meaningfully. (“You can’t pick the lock, but you can hold the torch steady—grant +1 die to the rogue’s roll.”)
- **Embrace the unexpected:** If they bypass your planned encounter, let it work—but escalate pressure elsewhere. (“You trick the guards into leaving their post... but the ritual chamber’s seals begin to weaken. Tick Ritual Completion +1.”)
- **Fail forward aggressively:** A Miss on their creative solution shouldn’t stop the story—it should change direction. (“You fail to convince the guard... but in your panic, you notice a loose stone in the wall—a possible escape route.”)

6.4.4 Visible Pressure: Making Timers Matter

Timers only create tension if players *see and understand* them.

- **Name timers descriptively:** “*Ritual Completion*” not “*Timer 3*”. Players should know what advancing it means.
- **Tick them aloud:** “The cult’s chant grows louder—Ritual Completion advances to 4 of 6.”
- **Link timer advances to fiction:** Never just say “tick timer.” Describe what changes: “As the timer hits 5, the air smells of ozone and sulfur—the demon’s presence warps reality nearby.”
- **Place trackers centrally:** Use physical tokens (see 7 for tracker ideas) where all players see them. Update them *during* play, not just between scenes.

6.5 Common Pitfalls and Fixes

Even experienced GMs fall into these traps. Recognize and correct them instantly.

Pitfall Fixes

- **Pitfall:** “I’m hoarding SB for a big climax.”
Fix: Spend SB early and often. Pressure creates drama—saving it makes scenes flat. Unspent SB beyond your limit (Tier +1) carries over, but hoarding starves the table of tension.
- **Pitfall:** “The players are stuck—they keep failing the same roll.”
Fix: Ask: “What is your *goal*?” Then name the simplest obstacle. If they want to sneak past guards but keep failing Stealth, offer: “You can’t sneak—but you could create a distraction (Make a Deceive roll).”
- **Pitfall:** “I don’t know the rule for X.”
Fix: Make a ruling that keeps the story moving, then check later. Default: DV 3, Position Controlled. Note it for downtime resolution—never halt play to look up rules.
- **Pitfall:** “My prep went unused—the players went off-track.”
Fix: Your prep was never about specific scenes—it was about *pressure*. If they ignored the cultist ambush, the cult’s timer still advances. Reveal consequences: “You avoided the ambush... but the ritual completes without interference. Tick Cult Influence +2.”
- **Pitfall:** “I feel like I’m arguing with players about rules.”
Fix: Remember: You are co-creators, not adversaries. When rules conflict with fiction, *always* side with fiction. Make a ruling that serves the story, then reconcile with rules text afterward.

6.6 Rookie GM Comfort Dials

If you’re new to Fate’s Edge, start here to build confidence.

Rookie GM Settings

- **Soft SB:** For first 2 sessions, cap SB spend per roll at 1–2 (unless it’s a set-piece moment like a timer filling). Prevents overwhelming new players.
- **Visible Timers:** Put *all* active timers on the table. Name them aloud. Tick them in ink so players see the progression.
- **Tag Cards:** Print one-liners for frequent tags (e.g., [WARD]: Blocks outsiders. DV = target’s Cap.) and hand them out when relevant.
- **One Move, One Sentence:** After every ruling, end with one sentence stating the new situation: “The gate holds—but the timer for Cult Influence advances to 3 of 6 as the chant peaks.”

6.7 Scenario Types: Adapting the Loop

Apply the 90-Second Loop to these common scenario frames with these tweaks:

6.7.1 Social Encounters

Use Persuasion Timers (see SRD 17.3.3):

- **Clean Success:** +2 segments to Persuasion Timer
- **Partial:** +1 segment; GM may spend SB for complication (“They agree—but you’ll owe a favor”)
- **Miss:** No progress; GM ticks Opposition Timer (when full, target hardens Position)
- *GM Tip:* Spend SB to reveal hidden motives (“The duke’s smile doesn’t reach his eyes—he’s stalling for time”) or escalate stakes (“His hand twitches toward his sword—you see the guard shift behind you”).

6.7.2 Travel Legs

Frame each leg as a scenario with roles (see 7.5):

- **Guide:** Wits+Survival to tick Travel Timer +1 (success) or backwards (failure)
- **Scout:** Wits+Stealth to avoid surprise on first encounter
- **Quartermaster:** Wits+Craft to manage Supply
- **Watch:** Presence+Notice for +1 Position on first ambush defense roll
- *GM Tip:* On failed role, spend SB to introduce immediate encounter (“As you argue the route, a wolf pack emerges from the fog”).

6.7.3 Magical Experiments

Treat spellcasting as pressure (see SRD 17.5.1):

- Free casters: Position worsens by 1 when engaged unless spell has [TOUCH] or [WARD]
- Rite casters: Mark Obligation when invoking; Push It for +1 Obligation for increased effect
- *GM Tip*: On Partial/Miss, spend SB for thematic backlash (“The fireball singes your eyebrows—next action is Desperate”) or environmental shift (“The spell’s resonance cracks a stalactite—it begins to fall”).

6.8 Ending the Scenario: Leave Hooks, Not Loose Ends

Close scenarios to create momentum for the next:

1. **Resolve the immediate stake:** State clearly whether they achieved their goal (yes/no/partial).
2. **Advance relevant timers:** Especially Campaign and Faction timers based on outcomes.
3. **Seed 1–2 hooks for next session:**
 - “The rival captain escaped—but she dropped this bloodstained sigil.”
 - “The ritual failed... but the cult’s leader whispers your true name as she flees.”
 - “You saved the village—but the Sunstone’s light now attracts *something* from the deep dark.”
4. **Explicitly note complication debt:** “Your Complication ‘Sealed Hold Refuses You’ remains unresolved—it will add +1 SB to your first action next session.”
5. **Ask one reflective question:** “What did you learn about your character tonight?” (Use answers to seed arcs/bonds).

6.9 The GM’s Sacred Trust

Remember: Your off-table work is where the magic happens. Between sessions:

- Update timers based on scene outcomes (factions advance, pressures spread)
- Check complication debt (unresolved Complications = +1 SB next scene)
- Prepare flexible situations (stake + timer, not scripts)
- Review player sheets for hooks (Bonds, Patron obligations, personal arcs)
- Refresh your memory on last session’s events

This invisible preparation transforms dice rolls into consequence-rich stories. When players say, “That session felt *alive*,” it’s because you honored this trust—not because of any rule you enforced at the table.

Let the pressure shape the story. Let the dice sing. And never forget: you are playing the game too.

Part III

Campaign and Tools

Chapter 7

Campaigns, Timers, and Consequences

In **Fate’s Edge**, campaigns are not a sequence of disconnected adventures—they are **pressure systems**. Every choice the players make pushes on something: a faction, a threat, a relationship, a belief. Over time, those pressures accumulate, shift, and eventually *break*.

Your job as GM is not to hide this pressure—it is to **shape it, reveal it, and let the players decide where it lands**.

This chapter presents the core tools for doing that work: **Timers, Fronts, the Crown Spread**, and long-term campaign structures. Used well, they create momentum without railroading and stakes without arbitrary escalation.

7.1 Foundational Principles for Campaign Design

Before diving into tools, internalize these rules of thumb. They will save you more prep time than any other advice.

7.1.1 Set Situations, Not Plots

A **situation** is a stable condition with inherent conflict. A **plot** is a sequence of events you expect the players to follow.

- **Plot:** “The players must retrieve the Sunstone from the Ruined Tower, then defeat the necromancer, then close the rift.”
- **Situation:** “The necromancer has claimed the Ruined Tower. The Sunstone inside could seal the rift. The village is starving because crops wither near the rift.”

Situations give players **agency**. They can negotiate with the necromancer, steal the Sunstone, collapse the tower, divert a river to flood the rift—any solution that fits the fiction.

7.1.2 Design Timers, Not Every Element

You do not need to know exactly how a faction will act in session 12. Instead, give them a **timer** with a trigger condition.

“The Cult of the Eternal Night [6] advances when the players fail to protect a solar shrine or when the GM spends 2+ SB on occult activity.”

When the timer fills, the cult achieves its goal—and you improvise the specifics based on the current fiction.

7.1.3 Read Your Player Sheets

Your players have already given you the best campaign hooks. Look for:

- **Bonds:** “I owe my life to the Vault-Queen’s wardens.” → The Vault-Queen calls in the debt.
- **Complications:** “A sealed hold refuses you entry.” → That hold is now a key location.
- **Patrons:** Any Patron choice is a promise to involve that Patron’s agenda.
- **Skills at 3+:** If a player invested in Lore 3, they want to discover ancient secrets.

7.1.4 Use Obligation as a Story Engine

Obligation (to Patrons, terrestrial patrons, or even the party’s own Trust) is not a punishment—it is a **guarantee of future adventure**. When a player marks Obligation, note it. When their capacity is near full, introduce a demand.

“Your Patron, the Traveler, appears in a dream. The road to Highpass is washed out, and a pilgrim family is trapped. Guide them safely, and clear 2 Obligation. Refuse, and mark Fatigue 2—the road will not open for you again until you do.”

7.1.5 Embrace the Cascade

A single failure should never end the campaign. Instead, let it **cascade** into new problems.

The party fails to stop the ritual. The demon is summoned. Now the campaign is not “stop the ritual” but “contain the demon before it corrupts the capital.”

Each failure should change the situation, not end it.

7.1.6 Let Timers Be Visible

Timers are not hidden GM tools. Show them to the players. Write *Cult Influence* [6] on an index card and place it on the table. When you tick it, announce: “The cult’s ritual advances. You feel the ground tremble.”

Visible timers create **tension** and **informed choices**. Players can prioritize which timer to slow.

Physical Trackers for Timers

Use tactile tools to make timers visible and engaging:

- **Dry-erase boards or laminated sheets** with pre-drawn timer circles (4/6/8/10 segments). Mark ticks with a wet-erase marker.
- **Index cards with pie-chart wedges** drawn in pen; use a paperclip to mark current segment.
- **Poker chips or glass beads** placed on a numbered track from 0 to timer size.
- **Magnetic whiteboard with a timer template** and magnetic tokens.

Place the tracker in the center of the table where all players can see it. Tick it aloud: “*Ritual Completion* now at 3 of 6 segments.”

7.1.7 Ask Questions, Then Use the Answers

During Session Zero and between sessions, ask:

- “What does your character fear will happen if you fail this mission?”
- “Who in your past might try to stop you?”
- “What secret are you hiding from the rest of the party?”

Use these answers to seed complications. The player who fears losing their family? Their family is now in danger.

7.1.8 Design for Your Tier

- **Tier I–II (0–90 XP):** Local scope, 3–5 session arcs. Threats affect a village, a guild, a noble house.
- **Tier III (91–150 XP):** Regional scope, 6–10 session arcs. Threats affect a city, a province, a trade route.
- **Tiers IV–V (151+ XP):** Continental scope, 15+ session arcs. Threats affect nations, the natural order, reality itself.

Do not give a Tier I party a world-ending prophecy. Give them a rival who stole their map.

7.2 Core GM Mechanics

Understanding the core resolution loop is essential for effective campaign design. Every meaningful action follows this cycle:

1. Declare intent and approach (Attribute+Skill)
2. GM sets DV (2–5+) and Position (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate)
3. Roll dice pool (Attribute+Skill d10s)
4. Count successes (6–9=1 success; 10=2 successes)
5. Apply outcome using the Outcome Matrix
6. GM spends Story Beats (SB) to introduce complications

7.2.1 Difficulty Values (DV)

- **DV 2:** Routine—clear path, no pressure
- **DV 3:** Pressured—mild opposition (default)
- **DV 4:** Hard—serious resistance
- **DV 5+:** Extreme—dramatic gamble

Default DV is 3. Don't inflate DV to “challenge” players—use Position instead.

7.2.2 Position

Position tells you how risky the action is and changes how dice behave:

- **Dominant:** You press advantage—re-roll one failure
- **Controlled:** Balanced normal risk—no re-rolls
- **Desperate:** You act under duress—re-roll one success

Spending 1 Boon improves Position by one step before rolling. The GM may spend SB to worsen Position.

7.2.3 Outcome Matrix

- **Successes $\geq$ DV, SB=0:** Clean Success—Intent achieved, no complication
- **Successes $\geq$ DV, SB>0:** Success with SB—Intent achieved; GM spends SB
- **0 < Successes < DV:** Partial—Progress; gain 1 Boon
- **Successes = 0:** Miss—No progress; gain 2 Boons; GM spends SB

A Partial is not failure—it moves the story forward. A Miss is never “nothing happens.” The GM must introduce a complication.

7.2.4 Resources: Boons and Story Beats

Boons (Player Resource)

- Earned on Partial (1 Boon) or Miss (2 Boons)
- Maximum 5 Boons held; reduce to 2 at scene end (excess lost)
- Spent to: re-roll a die, activate an Asset, or improve Position by one step
- During downtime: convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (max 2 XP/session)

Story Beats (GM Resource)

- Earned when players roll a 1 on any die
- Spent to introduce complications:
 - 1 SB: Minor–noise, distraction, tick a 4–6 segment timer +1
 - 2 SB: Moderate–alarm raised, lose advantage, worsen Position
 - 3+ SB: Major–reinforcements, scene shifts, break an Asset
- Be aggressive with SB–unused pressure is wasted momentum

7.3 Campaign Tools

7.3.1 The Crown Spread (Session Zero)

The Crown Spread is a five-card (or six-card) oracular tool for seeding a campaign’s major elements. Use it during Session Zero or at the start of a new arc. It creates a web of relationships, not a railroad.

What You Need

- A standard 52-card deck (jokers optional).
- A table or whiteboard to record the spread.
- 15–20 minutes of quiet thinking.

The Spread Positions

Draw one card for each position. Lay them in a semicircle (the “Crown”).

Position	Card Drawn	What It Represents
Spade	(e.g., 5♠)	The Crown Site – where destiny is decided.
Heart	(e.g., Q♥)	The Crown Rival – who stands between the party and their goals.
Club	(e.g., 9♣)	The Crown Pressure – the relentless force that prevents complacency.
Diamond	(e.g., A♦)	The Crown Leverage – the advantage that can turn the tide.
Wild (draw a 6th card)	(e.g., K♠)	The Hidden Force – the unexpected element.

Interpreting the Cards

Use the suit to determine the nature of the element, then interpret the rank to refine it.

Quick Interpretation Guide

Spade (Site) – A place: ruin, bridge, forest, tower, cave, city district, crossroads.

Heart (Rival) – A person with emotional ties: family, former ally, rival, spurned lover, grieving widow.

Club (Pressure) – A resource or systemic threat: famine, plague, debt, war tax, blight, curse.

Diamond (Leverage) – An object or secret: a lost letter, a relic, a true name, a hidden passage, a witness.

Wild (Hidden) – Anything: a monster, a traitor, a natural disaster, a forgotten god, a second faction.

Rank guidance:

- **Ace – 3:** Minor scale, personal stakes.
- **4 – 6:** Moderate scale, affects a community.
- **7 – 10:** Major scale, threatens a region.
- **Jack – King:** Face cards suggest a named individual with personality and agenda.

Connecting the Elements

After the draw, ask yourself:

1. How does the Rival relate to the Site?
2. How does the Pressure affect the Site or Rival?
3. How can the Leverage help against the Pressure or Rival?
4. What does the Hidden Force want, and how does it complicate the others?

Draw a simple relationship map. You now have a campaign skeleton.

Timers for the Crown Spread

Create one visible timer for each element that will take time to resolve. Use these defaults:

Element	Sample Timer
Rival's Agenda	<i>[Rival Name]'s Consolidation</i> [6]
Pressure	<i>[Pressure Name] Spreads</i> [8]
Leverage (if it can be lost)	<i>[Leverage Name]'s Safety</i> [6]
Hidden Force (if it escalates)	<i>[Hidden Name]'s Awakening</i> [4]

Tick these timers during play when players fail relevant rolls or ignore the element. When a timer fills, that element's situation worsens dramatically.

GM Quick Cues

- **Don't over-plan.** The spread is a seed, not a script. Let players discover connections through play.
- **Be flexible.** If a better idea emerges, replace an element – the cards are oracles, not chains.
- **Use the Wild card for surprise.** Even you don't have to know what it is until it appears.
- **Tie every character to at least one element.** During Session Zero, ask each player: "How do you know about the Rival?" or "Why does the Pressure affect you personally?"

7.3.2 Timers: The GM's Primary Tool

Timers are the single most useful tool in Fate's Edge. Use them for:

- **Threats:** *Reinforcements Arrive* [4], *Ritual Completes* [6]
- **Opportunities:** *Alliance Forming* [6], *Weakness Discovered* [4]
- **Travel:** *Journey to the Pass* [8]
- **Social:** *The Duke's Patience* [4], *Rumor Spreads* [6]

When to Tick a Timer

- On a **Miss** or **Partial** – even if the player otherwise succeeds.
- When the GM spends **Story Beats** (1 SB = 1 tick typically).
- When the fiction demands it (e.g., "While you argue, the fire spreads").
- At the end of a session (for long-term timers like *Cult Influence*).

Timer Size Guidelines

- **4 segments:** Short-term tension (a patrol arrives, a door breaks).

- **6 segments:** Standard scene timer (a ritual completes, a rival escapes).
- **8 segments:** Multi-scene or session timer (a faction consolidates power).
- **10+ segments:** Campaign timer (a war, a prophecy, a curse).

7.3.3 Factions and Fronts

A **faction** is any organized group with goals that intersect the party's. A **front** is a collection of related factions and timers that represent a major threat.

Faction Sheet (Quick Template)

Faction Template	
Name:	_____
Agenda Timer :	[] (what they want to achieve)
Key NPCs:	(2–3 names and roles)
Resources:	(what they can bring to bear)
Ticking conditions:	(when does their timer advance?)
Visible tracks:	(list timers players can see)

Running Faction Turns

Between sessions (or at the start of a session), run a quick **faction turn** to keep the world alive. A faction turn takes 5–10 minutes.

1. **List active factions.** Keep no more than 3–5 that directly interact with the party.
2. **For each faction, roll 1d6.** Use the table below.
3. **Advance or retreat their Agenda Timer .**
4. **Note one concrete change.** Write one sentence per faction.
5. **Read the changes aloud** at the start of the next session.

Faction Progress Roll (d6)			
Roll	Progress	Agenda Timer Change	
1–2	Setback	–1 segment (min 0)	
3–4	Stalled	No change	
5–6	Advance	+1 segment	

Optional: Faction Standing

For factions that are not pursuing a single agenda but merely have an attitude, track a simple **-3 to +3 scale**:

- **-3:** Enemy – actively works against the party.
- **0:** Neutral – indifferent.
- **+3:** Ally – will sacrifice for the party.

Shift standing by ± 1 after major interactions. No dice needed – just fiction.

7.3.4 Rival Parties

A rival party is a faction of 3–5 NPCs with their own Patrons, assets, and a visible **Rival Agenda timer** (6–8 segments). Tick their timer when the PCs ignore them or the GM spends SB on their off-screen activities. When the timer fills, the rivals achieve a major milestone.

Reveal their progress through:

- **Rumors:** “The Ashen Cord was seen leaving the Sunstone vault.”
- **Found scenes:** A burned camp, a dead informant, a signature left behind.
- **Direct confrontation:** They show up during a critical moment.

For a full template and example (The Ashen Cord), see Appendix A.

7.4 Complications and Hazards

Complications are the narrative, mechanical, and environmental consequences that arise from failure, pressure, or the GM spending Story Beats. Hazards are ongoing complications that require action to avoid or mitigate.

7.4.1 Using Story Beats for Complications

When spending SB, follow this menu:

- **1 SB:** Minor pressure–noise, distraction, tick a relevant timer +1, worsen Position by one step
- **2 SB:** Moderate setback–alarm raised, lose cover/advantage, lesser foe appears, split the party briefly
- **3 SB:** Serious trouble–reinforcements arrive, key gear breaks (temporarily), major twist shifts the scene
- **4+ SB:** Scene-shaping turn–a trap springs, authority arrives, the environment changes dramatically, a Patron manifests an omen

7.4.2 Hazard Timers

Represent active hazards (fire, flooding, toxic gas) with Threat Timers:

- Tick the timer on missed rolls, GM SB spends, or at scene intervals
- When the timer fills, the hazard triggers (e.g., collapse, wave of fire)
- Characters may attempt to slow or disable the hazard (e.g., Tinker to seal a leak, Magic to freeze spreading flames)
- Treat as a Progress Timer when players work against it

7.4.3 Social Hazards

- **Rumors:** A timer that advances when the party fails social rolls; when full, a faction turns hostile
- **Scrutiny:** Worsens Position for stealth or deception
- **Reputation Damage:** Future social rolls start at worse Position

7.4.4 Magical Hazards

- **Backlash Zone:** An area where free casting automatically generates +1 SB per spell
- **Ward/Seal:** Requires a roll to pass; failure triggers a consequence (harm, alarm, etc.)
- **Leaking Veil:** Spirits or fey occasionally manifest spontaneously (GM spends SB to introduce)

7.5 Running Travel as a Medieval Trek

Travel in Fate's Edge is not a line on a map. It is a **medieval journey** – uncertain, weather-beaten, dependent on local guides, hospitality, and the kindness (or cruelty) of strangers. For full procedures (weather tables, road condition dice, regional decks), see the *Travel Guide* and *Player's Guide* Chapter 10. This section gives you the GM principles.

7.5.1 Lead with Weather, Not Distance

Open each leg with a weather description, then set Position based on that weather (e.g., Desperate for navigation in fog, Controlled for stealth in rain). The weather *is* the terrain.

7.5.2 Maps Are Lies; Guides Are Truth

Require a **Guide** role for each leg (PC or hired NPC). The Guide's roll (Wits + Survival or Lore) determines if they find the safe route, the short route, or the one that leads to a cultist ambush.

7.5.3 Hospitality as a Resource

When the party seeks shelter, draw a **Heart** from the regional deck – that’s the host. Their attitude affects what they offer. Spending a **String** (e.g., “I helped this village last year”) can improve the outcome.

7.5.4 The Travel Timer as Mood Tracker

Do not just tick the timer on successes. Use it to track the *feeling* of the journey (Optimism → Fatigue → Desperation → The Edge). When the timer fills, describe the arrival – mud-caked and grateful.

7.5.5 Genre Shifts Through Borders

When the party crosses from one region to another, the dominant fantasy subgenre shifts. Use the travel deck to introduce the new region’s flavor immediately (e.g., from Ecktoria’s political intrigue to the Mistlands’ folk horror: the road grows silent, fog rolls in, a bell tolls without wind).

7.5.6 Traveling Without a Map

Fate’s Edge does not use hex crawls. Travel is abstracted into **legs**, each with a Travel Timer (4, 6, 8, or 10 segments). You need only know how many **meaningful scenes** stand between two locations – not the miles.

7.5.7 Roles on the Road

Assign one role per character each leg. Roles may rotate each leg.

Role	Key Test	Benefit on Success
Guide	Wits+Survival	Tick the Travel Timer +1
Scout	Wits+Stealth	Party cannot be surprised on the first encounter of the leg
Quartermaster	Wits+Craft	Prevent one Supply drop or recover 1 spent Supply
Watch	Presence+Notice	Party gains +1 Position on the first defense roll of any ambush

Each role action requires a roll (Attribute+appropriate skill, DV set by the GM). Failure may tick the Travel Timer backwards or introduce a complication.

7.5.8 Encounters and Events

Every 1–2 segments filled, the GM introduces an encounter or hazard. At minimum, each leg should include one meaningful encounter.

Type	Examples	Typical Resolution
Discovery	Ruins, strange omens, hidden sites	Investigation or exploration roll
Hazard	Terrain challenge, illness, extreme weather	Survival or Endurance test; may use a hazard
Encounter	Bandits, emissaries, beasts, rival travelers	Combat or social resolution
Complication	Bond tested, supplies strained, pursuit gains ground	Roleplay or skill challenge

On a failed travel roll, the GM may spend SB to introduce an encounter immediately.

7.5.9 Supply and Depletion

Track shared party supplies with a Supply Timer [4]:

- Tick the timer when the Quartermaster fails a roll, when the GM spends SB on scarcity, or when the party is forced to march without resupply
- When the timer fills, the party runs out of a critical resource (food, water, fuel)
- Apply a Condition (Hungry, Thirsty, etc.) or mark 1 Fatigue per character
- Resupply at settlements, through successful foraging, or by spending a Cache token (see Asset rules)

7.5.10 Weather and Terrain Modifiers

The GM may apply modifiers based on conditions:

Condition	Effect
Difficult Terrain	Movement costs double; Charge/Skirmish requires open ground
Extreme Weather (rain, snow, heat)	First travel roll each leg is Desperate
Hazardous Weather (storm, blizzard, sandstorm)	Travel Timer ticks +1 at leg start; navigation DV +1
Favorable Weather	First travel roll each leg gains +1 Position

7.5.11 Foraging and Subsistence

A character may forage during a leg instead of taking a role action. Roll Wits+Survival (DV by terrain, typical 3–4):

- **Clean Success:** Gain 1 Supply
- **Partial:** Gain 1 Supply but mark 1 Fatigue (time or exposure)
- **Miss:** No Supply; GM gains 1 SB (scarce resources, dangerous plant, predator sign)

7.6 Pacing and Arc Structure

7.6.1 Session Energy Management

Aim for three “beats” per session:

1. **Opening hook** (5–10 minutes): Re-establish stakes, remind of timers.
2. **Rising action** (60–90 minutes): 2–3 scenes with escalating tension.
3. **Climax or cliffhanger** (20–30 minutes): A major roll, a timer filling, or a hard choice.

7.6.2 Arc Length by Tier

- **Tier I–II (0–90 XP):** 3–5 session arcs. Local scope, personal stakes.
- **Tier III (91–150 XP):** 6–10 session arcs. Regional influence, branching paths.
- **Tiers IV–V (151+ XP):** 15+ session arcs. Continental scope, world-shaping consequences.

7.6.3 Between Sessions: The GM’s Sacred Trust

Between sessions, update timers, track complication debt, and prepare scenes. Use the *Between-Session Checklist* in the GM’s Appendix. Remember: your preparation is the quiet magic that transforms random encounters into meaningful episodes.

Between-Session Checklist

1. **Update timers:** Tick any faction, travel, or campaign timers based on last session’s outcomes.
2. **Check complication debt:** Note any unresolved player Complications; they add +1 SB to the next session’s first scene.
3. **Prepare 2–3 flexible scenes:** Not scripts, but situations with a clear stake and a timer.
4. **Review player goals:** Look at Bonds, Patron obligations, and personal arcs. Seed at least one hook per player.
5. **Refresh your memory:** Re-read the session summary from last time (ask a player to recap if you didn’t write one).

7.6.4 The Three-Timer Rule

At any given time, maintain at most three active timers in a scene:

1. **Situation Timer:** Immediate goal (persuasion, escape, research)
2. **Counter-Clock:** Opposition pressure (guards arriving, ritual completing)
3. **Campaign Timer:** Long-term front (faction rise, curse spreading)

Merge or retire additional timers. Timers are visible; name them and tick them in front of players.

7.7 The Finale: Calling or Forcing the Crown

The campaign reaches its crescendo when one of two thresholds is met—the moment when accumulated influence and mounting pressure collide in a final reckoning.

Finale Triggers and Conditions

Finale Type	Conditions and Narrative Implications
Player-Called	Mandate ≥ 6 and Crisis ≤ 3 – the party has earned the right to choose their moment of triumph.
Forced Finale	Crisis ≥ 6 regardless of Mandate – the world forces a confrontation that can no longer be avoided.
Balanced Finale	Both dials at 4–5 – a tense equilibrium where victory and defeat hang in perfect balance.

7.7.1 The Finale Procedure

When the Crown is called, run the three-beat finale:

1. **Reckoning:** Defend or sanctify the record of accomplishments. Draw upon the Rival's established motives. Place the Pressure rail that will drive the scene forward.
2. **Crossing:** Stage the kinetic rail (Escape/Hunt/Hazard) that threatens to end the scene prematurely if not managed carefully.
3. **Coronation:** Use the Diamond Leverage to sign, seal, or swear the oath that cements the campaign's legacy.

7.7.2 Twist Collision (Finale Clause)

Exactly once, when the Rival's Spade Twist contradicts their Club Belief, the table chooses:

- GM gains +1 SB to complicate matters, or

- Players reduce two ticks total across the active rails, gaining breathing room.

7.8 Legacy Conversion: Epilogue

After the Finale, each PC draws 2 cards and answers epilogue prompts by suit. Then convert campaign elements into lasting legacy:

- **Major Asset** → **Institution** (12 XP): A safehouse becomes a school, a spy ring becomes an intelligence service.
- **Seasonal Endorsement** → **Doctrine Rider** (4 XP): Temporary support becomes permanent policy.
- **Follower (Cap 3+)** → **Stationed NPC** (0 XP): Loyal companions become custodians of the new order.
- **Rival** → **Fixture**: Surviving adversaries become recurring elements of the setting's fabric.

7.8.1 The Legacy Bond

When a PC retires or dies, their successor (a follower or a new character) inherits a **Legacy Bond**. This bond represents the predecessor's enduring influence. Once per session, the player may invoke the Legacy Bond to gain **1 Boon** when acting to uphold the predecessor's values or complete their unfinished business.

7.8.2 Character Arc Management

Help players develop meaningful character growth through the legacy process:

1. **Establishment**: Define the character's current state and potential conflicts.
2. **Development**: Create opportunities for growth and choice.
3. **Crisis**: Present challenges that test the character's core beliefs.
4. **Resolution**: Allow meaningful transformation based on choices.

Arcs Generate Obligation and Patron Interest

A character's personal arc should not exist in a vacuum. Tie it directly to the game's resource systems:

- **Internal arcs** (fear, doubt, guilt) are perfect sources of *Corruption* or *Obligation*.
- **External arcs** (revenge, ambition, love) create *Debt Timers* with terrestrial patrons or generate *Crisis*.
- **Whenever a player advances their arc, mark +1 Obligation to a relevant Patron or tick a Patron's Interest timer.**

7.9 Quick Start Campaigns

7.9.1 The Sunstone Gambit (Tier I–II, 4–6 sessions)

A medium-difficulty introduction set in Acasia. **Premise:** A scholar hires the party to retrieve a sunstone from a ruined tower before a rival adventuring company does. **Key NPCs:** Scholar Mira (quest-giver), Captain Voss (rival leader), the Tower’s Guardian (ancient spirit). **Timers:** *Rival Progress* [6], *Tower Collapse* [8], *Spirit Wakening* [4]. **Session breakdown:** Commission → Travel → Exploration → Confrontation → Climax → Aftermath.

7.9.2 The Dying Sun (Tier III–IV, 6–8 sessions)

A regional crisis campaign. The sun-spirit is fading; a cult of eternal night seeks to extinguish it permanently. **Premise:** The party must rally factions, recover a lost ritual, and confront the cult before the winter solstice. **Key NPCs:** High Priestess of the Sun, Cult Shadow-bound, Reluctant Ykrul Chieftain. **Timers:** *Sun’s Fading* [10] (ticks each session), *Cult Influence* [6], *Alliance of the Dawn* [8]. **Acts:** Investigate the cult → Gather allies → Raid the cult’s lair → Final confrontation.

7.10 Campaign Worksheet

Use this one-page worksheet to capture your campaign’s key elements.

Campaign Worksheet	
Campaign Name:	_____
Starting Tier:	_____ Estimated Sessions: _____
Crown Spread:	
Spade (Site):	
Heart (Rival):	
Club (Pressure):	Factions (name, agenda timer, key NPCs):
Diamond (Leverage):	
Wild (Hidden):	
Fronts (name, agenda timer, supporting timers, stakes):	
Mandate: 0/6 Crisis: 0/6	
Player Hooks (from sheets):	

Notes: _____

7.11 Narrative First: The World Remembers

Campaign design in Fate's Edge is not about railroading players along predetermined paths—it's about **responding to player choices** with consequences that accumulate like stones in a river, gradually shaping the flow of the narrative itself. Let the world shift in response to their actions. Let factions rise and fall based on their allegiances. Let the dice sing the song of a universe that reacts.

And when the Crown is finally crowned—when the last card is played and the final timer ticks to completion—let the echo of that moment be heard across the entire Amaranthine, a testament to stories well-lived and consequences fully earned.

Remember: Your preparation between sessions is the quiet magic that transforms random encounters into meaningful episodes and mechanical challenges into memorable stories. The investment in this sacred trust pays dividends in player engagement, narrative coherence, and the creation of campaigns that will be remembered long after the final dice have been rolled.

Chapter 8

Tier IV and V: Running Epic Adventures

As characters reach Tier IV and V, the game changes. The scope expands from local concerns to regional, national, or world-shaking events. This chapter focuses on how to run these epic tiers effectively, with special attention to how the game **naturally scales** through Boon scarcity – not inflated Difficulty Values.

8.1 What Changes at Tier IV–V

- **Scope:** Actions affect cities, nations, or the entire known world.
- **Consequences:** Failure can shift political borders, end bloodlines, or awaken ancient horrors.
- **Time:** Campaigns often span months or years, with downtime becoming a major phase.
- **Legacy:** Characters become legends – their deeds echo for generations.

The core mechanics remain the same. The difference is **weight** – every success and every failure reshapes the fiction in larger, more permanent ways.

8.2 Natural Scaling: The Boon Economy Does the Work

One of Fate’s Edge’s most elegant features is how it automatically scales difficulty without inflating numbers. At high tiers, characters have large dice pools (often 8–10 dice). They succeed more often and generate fewer Misses and Partial – the primary sources of Boons.

Boon Generation Basics (Reminder)

- **Miss (0 successes):** Gain 2 Boons.
- **Partial ($0 < \text{successes} < \text{DV}$):** Gain 1 Boon.
- **Clean Success ($\text{successes} \geq \text{DV}$, $\text{SB} = 0$):** No Boons.
- **Success with SB ($\text{successes} \geq \text{DV}$, $\text{SB} > 0$):** No Boons.

Boons do not come from winning. They come from *struggling*.

Boon Availability by Tier (Typical)

Tier	Avg. Boons earned per scene	Typical use
I (0–40 XP)	2–3	Re-rolls, minor advantages
II (41–90 XP)	1–2	Re-rolls, asset activation
III (91–150 XP)	1	Critical rerolls, story shifts
IV (151–220 XP)	0–1	Rare, decisive actions
V (221+ XP)	0–1 (often 0)	Mythic choices only

Why This Works

- **Low-tier characters need the help.** Their small pools produce unreliable results; Boons give them a cushion.
- **High-tier characters must rely on skill, not luck.** With huge pools and reliable success, they no longer have a safety net.
- **The scarcity creates strategic depth.** At high levels, spending a Boon on a re-roll means you cannot activate your spy network later. Every Boon is a meaningful choice.

Why Brittleness is Good

At high tiers, your power comes from skill, not luck. Fewer Boons mean every roll matters. This is intentional – embrace the tension.

The simulation insights show that **chaos players thrived at high tier** because they understood this. They did not hoard Boons; they accepted scarcity and adapted by:

- Relying on high Skills and clever positioning.
- Using Bonds to generate Boons when needed.
- Spending Boons only on critical moments.

A "brittle" character – one with few resources but immense competence – is not a flaw. It is the design. It makes every decision weighty and every success earned.

Let the dice fall. Let the Boons be precious. Let the tension sing.

Do Not Increase Boon Awards

Resist the urge to give out extra Boons because players "look cool" or "rolled a 10." The scarcity is intentional. It makes high-tier play feel tense and consequential. If you inject Boons, you remove the resource pressure that defines epic play.

Example: Tier I vs. Tier V

A Tier I rogue picks a lock (DV 3, 5 dice). She rolls a Miss → gains 2 Boons, re-rolls, succeeds. A Tier V master thief picks the same lock (DV 3, 10 dice). He rolls a Clean Success → no Boons. Later, he fails a critical roll to disable a ward – he has only 1 Boon left. He must decide: re-roll this roll, or save it for the escape. The tension is real.

8.3 Do Not Inflate Difficulty Values**Warning: DV Inflation Breaks High-Tier Play**

A higher DV does not mean "more challenging" – it means "fewer Partials, fewer Boons, faster escalation." At high tiers, players have large pools, but raising DV to 5 or 6 will starve them of Boons entirely and make failure feel arbitrary.

Scale Challenge With These Tools Instead:

- **Timers:** Add a 4–6 segment timer to the scene (*Palace Coup* [4], *Ritual Completion* [6]). Players see it tick.
- **Position:** Worsen Position when the fiction demands danger. A Desperate roll already re-rolls successes – that is plenty.
- **Consequences:** Use SB to add layered costs (see ??).
- **Faction Timers:** Advance long-term threats (*War* [8]) regardless of player success in individual scenes (see 2.3).

When Is a Higher DV Appropriate?

Only when the *fiction* itself demands it: a god's impossible ward, a lock designed by a legendary artisan, a ritual that twists reality. Even then, keep it to DV 5–6 and telegraph clearly: "This is a mythic challenge. Even with your power, it may fail."

8.4 Failure Must Matter

At high tiers, a failed roll should never mean "nothing happens." Instead:

- **A rival gains leverage.** "You cannot open the vault, but you see the Duke's sigil on the lock – he knows someone inside."
- **A secret becomes public.** "Your investigation fails, but the guard captain mentions your name to a reporter."
- **A faction timer advances.** "The ritual continues. *Summoning* [8] ticks +1."
- **An asset is compromised.** "Your safehouse is discovered – it is now *Neglected*."

If failure merely delays action without changing the situation, you are not using the system to its full potential.

8.5 Using Bonds as the Primary Boon Engine

At high tiers, Boons should mainly come from **Bond-driven actions** (see 3.3.1). Encourage players to:

- Call on Bonds in difficult moments: "I owe you – I ask for your help now."
- Expose allies or followers to danger to gain Boons.
- Accept new obligations or narrative fallout in exchange for Boons.

Example: Bonded Allies Transferring Boons

The party faces a mythic guardian. Sariel, the rogue, has 0 Boons left. Kestra, the mage, has 2 Boons but is pinned at range. They share a Bond ("She saved me from the shadow cult.")

Kestra: "I spend my action to transfer 2 Boons to Sariel. As I channel, I shout: 'Remember the Forge – you owe me!'"
GM: "The Bond flares. Sariel receives 2 Boons. Spend them wisely."

Sariel uses 1 Boon to re-roll a failed stealth check and 1 Boon to improve her Position to Dominant. She slips past the guardian and disables the trap.

This turns a Bond from backstory into a tactical resource. At high tiers, such exchanges are the difference between victory and defeat.

8.6 Designing High-Tier Scenes

When planning an epic scene, ask:

1. **What changes if the characters succeed?**
2. **What compromises emerge on a Partial success?**
3. **What new dangers arise on a Miss?**

If the answer to "Miss" is "they try again," increase the stakes, not the DV.

Example Scene: The Royal Vote

The party tries to convince the council to declare war on a neighboring realm.

- **Clean Success:** The vote passes; the army marches under their banner.

- **Success with SB:** The vote passes, but a rival is appointed general.
- **Partial:** The vote is delayed; new timer *Council Deadlock [4]* appears.
- **Miss:** The vote fails. The rival declares war anyway – without the party’s leadership.

No DV was inflated. The stakes did the work.

8.7 Pacing and Scope

Embrace Longer Timelines

Time becomes a tool. Use downtime to:

- Advance faction timers.
- Allow rumors to spread.
- Let players build legacies (fortresses, guilds, schools).

Abstract the Mundane

At high tiers, do not roll for climbing walls or picking common locks. Assume competence. Save rolls for choices that matter.

Let Players Command Armies

Treat armies as high-Cap followers (see 3.4). Use **Battle Timers** (4–6 segments) for skirmishes. Do not resolve each soldier’s attack – abstract with leadership rolls.

8.8 Caveats and Warnings

- **Do not design adventures like Tier I.** Linear dungeons and small-scale fetch quests feel beneath legendary heroes. Instead, give them systemic problems: a curse that erases memory, a political schism, a dying god.
- **Do not hoard Boons.** Spend SB and optional Threat Pool points (see) to create memorable moments. Players earned their power – challenge them with creative complications, not starvation.
- **Do not fall into "superhero" mode.** The world should still react believably. A legendary warrior can be assassinated in their sleep. A master mage can be outmaneuvered politically.

8.9 Tools for Managing Boon Scarcity

High-tier play demands that GMs and players rethink how Boons are used. The following tools help make scarcity feel tense, not frustrating.

Boon-Worthy Moments (Player Guidance)

At Tier IV–V, a Boon should never be spent on a trivial re-roll. Instead, reserve Boons for:

- **Negating a catastrophic failure** (e.g., re-rolling a Miss that would kill an ally).
- **Activating a key Asset** (e.g., calling in a spy network to reveal a weakness).
- **Shifting Position from Desperate to Controlled** before a mythic roll.
- **Powering a Prestige or Epic talent** that changes the scene.

GM tip: Remind players of this at the start of each high-tier session.

The "Substituting Fatigue for Boons" Rule (Revisited)

Recall that a player may pay 1 Fatigue instead of 1 Boon (see Section 3.3.3). At high tiers, this becomes a lifeline. Encourage players to use it, but attach a narrative cost: "You push through the pain, but your hand trembles – your next roll is at Desperate Position."

Follower Sacrifice as Boon Substitute

A loyal follower (Cap 3+) can take the consequence of a failed roll in place of a Boon. The follower suffers Harm 1 (or a Condition) and the player avoids spending a Boon. This should be used sparingly (once per session maximum) and only when the fiction supports it.

Let the Roll Stand

At high tiers, players may reflexively reach for Boons to re-roll failures. Sometimes, the most dramatic outcome is to **let the failure stand**. As GM, you can say: "You have 0 Boons left. The die is cast. What does failure look like?" This forces players to engage with consequences rather than erase them.

Example: A High-Tier Turn with 0 Boons

The party's archmage, Jora (Tier V), attempts to counterspell a world-ending ritual. She has 0 Boons. She rolls 8 dice (Wits 5 + Arcana 3) vs DV 4. Result: 3 successes – a Partial.

- **Without Boons:** She cannot re-roll. The GM rules: "The ritual slows, but a backlash rips through the ley lines. A nearby village is consumed by wild magic. You save the world, but at

a cost."

- **If she had a Boon:** She could re-roll a failure and possibly achieve a Clean Success, avoiding the backlash.

The scarcity of Boons made the Partial outcome feel meaningful, not like a failure.

Physical Trackers for Boon Scarcity

To make Boon scarcity visible and tactile:

- Use a **small bowl or tray** in the center of the table with poker chips representing the *party's* total Boons (players still track individual Boons, but a shared visual reinforces scarcity).
- When a player spends a Boon, they physically move a chip to a "spent" pile. When they earn a Boon, they add a chip.
- For high-tier sessions, set a **table limit of 3 Boons maximum per player** (down from 5). This makes each chip precious.

8.10 Optional Epic Tools (Brief)

The following are covered in other chapters or appendixes:

- **Boss Generator** – See Appendix F (in the full GM's Guide) for a card-based tool to create mythic adversaries.
- **Legacy Projects** – See Chapter 3 for long-term timers that span sessions.
- **Mythic Martial Tags** – Player-facing epic talents for warriors; see Chapter 6 of the *Player's Guide*.
- **Mass Combat** – See optional rules in Appendix G for battle timers and army followers.

The Mythic Failure Table (d12)

When a high-tier character fails a pivotal roll, describe a consequence from this table (or invent your own).

d12 Consequence

- 1 An innocent dies because of your failure.
- 2 A rival claims the victory instead of you.
- 3 An artifact shatters, releasing a curse or a new threat.
- 4 Your reputation is damaged – lose 1 Mandate (if using, see 3.6.7).
- 5 An ally is captured or turned against you.
- 6 The problem spreads – a new timer appears (*Crisis* [4]).
- 7 A Patron withdraws favor – lose access to one Rite until you atone.
- 8 A faction declares you an enemy – start a *Vendetta* [6] timer.
- 9 The land itself is wounded – a region becomes blighted or uninhabitable.
- 10 You lose a memory or a cherished belonging (GM chooses).
- 11 A prophecy twists – your success now serves a dark purpose you cannot yet see.
- 12 Your failure opens a door – something ancient and hungry awakens.

8.11 Sample High-Tier Scenario: The Dying Sun

Premise: The realm’s patron sun-spirit is fading. Without it, crops fail, undead rise, and the land dies.

Scope: Continental.

Timers:

- *Sun’s Fading* [10] – ticks each session, faster if neglected.
- *Cult of Eternal Night* [6] – a faction that worships the darkness.
- *Alliance of the Dawn* [8] – political support for a ritual to save the sun.

Success: The party finds a lost relic, performs a ritual, and restores the sun – but must choose a cost (e.g., their own lifespans, a Patron’s demand).

Partial: The sun is saved, but the cult is not destroyed – they will return.

Miss: The sun dies. The party must lead a desperate exodus or accept a dark bargain for a new light.

This scenario cannot be solved by a single roll. It requires investigation, diplomacy, combat, and sacrifice – perfect for epic tier play.

8.12 Final Thought

At Tier IV and V, your players are no longer adventurers – they are **legends in the making**. Honor their power by giving them problems that require wisdom, sacrifice, and creativity to solve.

The dice still matter. Consequences still flow. But now, every choice echoes across nations and generations.

Make it legendary.

Chapter 9

Advanced GM Techniques

This chapter assumes you have mastered Fate’s Edge core rules. It offers tools for GMs running **experienced groups and higher-tier campaigns (Tier III+)**. If you are new to the game, start with earlier chapters.

9.1 Advanced Story Beat Management

Story Beats (SB) are your primary tool for escalating tension. At high tiers, you will have more SB to spend – but also more narrative threads to manage.

You Are Not Limited by SB

SB are a pacing tool, not a budget. If the story needs a complication, introduce it. SB just tells you when players *want* escalation (by rolling 1s) and gives you a reservoir to draw from. Do not hoard SB; spend them freely to keep scenes dynamic.

Example: The party is interrogating a prisoner. Even without a roll, you sense the scene dragging. Spend 1 SB: “The prisoner’s eyes dart to the window – a signal. Someone is listening.” No roll, no budget – just pacing.

Spending SB Across Multiple Threads

Instead of pouring all SB into one complication, distribute them across several active timers or fronts (see 2.3). A scene might have:

- *Alarm Raised [4]* – advances from noise or failed stealth.
- *Rival Closing In [6]* – advances from delays or loud magic.
- *Patron Attention [8]* – advances each time a Rite is invoked.

Each Miss or Partial can tick one or two small timers instead of a single big setback. This keeps pressure distributed and gives players multiple problems to solve.

Using SB to Advance Campaign Fronts

When a scene directly relates to a long-term front (e.g., a war, a spreading curse), spend SB to advance that front’s timer – even if the scene is otherwise a “success”. Example: The party defeats a cultist cell (clean success), but you spend 2 SB to tick *Cult Influence* [6] – their network still grows elsewhere.

Banked SB from Player Complications

Characters may start sessions with banked SB from unresolved complications (see). These count toward scene spending limits but should be spent on **thematic complications tied to that character’s background or Patron**, not generic setbacks. This makes personal storylines matter.

Example: Cascade Spend

A single Miss generates 2 SB. The GM:

1. Spends 1 SB to advance *Alarm Raised* [4] by 1 (now 2/4 – guards are converging).
2. Spends 1 SB to advance *Rival Closing In* [6] by 1 (now 3/6 – rival scouts are spotted).
3. Both timers are now half full – the scene’s tension doubles without a single “big” complication.

9.2 Mastering the Deck of Consequences

The deck is not just a randomizer; it is a **thematic engine**. Use it to keep complications fresh and unpredictable, even at high tiers.

Shortcut Table: Suit + Rank → *TypicalComplication*

Use this table for fast interpretation at the table.

Suit	Low (2–5)	High (J–A)
Hearts (Emotion/Social)	Awkward social moment, minor suspicion	Betrayal, scandal, broken trust
Spades (Physical/Harm)	Bruise, small gear damage, stumble	Serious injury, structural collapse
Clubs (Resource/Cost)	Minor loss (rations, a few coins)	Major asset destroyed, debt called
Diamonds (Magic/Spiritual)	Omen, eerie noise, minor curse	Patron demand, reality bend

Table 9.1: Shortcut table: Suit + Rank → *TypicalComplication*

Combining Draws (Suit Synthesis)

Draw up to 3 cards per SB spend (minimum 1, maximum 3). Synthesize a single twist from the combination of suits, not just the highest rank.

- **Hearts + Spades:** Emotional betrayal that leads to physical harm (“Your ally flees, and the portcullis drops on you.”)
- **Clubs + Diamonds:** Resource drain with magical backlash (“The ritual consumes your healing herbs and leaves a tainted scar.”)
- **Hearts + Clubs + Spades:** Social pressure plus resource loss plus injury – a crowd riots and loots your gear.

Using the Deck for Non-Linear Scenes

Draw a card to inspire flashbacks, montages, or off-screen events. Example: During downtime, draw a Clubs card – “A fire at your safehouse.” Instead of playing it, you narrate a short scene of the party arriving to find the aftermath. The deck becomes a prompt generator, not merely a roll-aftermath tool.

Custom Suit Tables

For a specific campaign or region, replace the default suit meanings with custom ones. Example – Shadow Court campaign:

- **Hearts:** Vows and obligations.
- **Spades:** Physical traps and barriers.
- **Clubs:** Political pressure and blackmail.
- **Diamonds:** Oaths and geasa.

This reflavors the deck without changing its structure.

9.3 Adjudicating Thresholds

Thresholds – doorways, crossroads, riverbanks, the space between waking and sleeping – are where the world’s memory is thinnest. When a player announces “I cross the threshold,” you need a consistent way to respond.

Common Threshold Types and Their Effects

Use this table as a reference. The effects are narrative nudges, not rigid rules.

Threshold	Typical Effect	SB Spend Opportunity
Doorway (unwarded)	Position worsens one step (attention from spirits)	1 SB: door leads to wrong room
Doorway (warded)	Resolve test (DV 3) or mark Fatigue	2 SB: ward triggers (Harm 1)
Crossroads	GM asks a “choice” question; answer becomes true	3 SB: a stranger appears with a bargain
Riverbank	Roll Spirit + Survival; success gives omen	2 SB: spirit from the water surfaces
Bridge	The bridge “remembers” – ask a past event	3 SB: bridge’s toll is a memory
Sleep/waking edge	Player narrates a dream; GM gains 1 SB	4 SB: dream becomes real for a scene

Table 9.2: Common threshold types and their effects

Threshold Timers

For a location that is heavily liminal (a haunted manor, a fey crossing), start a **Threshold Instability [4–6]** timer. Tick it each time a player crosses a threshold without proper respect (no offering, no announced name). When the timer fills, the threshold inverts: doors open to the wrong places, the dead walk, or the party is lost in a mirror realm.

Player-Driven Thresholds

When a player says “I act at the threshold,” encourage them to be specific: “I open the door with my left hand” or “I step over the river stone.” Use that fiction to set Position. A respectful crossing (removing boots, pouring a libation) may start Controlled; a brash crossing starts Desperate.

9.4 Faction Grand Strategy

At high tiers, factions act as “campaign engines.” Build them with **faction timers** that advance whether the players intervene or not.

Faction Timer Examples

- **War [8]** – Advances when battles occur or supply lines are cut.
- **Influence [6]** – Advances when allies are won or propaganda spreads.
- **Intrigue [8]** – Advances when secrets are uncovered or betrayals happen.

These timers are **visible to players** – they see the war brewing, even if they cannot stop it alone.

Player Actions and Faction Timers

When players act, they can tick a faction timer forward or backward. Example: Sabotaging a siege engine ticks *War* -1 (enemy's timer) and ticks *Their Own Mandate* $+1$ (see 3.6.7). Document these changes openly. The world becomes a reactive board.

Running a “Faction Turn” Between Sessions

For a highly political campaign, between sessions you can:

- Ask players for their faction's orders (e.g., “Send spies to the capital”).
- Roll a single die per order (Pass/Fail/Partial) using the faction's relevant Asset (e.g., Spy Ring).
- Advance faction timers accordingly.
- Start the next session with a brief “news from the front” segment.

This makes factions feel alive without heavy bookkeeping.

Example: Faction Turn with Rivals

The rival party **The Ashen Cord** has their own faction timer: *Cord's Agenda* [6]. During the faction turn:

- The GM rolls for the Cord's order: “Secure the Sunstone fragment.”
- The roll is a Partial. The Cord finds the fragment but leaves evidence (tracks, a witness).
- The GM ticks *Cord's Agenda* by 1 and notes: “A merchant in Silkstrand saw a scarred woman matching Vesper's description.”
- At the next session, the players hear the rumor. They now have a choice: pursue the Cord or stay on their own path.

9.5 Advanced Timer Design

Timers become more powerful when they interact. Use the following patterns to create tension that players must actively manage.

Interacting Timers

Two timers that affect each other. Example: *Ritual Progress* [6] and *Cult Interference* [4]. Ticking one may automatically tick the other, or players can choose which to slow.

Cascading Timers

When one timer fills, it creates another. Example: *Security Alert [4]* fills → *Reinforcements Arrive [6]* appears. *This moment*

Hidden Consequences Behind Success

Even a clean success can tick a long-term timer. Example: The party assassinates a cult leader (clean success). Off-screen, *Cult of the Martyr [8]* ticks +2 – the death radicalizes the remaining followers.

9.6 Designing High-Tier Custom Content

At Tiers IV–V, characters can reshape nations and realities. Custom content should grant **narrative permissions**, not merely bigger numbers.

Epic Talents (12+ XP)

An epic talent might:

- Allow rewriting one line of a Patron’s Rite (changing its cost or effect).
- Grant a once-per-session “truth edit” – the GM must accept one factual change to the scene.
- Let a character invoke a Patron’s name to retroactively avoid a TPK (once per campaign, with heavy cost).

These are not combat bonuses – they change what kind of story is being told.

Assets for Ruling Nations

A Major Asset (12 XP) might be a kingdom. Its free use could be “order a levy” or “declare a holiday”. Its scene surge (1 Boon) could be “call in a noble favor” or “divert a river”. Such assets come with obvious upkeep (taxes, succession, rebellions) – and they can be threatened or lost.

Adventures for Demigods

At the highest tiers, stakes should threaten **concepts**, not just lives. Examples:

- A curse that erases the memory of a city.
- A war that will redraw the map for centuries.
- A Patron who will change the fundamental laws of magic.

Victory may not be guaranteed – but even failure should leave a permanent mark on the world.

9.7 Running Mythic Scenarios (Tiers IV–V)

At the apex of power, the game changes. Use these techniques to keep play grounded in choices, not points.

Handling Reality-Altering Magic

When a player attempts something cosmic (e.g., “I wish the volcano had never erupted”), do not say no. Instead, offer a **compromise**:

- “You can do it, but it will cost you your connection to this place – you will never return.”
- “It works, but for the remainder of the session, the world is unstable – every roll generates an extra SB.”
- “You succeed, but your Patron demands a permanent sacrifice – one of your Talents is erased.”

The effect happens, but the price is felt.

Player Agency at Cosmic Scale

At Tier V

Embrace this. Let players narrate what they are saving (or sacrificing) when they act.

Example: “I stop the ritual – but I let the rival escape.” That rival becomes a future problem. “I save the city – but I lose my connection to my Patron.” Now the player has a new arc: how to regain favor or find a new source of power.

Let the world break. If the climax involves a collapsing reality, the battlefield itself can be a timer. Example: *Reality Fracture* [8]. Each time a major event occurs (a spell, a death, an oath), tick the timer. When it fills, the scene shifts – time loops, gravity reverses, or the characters meet themselves from another timeline.

Let the World Break (Timer Example)

Set a visible timer: **Reality Fracture** [8]. Tick it when:

- A character invokes a Patron’s name in desperation.
- A major magical effect is attempted.
- A character makes a life-or-death choice.

At 4 segments, strange echoes appear (ghostly duplicates, time slips). At 8 segments, the scene transforms: gravity inverts, doors lead to wrong locations, or the party faces an alternate version of themselves.

9.8 Managing Cross-Patron and Invoker Conflicts

When a character serves multiple Patrons (e.g., an Invoker with several Symbols, or a Runekeeper who also carries a Symbol), their obligations can conflict.

Signs of Cross-Resonance

- A Symbol grows warm when another is used.
- Dreams become fragmented – two Patrons arguing in metaphor.
- Rites from one Patron cost +1 Obligation because the other Patron is “watching.”

Resolving Conflicts Mechanically

If a character invokes two conflicting Patrons in the same scene, the GM may:

- Increase the DV of the second Rite by 1 (the Weave resists).
- Tick a *Patron Jealousy* [4] timer. When it fills, one Patron demands the character renounce the other (or pay a heavy price).
- Offer a Devil’s Bargain: “You can use both, but mark 2 Fatigue and the GM gains 2 SB.”

Narrative Resolution

Encourage players to roleplay the tension. A character who serves both the Traveler and Malachai might struggle with whether to take a shortcut (Traveler) that feeds a cursed addiction (Malachai). Use these moments to advance character arcs, not just punish mechanics.

9.9 Player-Managed Modules at High Tiers

At high tiers, players track more resources: multiple Obligation segments per Patron, Corruption timers, Asset conditions, and often a Cord or Hollowed. Remind the table of the following responsibilities (see also Section 2.6 of the *GM Guide*):

- **Players declare thresholds.** “My Obligation just hit capacity” triggers an immediate effect. The GM should not have to ask.
- **Players maintain their own Asset states.** If a Safehouse is neglected, the player should note it and inform the GM when it is used.
- **Players track their own Corruption Blooms.** When a Cantor’s Corruption Timer fills, the player chooses (or rolls) the new trait and enforces its roleplay cost.

The GM’s job is to **spot-check** – occasionally ask “What’s your current Obligation to Malachai?” – and to **enforce consequences** when a threshold is crossed. Never hunt for a player’s misplaced

number. If they forget a resource, assume it is in their favor (they have it) but the story may suffer a small twist.

9.10 Advanced Complex Scenarios

Heists: Player-Designed Plans

Instead of planning the heist for them, ask each player: “How does your character contribute to the plan?” Build a timer (e.g., *Heist Progress* [8]). Each player makes a roll using their chosen method (Stealth, Deception, Arcana, etc.). Success ticks the timer; failure adds complications (alarm, guard alerted). The GM spends SB from misses to introduce obstacles from the security system.

Mass Combat: Unit Timers

Instead of rolling for every soldier, treat opposing armies as a single *War Timer* [8]. Player actions (command, sabotage, rally) tick the timer. When it fills, that side breaks or routs. Personal combat can happen in the same scene – but the mass conflict is abstracted to a single visible tracker.

Political Intrigue: Reputation as a Resource

Track a *Reputation Timer* [6] for the party in a given court. Social actions (gossip, favors, public deeds) tick it. When it fills, they become “trusted” – they can call in a major favor before the timer resets. But enemies also watch their rise, and may work to degrade the timer.

9.11 When to Say Yes, No, and Yes, But – Advanced Rulings

At high levels, players will attempt things that break normal bounds. Use these frameworks.

Compromise Solutions

Instead of a flat “no”, offer a **scaled success** with a cost:

- **Yes, but only for this scene.**
- **Yes, but you must mark a permanent Condition.**
- **Yes, but it will take longer – start a timer.**
- **Yes, but the GM gains 3 SB to spend on that effect.**

This keeps creativity alive while respecting the game’s tension economy.

Saying “No” Without Shutting Down

If a plan is impossible (e.g., “I kill the god with a single arrow”), explain why: “The god is not physically present; you would need to unmake its last shrine first.” Then offer a path: “If you find the shrine and perform a ritual, you could banish it – you’ll need to gather three relics.” Turn the “no” into a new arc.

Let the Dice Decide – But Hedge

For a truly impossible request, set an **extreme DV (6+)** and a **Desperate Position**. If they succeed, they get a lesser version of what they wanted, or a temporary victory. This respects the dice while maintaining verisimilitude.

GM Golden Rule for Advanced Play

The mechanics are not a ceiling – they are scaffolding. Build taller stories with them, but never let them crush creativity.

Part IV

Lore and Reference

Chapter 10

The Known World: A Lore Compendium

Using This Compendium

You only need to read the region your campaign is set in. The generators (see the separate *Travel Guide*) will provide the rest.

Quick reference by subgenre and typical conflict:

Region	Fantasy Subgenre	Typical Conflict
Acasia	Low fantasy / mercenary realism	Feuding warlords, mercenary flips, the Curse
Aelaerem	Folk horror / pastoral dark	The Neighbors, clan feuds, harvest famine
Aeler	Industrial / political / survival horror	Resource scarcity, jurisdiction feuds, White Flood
Aelinnel	Fae / mathematical / courtesy horror	Geasa, Thorn Court vs. law, the Green Gate
Black Banners	Military / mercenary warfare	Payday delays, condotta flips, winter campaigns
Ecktoria	Political intrigue / legal drama	Rival claimants, bread riots, Everflame schisms
Linn	Viking / maritime / oath-bound raiding	Feuds, mistland fog, Thing injunctions
Mistlands	Folk horror / gothic	Direwood encroachment, ward-salt shortages
Silkstrand	Urban / mercantile / noir	Guild rivalries, dyewater curses, condotta flips
Theona	Celtic / folk horror / taboo-driven	No Ninth taboo, bride-peace feasts, Green Host
Thepyrgos	Byzantine / academic / arcane mystery	Synod edicts, iconoclast riots, witch-hunters
Ubral	Highland clan / reiver / honor culture	Blood feuds, guest-right, dwarf toll roads
Valewood	Fairy tale / dark forest / fey remnant	Phasing ruins, fae courts, imperial echoes
Vhasia	Courtly romance / chivalric / fractured kingdom	Rival dukes, chevauchée, parlement war
Viterra	Legal drama / low fantasy / frontier justice	Border disputes, legal duels, Queen's progress
Ykrul	Steppe nomad / saga / honor culture	Feuds, hostage strings, white squalls
Zakov	Pirate / noir / crime syndicate	Syndicate wars, tide-driven routes, cursed cargoes

When you read a region entry, look for the **GM Seed** – a one-line hook to spark an adventure – and the **Faction Standing** suggestion. Use the simple –3 to +3 scale to track attitudes, and tie advancements to **Mandate** and **Crisis** timers (see 3.6.7 and 3.6.8).

This chapter presents a practical overview of the major regions of Fate's Edge. For each area, you will find its dominant **fantasy subgenre**, the **primary conflicts** that drive adventure, and the **key stakeholders** (factions, leaders, and powers) that shape events. Use this as a quick reference when planning sessions or improvising.

10.1 A Note on Subgenres and Travel

Each region is designed as a distinct fantasy subgenre (see §??). When the party travels from one region to another, the genre shifts – a journey from the folk horror of the Mistlands to the political intrigue of Ecktoria should feel like turning the page to a different kind of story. Use the travel rules to blend these genres organically.

10.2 Acasia — "The Broken Province"

Genre: Low fantasy / mercenary realism / border feud.

Primary Conflicts.

- Feuding petty kingdoms and warlords.
- Mercenary companies (the Black Banners) that shift loyalties with coin.
- The lingering "Curse"— a supernatural blight that twists roads and ruins.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Margravine of the Broken March** – The highest authority, half-saint, half-tax-roll.
- **The Lame King** – A traveling pretender who makes law by pointing.
- **Blackwood Matriarchs** – Hedge-witches and feud-keepers.
- **Free Company Captains** – Pike and shot mercenaries between contracts.

Quote.

"In Acasia, every bargain is an echo of a promise once broken, and every drink tastes faintly of debt."

GM Seed.

A broken bridge, a cursed child, and a free company that switches sides.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Margravine secretly funds the Lame King's pretensions to keep the province fractured – unity would threaten her tax base.
- A Blackwood Matriarch knows the true cause of the Curse: a forgotten oath to a powerful spirit, now demanding a child as payment.

Faction Standing. Track attitudes toward the Margravine, the Lame King, and the major free companies on a −3 to +3 scale. Tick *Mandate* up when the party brokers a truce or earns a noble's public endorsement. Tick *Crisis* when a feud spills into their path or a condotta flips.

Lore Note. *The road-judges of Acasia whisper that the Curse is not a blight but a slow accounting – every unpaid tithe, every broken oath, etched into the stone. "Pay what you owe," they say, "or the road will eat the interest."*

10.3 Aelaerem (Halflings) — "Hearth & Hollow"

Genre: Folk horror / pastoral quiet with dark undercurrents.

Primary Conflicts.

- The "Neighbors"— fae or otherworldly powers that demand observance.
- Feuds between clan matriarchs that can last generations.
- Harvest tithes and famine pressure.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Apple-Matron** – Hostess of harvest feasts; power sits where she pours.
- **The Pale Shepherd** – Comes when lambs are born and when people go missing.
- **Mummers' Captain** – Keeps a chest of masks and stricter rules than church.
- **Lantern-Warden** – Trims lamps and knows which shadow is wrong.

Quote.

"Don't cross the Pale Causeway at dusk, especially not if you've got a silver tooth."

GM Seed.

A harvest feast where the ninth cup is poured, and the Hollow answers.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Apple-Matron knows that the Pale Shepherd is not a single entity – it is a title passed down. The current Shepherd is a desperate woman trying to buy back her son's life.
- The Mummers' Captain's masks are not carved; they are grown from a living barrow. Each mask contains a trapped Neighbor.

Faction Standing. Track relations with the Apple-Matron's hearth, the Lantern-Wardens, and the Pale Shepherd's circuit. Tick *Mandate* when the party honors a taboo or mediates a feud. Tick *Crisis* when a Neighbor is disturbed or a harvest fails.

Lore Note. *A Grey Wanderer's note: "The Aelaerem pour the ninth cup only for the Hollow. They count to eight, then stop. I have seen a child count nine. The cup did not overflow – but the child's reflection was no longer her own."*

10.4 Aeler (Dwarves) — "Crowns & Under-Vaults"

Genre: Industrial / political / survival horror (underground).

Primary Conflicts.

- Resource scarcity (air, water, light, food) in sealed holds.
- Jurisdictional feuds – bell-code conflicts between crown and basilica.
- The "White Flood"– mountain thaw that becomes a river through routes.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Vault-Queen** – Sovereign above and below.
- **High King Beneath the Peaks** – First among crowns by ancient concord.
- **True Masons** – Wanderers repairing ancient stonework.
- **Edgewalkers** – Prospectors and border scanners.

Quote.

"When the stone starts singing a different tune, you best listen."

GM Seed.

A ventilation shaft collapses, and the only way out is through a sealed crypt that holds a forgotten king's secret.

Hidden Agendas.

- The High King's health is failing; his advisors are preparing a succession that would shatter the ancient concord.
- The True Masons are not neutral – some factions use them to quietly seal off rival holds.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Vault-Queen, the High King's court, and the True Masons. Tick *Mandate* when the party secures a new trade route or repairs a crucial under-way. Tick *Crisis* when a bell-code dispute escalates or a White Flood warning is ignored.

Lore Note. *Saikou Ira's case files: "An Aeler tunnel-wright once told me, "The mountain does not forget a misplaced keystone. It waits – sometimes a year, sometimes a century – then settles the debt with a collapse." I have never seen a dwarf leave a stone unturned."*

10.5 Aelinnel (Gnomes) — "Stone, Bough, and Bright Things"

Genre: Fae / mathematical / courtesy horror.

Primary Conflicts.

- Geasa and spoken taboos that bind without warning.
- Thorn Court vs. human law – jurisdiction debates.
- The Green Gate – a threshold that demands exact change in truths.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Stone Prince of Aelinnel** – Mortal crown with fae debts properly indexed.
- **Lady of Thorns** – Hawthorn court sovereign; smiles like a snare.
- **Green Knight** – Duelist of paths and proofs.
- **Oath-Carver** – Sets promises in quartz so they can be seen.

Quote.

"The law here flows like water over stone – it finds its own path, and woe to those who try to dam it with paper."

GM Seed.

A missing step, an unsaid name, and a door that only opens when you speak the eighth word.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Stone Prince's ledger is missing a page – a debt owed to the Thorn Court that could collapse his reign if discovered.
- The Green Knight is not a single being; the title passes to whoever wins the last duel. The current Knight is a mortal who refuses to die.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Stone Prince's court, the Lady of Thorns, and the Oath-Carvers. Tick *Mandate* when the party resolves a dispute without breaking geas. Tick *Crisis* when a promise is shattered or the Green Gate opens at the wrong hour.

Lore Note. *From the Grey Wanderer: "An Aelinnel bell-tender once told me, "We do not say "no" to a spirit. We say, "That road is closed for repairs." The spirit nods and leaves. It is not a lie – the road is closed. To spirits."*

10.6 Black Banners — "Condotta & Crowns"

Genre: Military / mercenary / low fantasy warfare.

Primary Conflicts.

- Payday delays and supply shortages.
- Condotta units flipping sides mid-battle.
- Winter campaigns and frozen battlefields.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Banner-Captain** – Griffon standard and a ledger of noble grudges.
- **The Black Colonel** – Legendary commander not seen in months, yet his banner still rides.
- **Clan-Mother** (Ykrul) – Wears war-braids from oath-breakers' hair.
- **Veteran Sergeant** – Counts scars like coins.

Quote.

"A contract is only as good as the next payday, and a grudge is only as sharp as the sword backing it."

GM Seed.

Two rival companies encamped on opposite sides of a frozen river; a single bag of coin could end the war or set off a massacre.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Black Colonel is dead; his banner is carried by a mute lieutenant who follows his last orders. No one dares question the legend.
- The Clan-Mother is secretly selling war-braids to both sides, prolonging the conflict for profit.

Faction Standing. Track standing with individual banner captains, the condotta brokers, and the Clan-Mother. Tick *Crisis* when a payday is missed or a condotta flips mid-contract.

Lore Note. *A camp whisper: "The Black Colonel died three winters ago. The banner rides because the company owes him a war. They will not stop until the debt is paid – in blood or gold."*

10.7 Ecktoria — "Marble & Fire"

Genre: Political intrigue / legal drama / fallen empire.

Primary Conflicts.

- Rival dukes, abbesses, and parlements claiming legitimacy.
- Bread riots, grain shortages, and currency devaluation.
- The Everflame orthodoxy vs. reformist sects.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Grand Magistrate** – Guardian of forms, breaker of them when needed.
- **High Priest of the Everflame** – Smiles like law; flame judges truth and debt.
- **Duchess-Regent** – Speaks through cousins, rules through silence.
- **Censor's Clerk** – "Misfiles" careers; knows which names to forget.

Quote.

"The law here is written not in books but in marble and flame."

GM Seed.

A forged will, a missing tax ledger, and a procession that turns into a riot at noon.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Grand Magistrate suspects the High Priest of the Everflame is hiding a heretic in the basilica's crypt – a former Censor who knows too much.
- The Duchess-Regent is not the real ruler; she is a body double. The true duchess died years ago, and her spymaster keeps the secret to control the province.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Grand Magistrate, the Everflame priesthood, and the ducal courts. Tick *Mandate* when the party wins a legal case or brokers a grain deal. Tick *Crisis* when a bread riot ignites or a heretic is burned.

Lore Note. *Saikou Ira notes: "The Everflame's inquisitors burn heretics on the Triumph Stairs. But the ashes are swept into the same crypts as the senators' bones. In Ecktoria, even the dead cannot escape politics."*

10.8 Linn — "Skeries & Storm-Oaths"

Genre: Viking / maritime / oath-bound raiding.

Primary Conflicts.

- Feuds that turn weddings into funerals.
- Mistlands fog and misdirection – channels "move" without warning.
- Thing injunctions that forbid sailing until a grievance is heard.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Sea-Queen** – Crown of hammered silver, eyes for weather and law.
- **High Jarl** – First among raids, last to boast.
- **Volva of the Mist** – Oath-reader whose nod stills surf.
- **Skald** – Verses buy silence, start fights, end them.

Quote.

"The sea keeps better counsel than any scribe, and the storm remembers every oath sworn upon its winds."

GM Seed.

A bride stolen, a longship lost in fog, and a skald's verse that names the dead.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Sea-Queen lost an eye to a storm – or to a rival's blade. Her court knows, but no one speaks of it.
- The Volva of the Mist is not Linnic; she is a runaway from the Mistlands who bargained with a spirit for her position.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Sea-Queen's court, the High Jarl's household, and the skaldic circles. Tick *Mandate* when the party resolves a feud at Thing. Tick *Crisis* when a ship is lost in a squall or a wedding turns to blood.

Lore Note. *"A Linn skald's verse: 'The Thing-bell rings for the living. The drowned wait for a different bell – one that only sounds when the tide forgets its name.'"*

10.9 Mistlands — "Bells, Salt, and Breath"

Genre: Folk horror / gothic / supernatural dread.

Primary Conflicts.

- The Direwood's encroachment – undead and wraiths testing the bell-lines.
- Ward-salt shortages and bell-line failures.
- Aeler protectorate authority vs. local independence.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Legate of the Mists** – Aeler governor; equal parts mercy and decree.
- **Bell-Warden** – Ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts at bay.
- **Salt-Monk** – Blesses pans and keeps ward-measure honest.
- **Mist-Seer** – Bargains breath for answers; candles shorten when she speaks.

Quote.

"The bells here do more than mark time – they weave the very fabric of reality."

GM Seed.

A bell-line fails at dusk, and something that should not walk steps through the gap.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Legate of the Mists knows that the Direwood is not a natural forest – it is a prison for a forgotten god. The bell-lines are the bars of its cage.
- A faction of Salt-Monks hoards pure salt to sell to desperate villages, letting other wards decay.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Legate's protectorate, the Bell-Wardens, and the Salt-Monks. Tick *Mandate* when the party repairs a bell-line or negotiates a ward-salt shipment. Tick *Crisis* when a wraith breaks through or a village is quarantined.

Lore Note. *A Grey Wanderer's warning: "In the Mistlands, never breathe deeply after the ninth bell. The fog remembers your breath, and one day it will ask for it back."*

10.10 Silkstrand — "City of Bridges & Dyewater"

Genre: Urban / mercantile / noir.

Primary Conflicts.

- Guild rivalries and Exchange cornering.
- The "Curse"—dyewater omens and awakened curses in the canals.
- Condottieri flipping colors mid-contract.

Key Stakeholders.

- **The Matron** – Rules from her palazzo stairs with velvet and iron.
- **Guildmistress of Dyers** – Stained hands, permits tighter than purse strings.
- **Bridge Bailiff** – Rents stalls, sells gossip by the breath.
- **Night-Boat Smuggler ("Ravel")** – Silent oar, louder favors.

Quote.

"In this city, every bridge is a ledger and every current carries coin."

GM Seed.

A dye-permit stamped with a dead notary's seal, and a canal that runs red at midnight.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Matron's velvet gloves hide iron claws: she personally ordered the death of the last Bridge Bailiff who refused to rig a debt auction.
- The Guildmistress of Dyers is slowly poisoning the water to drive out smaller competitors; the "Curse" is a convenient cover.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Matron's office, the Dyers' Guild, and the smuggling networks. Tick *Mandate* when the party brokers a trade deal or exposes a forger. Tick *Crisis* when the Exchange corners a market or a condotta flips.

Lore Note. *Madam Serafine's whisper: "The dye-water never truly washes out. A forger's hands stay stained – not with color, but with the memory of every seal they broke. You can see it in the way their fingers curl."*

10.11 Theona — "Three Greens, No Ninth"

Genre: Celtic / folk horror / taboo-driven.

Primary Conflicts.

- The "No Ninth" taboo – omissions, unspoken names, missing steps.
- Bride-peace feasts that can end or restart feuds.
- The Green Host – spectral riders that appear when customs are broken.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Matron of Wells** – Queen-mother in truth if not name.
- **Three-Isles King** – Elected by moots; whale-bone throne.
- **Lady Beneath** – Unseen queen who bargains in dreams.
- **Taboo-Witness** – Geas-keeper who knows which words ruin deals.

Quote.

"The wells here hold more than water – they hold the dreams and prayers of generations."

GM Seed.

A bride-peace feast where the ninth cup is poured, and the Green Host rides before dawn.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Lady Beneath is not a spirit – she is a mortal exile who learned to walk through dreams. She uses omens to manipulate the Three-Isles King.
- The Taboo-Witness is dying. She is looking for a successor to inherit her geas – and her debts.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Matron of Wells, the Three-Isles King's moot, and the Taboo-Witness. Tick *Mandate* when the party keeps the Ninth silent or brokers a marriage peace. Tick *Crisis* when a taboo is broken or the Green Host is sighted.

Lore Note. *A Grey Wanderer's note: "I attended a moot on Theona. They counted every vote, every step, every cup – but never the ninth. When I asked why, the eldest said, "The ninth is not for us. It is for the ones who will come after. Let them count it."*

10.12 Thepyrgos — "City of a Thousand Stairs"

Genre: Byzantine / academic / arcane mystery.

Primary Conflicts.

- Synod edicts that proscribe or permit chants and rites.
- Iconoclast riots between competing faiths.
- Witch-hunters and arcane talent conscription.

Key Stakeholders.

- **The Archon** – Elected, entrenched, counting bells.
- **Lighthouse-Patriarch** – Reclusive seer who steers beacons in storms.
- **Nomophylax** – Law-scholar whose citations close mouths.
- **Palkar Captain** – Tower guards; ladder-quick and letter-shy.

Quote.

"Every stair climbed is a word in the great conversation between earth and sky."

GM Seed.

A stolen grimoire, a silent bell, and a witch-hunter who refuses to explain her orders.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Lighthouse-Patriarch is not senile; he is hiding a child with forbidden talent in the beacon tower.
- The Archon plans to dissolve the Synod and rule alone. He has already bribed half the Palkar captains.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Archon's office, the Synod, and the Chain-Lantern order. Tick *Mandate* when the party resolves a heresy trial or sponsors a student. Tick *Crisis* when an iconoclast riot erupts or a witch-hunt goes too far.

Lore Note. *Saikou Ira's observation: "Thepyrgos's witch-hunters carry censers of lead, not brass. "Brass is for faith," they say. "Lead is for certainty." I have never seen a lead censer cool."*

10.13 Ubral — "The Stone Between Spears"

Genre: Highland clan / reiver / honor culture.

Primary Conflicts.

- Feuds that last generations, settled by wergild in cattle or blood.
- Guest-right – breaking hospitality stains name worse than breaking a sword.
- Dwarf toll roads and clan independence.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Lady of Tor** – Clan-chief in cloak and mail.
- **Council of Cairns** – Greybeards and granite wills; they do not hurry.
- **Feud-Broker** – Knows the weight of life in cattle and coin.
- **Wergild Counter** – Keeps tallies, ends grudges, starts others.

Quote.

"The stone here remembers every oath sworn upon it and every blood spilled in its shadow."

GM Seed.

A stolen herd, a broken guest-token, and a cairn that adds a new name at dawn.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Lady of Tor is dying without an heir. She plans to name a successor from outside the clan – a move that will trigger a civil war.
- The Council of Cairns is not a council of elders; it is a single shaman wearing many masks, speaking with different voices.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Lady of Tor, the Council of Cairns, and the Khaz-Vurim dwarf wardens. Tick *Mandate* when the party pays a wergild or brokers a truce. Tick *Crisis* when a feud reignites or a guest-right is violated.

Lore Note. *A Grey Wanderer's memory: "An Ubral widow once told me, "My husband's feud cost three cows and a boy's finger. I paid the cows. The finger – that is still owed." She smiled. I did not ask more."*

10.14 Valewood — "Empire Under Leaves"

Genre: Fairy tale / dark forest / fey remnant.

Primary Conflicts.

- Phasing ruins and star-roads that shift between worlds.
- Fae courts (Hazel vs. Alder) competing for influence.
- Imperial echoes – ancient shades still marching patrols.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Hazel Queen** – Lethai-ar sovereign in leaf and law.
- **Alder King** – Twilit Court sovereign in shadow and debt.
- **The Huntsman** – Antlers of moonlight; shortcuts owe him.
- **Pathweaver** – Knots safe routes into cord.

Quote.

"The forest here remembers empires that crumbled to dust, and its laws are older than your kingdoms."

GM Seed.

A star-road that opens at dusk, a fae bargain that demands a voice, and an imperial shade that knows your true name.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Hazel Queen is dying from an old curse. She is looking for a mortal to inherit her crown – and her debt to the Alder King.
- The Huntsman is not loyal to either court; he is a former lover of the Hazel Queen, cursed to hunt her enemies until she lifts the spell.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Hazel Queen, the Alder King, and the Imperial Echo patrols. Tick *Mandate* when the party returns a relic or respects a geas. Tick *Crisis* when a court's patience expires or a star-road realigns dangerously.

Lore Note. *A Lethai-ar whisper: "The Valewood is not a place. It is a process. Every root, every leaf, every fallen emperor – all are being digested into something new. Walk softly, or you will join the meal."*

10.15 Vhasia — "The Fractured Sun"

Genre: Courtly romance / chivalric / fractured kingdom.

Primary Conflicts.

- Rival dukes claiming the Sun-crown.
- Chevauchée – raiding parties that burn loyalty oaths as well as barns.
- Parlement divided – war by paperwork.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Two Crowns** – Rival dukes, each crowned in rival cathedrals.
- **Queen-Mother** – Weaves alliances as if they were dowries.
- **Last Dauphin** – Rumor with a birthmark; armies march for whispers.
- **Marshal-Exile** – Sun-court's hammer, now wielded by whoever pays.

Quote.

"The sun may be fractured, but our authority is absolute within our domains."

GM Seed.

A false Dauphin, a stolen crown, and a chevauchée that burns a village that swore neutrality.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Queen-Mother secretly supports both Crowns; she wants the war to continue until every rival duke is exhausted.
- The Last Dauphin is a commoner recruited by the Marshal-Exile. He believes his own legend.

Faction Standing. Track standing with each of the Two Crowns, the Queen-Mother, and the Parlement clerks. Tick *Mandate* when the party brokers a truce or exposes a forgery. Tick *Crisis* when a chevauchée goes unanswered or a parlement divides.

Lore Note. *The Grey Wanderer: "In Vhasia, every castle flies two banners – one for the king who might return, and one for the lord who actually lives there. The third banner, the one for the truth, is never raised."*

10.16 Viterra — "The Hedge-Law Realm"

Genre: Legal drama / low fantasy / frontier justice.

Primary Conflicts.

- Border disputes over hay-carts and toll rights.
- Legal duels – formal combat to settle property claims.
- The Queen's progress – royal authority moving through semi-autonomous duchies.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Warrior Queen** – Crown on helm, sword at side, patient sums behind gaze.
- **Queen's Justiciar** – Law on road, polite as a noose.
- **Fen Reeve** – Tally-rod; speaks for dike guilds.
- **Master Advocate Halric** – Silver-tongued legal warrior.

Quote.

"Every hedge here marks not just a boundary but a principle – the careful balance between order and freedom."

GM Seed.

A boundary stone moved overnight, a legal duel at dawn, and a charter that was signed in disappearing ink.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Warrior Queen is not a warrior; she is a diplomat who won the crown by out-arguing her rivals. Her sword has never been drawn.
- Master Advocate Halric is a spy for a foreign power, feeding legal secrets to Vhasian exiles.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Queen's court, the Queen's Justiciars, and the Fen Reeves. Tick *Mandate* when the party wins a legal case or settles a border dispute. Tick *Crisis* when a legal duel turns lethal or a charter is voided.

Lore Note. *A Justiciar's saying: "The hedge does not move. The law moves. If you wake to find your boundary stone three feet east, do not curse the neighbor – curse the clerk who slept with the surveyor's wife."*

10.17 Ykrul (Orcs) — "Wolf Standards, Winter Camps"

Genre: Steppe nomad / saga / honor culture.

Primary Conflicts.

- Feuds and blood-price (wergild) in cattle or horses.
- Hostage strings – token kin left to secure treaties.
- White squalls and raspuitisa (spring melt) that seal passes.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Khatun of Ring** – Camp-law and hostage strings.
- **Khagan's Kin** – Sent to bind foedus with a look.
- **Sky-Speaker** – Shaman of storms; shortcuts owe them price.
- **Kon'reh Masters** – Geometry arbiters and teachers.

Quote.

"The steppe remembers every oath sworn beneath its endless sky, and the wolf-standards carry the honor of clans that have outlasted empires."

GM Seed.

A hostage string cut, a white squall that blinds both sides, and a Sky-Speaker who demands a blood-price for the weather.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Khagan's Kin are not blood relatives; they are children of conquered chieftains, trained to be loyal enforcers.
- The Kon'reh Masters secretly manipulate the geometry of oaths to favor certain clans, maintaining a hidden balance of power.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Khatun's camp, the Khagan's court, and the Sky-Speaker's circle. Tick *Mandate* when the party pays a blood-price or secures a hostage exchange. Tick *Crisis* when a white squall isolates a camp or a hostage string is severed.

Lore Note. *A Ykrul bone-singer's whisper: "The wind carries more than snow. It carries the names of the forgotten. When a horse shies at nothing, it is because a name touched its ear. Speak the name, and the horse will calm – or run."*

10.18 Zakov — "Salt & Serpent"

Genre: Pirate / noir / crime syndicate.

Primary Conflicts.

- Syndicate wars and the Salt Prince's levy.
- Tide-driven smuggling routes that shift with the water.
- Cursed cargoes and fae bargains at the Crimson Docks.

Key Stakeholders.

- **Salt Prince** – Nominal ruler; real power in shadows.
- **Pirate Queen** – Rules the Shallows with charm and cutlass.
- **Kraken's Tongue** – Oracle who speaks in riddles and tides.
- **Syndicate Silent** – No names, just favors and faces.

Quote.

"The tide here keeps better ledgers than any scribe, and the reefs remember every secret whispered above their depths."

GM Seed.

A cursed cargo that whispers, a tide that does not rise, and a Syndicate Silent who offers a deal with no visible cost.

Hidden Agendas.

- The Salt Prince is a puppet; the real ruler is the Kraken's Tongue, who uses the oracle's prestige to manipulate every syndicate.
- The Pirate Queen is secretly a spy for a mainland power, sent to destabilize Zakov before an invasion.

Faction Standing. Track standing with the Salt Prince's court, the Pirate Queen's flotilla, and the Syndicate Silent. Tick *Crisis* when a syndicate war breaks out or a cursed cargo escapes. (Mandate rarely applies in Zakov – reputation is measured in threats, not legitimacy.)

Lore Note. *Madam Serafine's advice: "In Zakov, a coin that stays warm is a curse. Spend it fast, or throw it into the sea. The Salt Prince's collectors can smell interest from three docks away."*

10.19 Other Regions (Brief)

For completeness, these areas appear in the comprehensive guide but are less central to the core setting:

- **Dungeon – "Living Infrastructure"** – A mythic underworld that breathes; genre: dungeon crawl as survival horror.
- **The Ways Between – "Spiritways & Veilways"** – Liminal paths between death and dreams; genre: metaphysical / dream-logic.
- **The Wilds – "Roads, Ruins, and Weather"** – A reskin palette for any terrain – forest, desert, tundra, coast.
- **Vilikari – "Laurels & Longhouses"** – A federated frontier mixing Utaran law with barbarian custom.

10.20 Using This Compendium at the Table

When preparing a session or improvising, consult the region's entry for:

- **Genre** – to set the right mood.
- **Primary conflicts** – to generate immediate stakes.
- **Key stakeholders** – to populate scenes with recognizable NPCs.
- **Quote** – to read aloud as a flavor text.
- **GM Seed** – a one-sentence hook for quick inspiration.
- **Hidden Agendas** – secrets that can become campaign threads.
- **Faction Standing** – track attitudes with the simple –3 to +3 scale, and advance *Mandate* or *Crisis* timers as described.

Remember that travel rules (see §??) allow you to blend these genres as the party moves from one region to another.

Appendix A

Quick Reference and Tables

This chapter collects quick-reference tables, optional rules, and GM tools. Use them as needed at the table. For additional player-facing reference, see the *Player's Guide* appendices.

Appendix A: Core Reference Tables

Table A.1: Outcome Matrix

Case	Name	Guidance
$S \geq DV, C = 0$	Clean Success	Deliver the intent crisply.
$S \geq DV, C > 0$	Success & Cost	Grant intent; spend or bank SB for complications.
$0 < S < DV$	Partial	Progress; award 1 Boon.
$S = 0$	Miss	No progress; award 2 Boons; spend or bank SB.

Story Beat (SB) Spend Menu

- **1 SB:** Minor pressure – noise, trace, +1 segment on a relevant timer.
- **2 SB:** Moderate setback – alarm raised, lose cover or advantage, lesser foe appears.
- **3 SB:** Serious trouble – reinforcements arrive, key gear breaks temporarily, tick a campaign front.
- **4+ SB:** Major turn – trap springs, authority arrives, scene shifts dramatically.

Position Descriptions

- **Dominant:** Act on your terms. Consequences are manageable.
- **Controlled:** Normal risk and reward. Failure has a real cost.
- **Desperate:** Odds stacked against you. Failure could be catastrophic.

Table A.2: Difficulty Ladder

DV	Name	When to Use
2	Routine	Clear intent, modest stakes, controlled environment.
3	Pressured	Time pressure, mild opposition, partial information.
4	Hard	Hostile conditions, active opposition, precise timing.
5+	Extreme	Multiple constraints, high stakes, dramatic failure.

Boon Economy Quick Guide

- **Holding cap:** 5 Boons maximum.
- **Carryover:** At the end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of 2.
- **Conversion:** 2 Boons $\rightarrow$ 1XP, *once per session during downtime (max 2XP per session via conversion).*
- **Spending:** Re-roll a die, activate an asset, improve Position, or power certain Rites.

Mechanical Constraints

- **Assist Max:** +3 dice total per roll (Exceptional Coordination allows +4 from one follower).
- **Boon Max:** 5 total; $2 \rightarrow 1XP$ conversion once per session ($\max 2XP$ via conversion).
- **Follower Independent Action:** Once per scene (party-wide).
- **Over-Stack:** Two or more structural advantages on the same action $\rightarrow$ *start one obstacle* + 1 DV or GM banks +1 SB.

Table A.3: Harm Levels and Effects

Level	SB Generation	Penalty	Recovery
Minor	1 SB (next 2 rolls)	-1 die (related actions)	Rest or basic care
Moderate	1 SB (next roll)	-1 die (most actions)	Medical treatment
Severe	2 SB (next roll)	-2 dice (most actions)	Extended care
Critical	3 SB (next roll)	Incapacitated	Major intervention

Range Bands

- Close** Arm's length, grappling distance.
Near Same room or immediate area.
Far Visible but not immediately reachable.
Absent Off-screen; requires a scene change.

Movement Actions

- **Move:** Shift one range band (Close $\leftrightarrow$ Near or Near $\leftrightarrow$ Far).
- **Dash:** Shift two bands as your full action.
- **Disengage:** Test to leave an enemy's Close range without provoking an opportunity attack.
- **Charge / Skirmish:** Full-turn actions that move two bands and attack, costing 1 Fatigue.

Supply Timer States

- Full (0 segments)** Well-provisioned, no penalty.
Low (2 segments) Minor friction – resource checks at -1 die.
Dangerously Low (3 segments) Each PC gains Fatigue 1.
Empty (4 segments) Severe penalties – starvation or thirst risk.

Travel Timer Sizes

- 4 segments** Short, straightforward leg.
6 segments Standard leg.
8 segments Extended or complex journey.
10 segments Epic or highly dangerous passage.

Table A.4: XP Costs

Improvement	Cost	Downtime
Attribute increase	new rating $\times$ 3 XP	new rating days
Skill increase	new level $\times$ 2 XP	new level days
On-Screen Follower	Cap ² XP	1–3 days
Minor Asset	4 XP	1 day
Standard Asset	8 XP	1 week
Major Asset	12 XP	1 month

Upkeep (Condensed)

Frequency: Once per downtime period.

- **Efficient (higher XP, less time):** Upkeep XP = $\max(1, \frac{\text{Acquisition XP}}{3})$.
- **Intensive (1 XP, dedicated action):** One full downtime action.
- **Failure to pay:** Follower becomes Wary (or Seized if already Wary); Asset becomes Neglected (or Compromised if already Neglected).

Appendix B: Optional Rules and Tactical Tools

Grid-Based Combat (Optional)

Use a square or hex grid with Zones of Control (ZoC).

ZoC rules:

- Entering an enemy's Zone of Control ends your movement – you are engaged.
- You cannot move through an enemy's ZoC.
- Leaving a ZoC requires the Disengage action (DV 4–6) or spending 1 Boon.
- Flank: +1 die to attack. Rear: +1 die and +1 Effect.

Push-Through: Roll Body + Athletics vs. $DV = 2 + \text{enemy Tier}$. Choose a cost on success: Position worsens by one step, –1 die on the action, or the enemy gets a free opportunity attack.

Detailed Warfare (Mass Combat)

Treat an army as a high-Cap Follower (see 3.4) with its own timers:

- **Supply Timer** (6–8 segments): When empty, the army suffers severe penalties.
- **Morale Timer** (6–8 segments): When full, the army routs.
- **Command rolls** (Presence + Command or Wits + Tactics) advance objective timers (e.g., *Break Their Line* [6]).
- **Battle's Edge:** Story Beats generated by command rolls can be spent on fog-of-war complications – false orders, broken supply wagons, or a messenger's death.

Hex-Based Exploration

Map a region in 6-mile hexes. Entering a hex requires a Wits + Survival roll (DV set by terrain). Outcomes determine discovery (find a point of interest), danger (ambush, hazard), or becoming lost (add a timer segment to find the way out).

Miniatures Mode — Speed Defaults

Base DV: $DV = \text{Tier} + 2 + \text{Keywords (elevation +1, [WARD] +1, Disengage base DV 4)}$.

Critical Hit (10): Bump Position one step; if already Dominant, Push or Pull the target 1 hex *or* gain +1 automatic success.

Zone of Control (ZoC): Entering or leaving a hex adjacent to an enemy provokes one Reaction (Free Strike or Shove 1 hex).

Heat: On a critical hit, the GM may spend 1 Heat (a resource tracked per scene) to degrade Position or trigger a terrain hazard.

Hex Keywords

Difficult: Costs 2 movement points per hex. **Elevation:** Attacks from lower ground suffer +1 DV. **ZoC:** Provokes a Reaction on crossing.

Altar [WARD]: -1 die to attacks (or attacker may spend 2 Fatigue to ignore).

Incorporeal: Ignores Difficult terrain; can pass through occupied hexes but cannot end movement in one.

Sample NPCs

Encounters (Tier I–II)

- **Bandit Skirmisher:** Body 2, Wits 2. Melee 2, Stealth 1.
- **Ykrul Rider:** Body 4, Wits 3. Riding 3, Melee 3.
- **Street Bravo:** Presence 3, Body 2. Dueling 3.

Foils & Rivals (Tier II–III)

- **Ambitious Scribe:** Wits 3, Presence 3. Intrigue 3, Lore 2.
- **Mercenary Captain:** Body 4, Spirit 3. Command 3, Melee 4.
- **Flame Preacher:** Presence 4, Spirit 3. Oratory 4, Faith 3.

Prestige NPCs (Tier IV–V)

- **High Elf Loremaster:** Wits 5, Spirit 4. Lore 5, Arcana 4.
- **Dwarven Forge-Patriarch:** Body 5, Spirit 4. Craft 5, Command 4.
- **Ykrul Warglord:** Body 5, Presence 4. Command 4, Melee 5.

Common Rolls (GM Screen Reference)

Athletics: climb (<i>Body</i> +Athletics), time a leap (<i>Wits</i> +Athletics)	Performance: captivate a crowd (<i>Presence</i> +Performance), mimic voice (<i>Wits</i> +Performance)
Stealth: shadow patrol (<i>Wits</i> +Stealth), hold still (<i>Spirit</i> +Stealth)	Subterfuge: talk past a checkpoint (<i>Presence</i> +Subterfuge), case a routine (<i>Wits</i> +Subterfuge)
Endurance: resist cold (<i>Spirit</i> +Endurance), push through pain (<i>Spirit</i> +Endurance)	Streetwise: find a fence (<i>Presence</i> +Streetwise), sift rumors (<i>Wits</i> +Streetwise)
Craft: blueprint (<i>Wits</i> +Craft), brace a door (<i>Body</i> +Craft)	Arcana: read a ward anchor (<i>Wits</i> +Arcana), hold a rite steady (<i>Spirit</i> +Arcana)
Melee: break guard (<i>Body</i> +Melee), bind a blade (<i>Wits</i> +Melee)	Mechanics: diagnose a lock (<i>Wits</i> +Mechanics), field-rig a pump (<i>Body</i> +Mechanics)
Ranged: leading shot (<i>Wits</i> +Ranged), loose in a squall (<i>Spirit</i> +Ranged)	Investigation: reconstruct a scene (<i>Wits</i> +Investigation), interview a witness (<i>Presence</i> +Investigation)
Brawl: grapple (<i>Body</i> +Brawl), feint (<i>Wits</i> +Brawl)	Lore: cite local custom (<i>Presence</i> +Lore), perform a rite (<i>Spirit</i> +Lore)
Tactics: ambush lane (<i>Wits</i> +Tactics), coordinate a retreat (<i>Presence</i> +Tactics)	Nature: read weather (<i>Wits</i> +Nature), calm a mount (<i>Presence</i> +Nature)
Diplomacy: audience (<i>Presence</i> +Diplomacy), draft terms (<i>Wits</i> +Diplomacy)	Medicine: stabilize a wound (<i>Wits</i> +Medicine), cut away rot (<i>Body</i> +Medicine)
Sway: haggle (<i>Presence</i> +Sway), sell a risky plan (<i>Presence</i> +Sway)	Command: rally allies (<i>Presence</i> +Command), hold the line (<i>Spirit</i> +Command)
Deception: lie under scrutiny (<i>Presence</i> +Deception), misdirect guard (<i>Wits</i> +Deception)	

Fast Boundaries:

- **Locks & Traps:** Mechanical = Mechanics + Attribute; Arcane = Arcana + Attribute.
- **People vs. Mechanisms:** Subterfuge for social infiltration; Stealth to avoid detection; Mechanics or Arcana to bypass a physical or magical barrier.
- **Formal vs. Informal:** Diplomacy for courts and treaties; Sway for bargaining and personal persuasion.

Appendix C: Deck and Magic Reference

Deck Types and Meanings

Travel Decks (regional, 52-card) Spade = Place, Heart = Actor, Club = Pressure, Diamond = Leverage.

Deck of Consequences (scene drama) Hearts = Social/Emotional, Spades = Harm/Escalation, Clubs = Material Cost, Diamonds = Magical/Spiritual.

Important: Never mix suit meanings across different deck types.

Deck Usage Procedure

After a roll that generates Story Beats:

1. **Direct Spend:** Translate SB into immediate consequences or timer ticks (see Appendix A).
2. **Optional Deck Draw:** Draw up to $\min(\text{SB}, 3)$ cards and synthesize a single narrative twist guided by the suits and the highest rank.

Rank Severity Guide

Ace–3 Minor inconvenience or flavor.

4–6 Moderate setback.

7–9 Significant consequence.

10–King Major fallout with lasting effects.

Table A.5: Deck of Consequences Interpretation

Suit	Interpretation
Hearts (Emotional/Social)	Ace–3: awkward social moment; 4–6: relationship strain; 7–9: betrayal; 10–King: exile or shattered alliance.
Spades (Harm/Escalation)	Ace–3: bruise or Fatigue; 4–6: wound or damaged gear; 7–9: severe injury; 10–King: death or permanent loss.
Clubs (Material/Cost)	Ace–3: minor resource loss; 4–6: gear failure or debt; 7–9: major asset lost; 10–King: total ruin.
Diamonds (Magical/Spiritual)	Ace–3: omen or whisper; 4–6: curse or spirit appears; 7–9: arcane backlash; 10–King: reality bends temporarily.

Table A.6: Magic Paths Comparison

Path	Requirements	Key Feature	Risk Type
Caster (Freeform)	Spellcraft (6 XP)	Improvisational spellcasting	Backlash (5.3)
Runekeeper (Rites)	Thiasos (2 XP) + Codex (4 XP)	Structured Patron Rites	Obligation (5.4)

Table A.6 – continued

Path	Requirements	Key Feature	Risk Type
Invoker (Symbols)	Patron's Symbol (4 XP each)	Ritual precision, emergency casting	Symbol compromise

DV Reference for Rites

$$DV = \max(\text{ObligationCost} - \text{Spirit}, \text{Tier})$$

Obligation	Spirit 0	Spirit 1	Spirit 2	Spirit 3–4	Tier 1	Tier 2	Tier 3
1	1	1	1	1	1	2	3
2	2	1	1	1	1	2	3
3	3	2	1	1	1	2	3
4	4	3	2	1	1	2	3
5	5	4	3	2	1	2	3
6	6	5	4	3	1	2	3
7	7	6	5	4	1	2	3

Casting Loop Summary

1. **Channel:** Wits + Arcana to gather magical potential.
2. **Weave:** Wits + Art (or appropriate magical skill) to shape the effect.
3. **Backlash:** The GM spends SB generated during the roll to impose thematic consequences (see 5.3).

Eight Elements of Magic

Earth Solidity, stability, foundation.

Fire Energy, transformation, destruction.

Air Movement, speed, freedom.

Water Fluidity, healing, adaptability.

Fate Destiny, inevitability, causality.

Life Vitality, creation, growth.

Luck Chance, unpredictability.

Death/Dreams Endings, thresholds, the subconscious.

Appendix D: Campaign Management

Campaign Timer Examples

- **Mandate Advancement:** Public victories, crisis resolution, recognition by powerful factions (see 3.6.7).
- **Crisis Advancement:** Rival faction gains influence, asset neglect, betrayal, scandal (see 3.6.8).

Follower and Asset Condition States

Maintained Full capability, no penalties.

Neglected -1 die penalty; narrative wear and tear.

Compromised Unavailable until repaired or recovered through downtime.

See 3.4 for detailed rules.

Faction Loyalty Scale (Optional)

Track faction standing on a simple -3 to +3 scale.

-3 Enemy Actively works against the party.

0 Neutral Indifferent.

+3 Ally Will sacrifice for the party.

Adjust by ± 1 after major interactions (saving or betraying the faction).

Campaign Pacing (Arc Structure)

1. **Introduction** (1–2 sessions): Establish stakes, hook the players.
2. **Development** (2–4 sessions): Complications multiply, alliances form.
3. **Climax** (1–2 sessions): Major confrontation, critical choices.
4. **Resolution** (1 session): Consequences land, new status quo established.

Appendix E: Safety and Inclusivity

X-Card System

- **X-Card:** “I’m not comfortable – change direction immediately.” No explanation required.
- **O-Card:** “I’m excited – lean into this element.”
- **N-Card:** “I need a break – pause the scene.”

Keep cards visible. Model appropriate use as the GM.

Script Change

Ask at appropriate moments:

- **Pause:** “Are you okay with this content?”
- **Rewind:** “Would you like to go back and change something?”
- **Fast Forward:** “Would you like to skip ahead?”

Inclusive Worldbuilding

- Research real cultures thoroughly when drawing inspiration.
- Avoid stereotypes; build characters with depth and agency.
- Provide character options that do not rely on real-world cultural markers.
- Use high-contrast, readable materials for accessibility.

Conflict Resolution

When conflicts arise at the table:

1. Pause gameplay.
2. Discuss privately if needed.
3. Focus on understanding, not assigning fault.
4. Find collaborative solutions.
5. Document any agreements.

Common solutions: the GM’s ruling stands for the session; research the rule later; adjust future play.

Appendix F: Rival Party Generator

Use the following d6 tables to generate a rival party in under 5 minutes. Roll once in each category or choose deliberately.

Rival Party Name

d6	Name	Flavor
1	The Ashen Cord	Echoes, smoke, unbreakable knots.
2	The Brass Legion	Gears, discipline, cold precision.
3	The Thorns of Winter	Ice, silence, patient cruelty.
4	The Gilded Chain	Wealth, obligation, gilded cages.
5	The Salt Pact	Oaths sworn in brine, pirates or pilgrims.
6	The Unfaced	Masks, secrets, stolen identities.

Composition (3–5 members)

d6	Role	Archetype
1	Leader	Shadow mage, war-priest, strategist, or oath-breaker.
2	Muscle	Berserker, knight, duelist, or beast-handler.
3	Mage/Weird	Cantor, free caster, runekeeper, or witch.
4	Scout/Thief	Infiltrator, poisoner, sniper, or ghost.
5	Face/Healer	Negotiator, spy, medic, or confessor.
6	Specialist	Engineer, summoner, trapper, or lore-master.

Patron (roll once per character or once for the party)

d6	Patron	Theme
1	Ikasha (Shadow)	Secrets, thresholds, omens.
2	Malachai (Curse)	Corrupted bargains, venomous gifts.
3	The Traveler (Roads)	Journeys, shortcuts, debts.
4	The Ninth (Knowledge)	Forbidden truths, fractured minds.
5	Khemesh (Depths)	Unstoppable pressure, drowning.
6	Palinode (Performance)	Rapture, encores, hungry fame.

Goal (pressure or obstacle)

d6	Goal	Example
1	Retrieve the same artifact.	Sunstone, charter, relic.
2	Capture/kill a mutual contact.	Witness, defector, rival.
3	Secure a Patron's favor.	Complete a ritual or sacrifice.
4	Eliminate the PCs for a rival.	Bounty, vendetta, jealous patron.
5	Claim a contested site.	Anchorhold, shrine, trade route.
6	Prevent a prophecy.	Stop the PCs from changing fate.

Relationship to PCs

d6	Relationship	Initial Attitude
1	Unexpected rivals	Neutral – will negotiate first.
2	Hunters seeking a bounty	Hostile – will attack if confident.
3	Former allies, now betrayed	Bitter – may accept apology at cost.
4	Pawns of a common enemy	Reluctant allies – temporary truce.
5	Zealous competitors	Competitive – will cheat but not kill.
6	Mysterious	Unreadable – may help or hinder.

Additional Resource (off-screen)

d6	Resource	Effect
1	Hidden safehouse	Can hide from pursuers once.
2	Bribed official	May delay a legal timer once.
3	Spy network	Gains +1 die to gather info.
4	War chest	Can hire temporary muscle.
5	Patron's omen	Once per arc, avoid a Miss.
6	Stolen map	Shortcut to any location once.

Rival Party Timer

Every rival party should have a visible agenda timer, e.g., *Rival Agenda [6]*. Tick it:

- When the party ignores or fails to hinder the rivals.
- When the GM spends 2+ SB on off-screen rival activity.

- When a session ends without contact.

When the timer fills, the rivals achieve a major milestone (steal the relic, secure the Patron's favor, etc.). The GM reveals their progress through rumors, looted sites, or a direct confrontation.

Example Rival Party (Quick Build)

The Ashen Cord (from simulation)

Composition: Vesper (leader, shadow mage, serves Ikasha), Tallow (berserker, serves Malachai), Ember (cantor, serves Palinode), Cinder (scout, no Patron).

Goal: Retrieve the Sunstone fragment before the PCs.

Relationship: Unexpected rivals – will negotiate or betray as needed.

Clock: *Cord's Agenda* [6].

Resource: Hidden safehouse in Silkstrand.

Appendix G: One-Page GM Screen Summary

Fate's Edge – GM Screen	
CORE RESOLUTION	
1. Declare Action	Intent + Attribute + Skill
2. Set DV	2=Routine, 3=Pressured, 4=Hard, 5+=Extreme
3. Set Position	Dominant (re-roll failure), Controlled (normal), Desperate (re-roll success)
4. Roll	Count successes (6+) and 1s (SB for GM)
5. Outcome	Clean Success, Success & Cost, Partial (1 Boon), Miss (2 Boons)
6. Spend SB	1=minor, 2=moderate, 3+=major complication
COMBAT QUICK REF	
Move	Shift one band (Close↔Near↔Far)
Dash	Move two bands, next defense Desperate
Charge/Skirmish	Move two bands + attack, cost 1 Fatigue, requires open ground
Opportunity Attack	Leaving Close without Disengage = free melee attack
Fatigue	Each Fatigue worsens Position; fill → <i>Harm</i> + 1, <i>clearFatigue</i>
Harm	1=–1 die (major), 2=–1 dice (most), 3=incapacitated
MAGIC SHORTCUTS	
Free Caster	DV = 1 + number of [TAGS] (dangerous +2); backlash on 1s
Runekeeper	Invoke Rite (1 action) +1 Obligation; Push It: +1 Obligation
Invoker	Ritual (DV+1 rounds) +1 Obligation; Crack the Seal: instant, +2 Obligation, Symbol Compromised
Cantor	Song (1 action, resolves next turn) +Corruption timer; Push: resolve immediately
Summoning	Call (1 action) + Bind (1 Boon or Fatigue); Leash = Cap + Spirit segments

SB SPEND QUICK

1 SB	Noise, trace, tick a timer +1
2 SB	Alarm raised, lose advantage, lesser foe appears
3 SB	Reinforcements, key gear break, campaign front tick
4+ SB	Trap springs, authority arrives, scene shift

CLOCKS & DIFFICULTY

Timer Size	4=short, 6=standard, 8=long, 10=epic
Default DV	3 (pressured, mild opposition)
DV 2	Routine, trivial stakes
DV 4	Hard, active opposition
DV 5+	Extreme, high drama

Golden Rule: When in doubt, make a ruling that keeps the story moving.

Appendix H: Sample Deck Reading (Example)

The GM draws three cards from the Deck of Consequences after a player rolls three 1s on a critical stealth check.

Drawn: Knave of Hearts, 7 of Clubs, Ace of Spades.

Synthesis: The GM combines the suits:

- **Hearts (social) + Spades (harm)** = betrayal with injury.
- **Clubs (resource cost)** = material loss.
- **Ace** = scene-altering twist.

GM narration:

"You slip past the first guard, but your cloak catches on a rusty nail (Clubs – resource drain: your cloak tears, leaving a scrap of fabric behind). Worse, the second guard recognizes your face from a wanted poster – she’s your estranged cousin (Hearts – social betrayal). She hesitates for only a heartbeat, then shouts, “Traitor!” (Spades – harm escalates). As she draws her blade, a hidden portcullis drops behind you, sealing off the exit (Ace – scene shift). You’re trapped in the courtyard with her and two more guards."

This single three-card draw creates a layered, memorable complication from a single SB spend.

Appendix I: Session Zero Checklist Handout

Session Zero Checklist

Use this checklist during your Session Zero. Write down the answers where everyone can see them.

1. **Lines & Veils** – What content is off-limits (Lines) or only implied (Veils)?
2. **Tone** – Cinematic action? Grim survival? Political intrigue? Dark horror? Mix of several?
3. **Campaign length** – One-shot, short arc (3–6 sessions), or long campaign (12+ sessions)?
4. **Character hooks** – Each player shares one goal and one fear for their character.
5. **Patron interest** – Which Patrons (if any) are already watching the party?
6. **Starting situation** – Where does the story begin? (Use the Crown Spread or a simple opener.)
7. **House rules** – Any optional subsystems (Threat Pool, Deck of Consequences, etc.) you plan to use?
8. **Scheduling & attendance** – How often do you meet? What happens if a player misses a session?
9. **Player-GM contract** – Remind the table: "We are co-creators, not adversaries."
10. **Resource mindset** – "Boons are not XP tokens. Spend them. Embrace failure."
11. **Patron expectation** – "They are allies who demand payment – embrace it."
12. **Flavor is free** – Encourage descriptive narration for all actions, not just magic.

Appendix B

Using Expansions: A Guide for the Overwhelmed GM

"I bought every expansion. Then I sat at my table with thirty-seven PDFs and a blank look. The players were waiting. The beer was warm. I learned that night: you don't use expansions. You borrow from them." — The Grey Wanderer, from a letter found under a stack of printouts

B.1 The First Rule: You Own the Expansions, They Don't Own You

Every expansion in Fate's Edge is a toolbox, not a syllabus. You are never required to use a single rule, timer, or cultural detail from any expansion. The core game runs perfectly well on its own. Expansions exist to *solve specific problems* or *add specific flavors* when you need them.

B.1.1 The Three Questions to Ask Before Opening Any Expansion

Before you reach for a PDF, ask yourself:

1. **What problem am I solving?** (e.g., “combat feels same-y”, “my players want more political intrigue”, “we’re going to sea”)
2. **What is the smallest piece of this expansion that solves it?** (e.g., “just the Seven Bell Court judging table”, “just the travel timers”, “just the Lethai-ar witness knots”)
3. **Can I explain that piece to my players in one minute?** If not, pick a smaller piece.

B.1.2 The 10% Rule

A typical Fate's Edge expansion is 30-100 pages. In a single session, you will use **at most 10% of any expansion**. The other 90% is background, lore, alternative systems, and optional depth. You are not expected to master all of it.

B.2 A Taxonomy of Expansions (What They're Actually For)

Use this table to quickly identify which expansion to reach for. Expansions are grouped by **purpose**, not by title.

If you want...	Use expansions in this family	Example of a single mechanic to steal
Honorable duels, tournaments, social combat	Seven Bell Court, Vhasia: The Knave's Regret	The Form/Spirit/Intent judging table (3 rows, no dice)
New martial options (no magic)	The Way of the Warrior, Ykrul: Iron & Blood	A single talent chain (e.g., Sentinel, Bladestorm, Pathfinder)
Cultural depth for a specific people	Eastern Realms, Peoples and Cultures, The Frost Ledger	One etiquette hook and one String (e.g., "Aelinnel never ring the ninth bell")
Investigation	The Salt Ledger, The Wandering Ledger, Saikou Ira's Compendium	One clue type (e.g., "a silver coin in the mouth = ferryman's toll")
Sea travel, naval combat, port intrigue	The Amaranthine Sea	Travel timers [4-8] and the Inspection procedure
Folk horror, psychological tension	Horror Campaigns, The Frost Ledger, Mistslands expansion	The Dread Timer (4-8 segments)
Witchcraft, curses, bargains	Witches of Fate's Edge, Daughters of the Unbroken Cord	One working type (e.g., Chord Working, Promise Timer, Cord of Flesh)
Patron-heavy campaigns	The Grey Wanderer's Grimoire, Malachai, The Chained Angel	One new Patron with its Rites and Obligation flavor
Dungeon crawling, ancient lairs	Dragon's Lair, The Book of Air, Mist, Alder, Thorn, and Mirror	Lair moves (3-4 per scene)
Political intrigue	Political Intrigue framework, Vhasia, Viterra expansions	Faction timers (Influence/Stability/Exposure)
Caravans, travel, trade	Caravans: The Way of Silk, The Wandering Ledger	Travel intent dial (Speed/Stealth/Show/Tribute)

B.3 The Hybrid Adventure: How to Cook with Leftovers

The most successful way to use expansions is to build a **hybrid adventure**: one core story (often from a free adventure or your own imagination) with mechanics borrowed from 2-4 expansions.

B.3.1 Example: The Tournament of the Broken Crown

The GM wanted:

- A tournament (so players could fight without dying).
- A murder mystery (so non-combat characters had something to do).
- Cultural flavor (so the world felt lived-in).

They borrowed:

- **Judging table** from *Seven Bell Court* (3 rows: Form, Spirit, Intent).
- **Unbuckled gorget clue** from *Vhasia: The Knave's Regret* (mercy as a theme).
- **Bell-tending** and **witness knots** from *Eastern Realms* (investigation hooks).
- **Martial talents** from *The Way of the Warrior* (Disciplined Body, Shield Bearer, Flurry).

Prep time: 90 minutes. **Pages read:** 15 total across four expansions. **Result:** A 3-hour session that felt fresh, deep, and manageable.

B.3.2 The Hybrid Recipe

1. Pick a **core activity** (tournament, heist, travel, investigation).
2. Identify **one gap** in the core rules that an expansion fills (e.g., “combat lacks stakes beyond HP” → *SevenBellCourt*).
2. Read **only the first 5-10 pages** of that expansion until you find a mechanic you understand.
3. Add **one cultural hook** from a lore expansion (e.g., “in this city, knights unbuckle their gorgets to show mercy”).
4. Add **one talent** from a player-options expansion (e.g., give an NPC a talent from *The Way of the Warrior*).
5. Run the session. **Ignore every other rule** from the expansions.

B.4 Managing Player Expectations

When players know you own expansions, they will ask to use things. This is a gift, not a burden.

B.4.1 The “Yes, But Later” Rule

When a player asks “Can I use the Shadow Step talent from *Witches of Fate's Edge*?”

- **Yes:** “Yes, but you’ll need to earn it through roleplay. Find a hag or a Lethai-ar teacher in the next town.”
- **No, but:** “No, but you can take a different talent from the core book that works similarly, and we’ll reskin it.”
- **Later:** “Not this session, but tell me about it during downtime and we’ll build it into your character’s arc.”

B.4.2 The Expansion Session Zero

At the start of a new campaign or arc, ask your players:

1. “Which expansions have you read?” (Be honest; they may have read none.)
2. “What’s one thing from an expansion you’d love to see in play?” (Write it down.)
3. “What’s one thing you absolutely don’t want?” (Lines and veils for expansion content.)

Then pick **one expansion** to feature prominently in the next 2-3 sessions. Rotate.

B.5 Cross-Expansion Synergy (When Two Books Work Better Than One)

Some expansions are designed to work together. Others accidentally complement each other. Here are known synergies:

- **Seven Bell Court + Vhasia: The Knave’s Regret** = duels that are judged on honor, not just damage. The “unbuckled gorget” becomes a mechanical choice (lower Defense, higher Spirit points).
- **The Amaranthine Sea + The Salt Ledger** = sea travel with port mysteries. Use the travel timers from *Sea* and the lighthouse/spirit stories from *Salt* as random encounters.
- **Witches of Fate’s Edge + Horror Campaigns** = curse-based horror. Use the Dread Timer and the Cord mechanics together; each curse failure ticks the Dread Timer .
- **Eastern Realms + The Way of the Warrior** = culturally-infused martial characters. Let a Lethai-al samurai take Bushido-style talents from *Warrior* and re flavor them as “the Way of the Leaf.”

B.5.1 Antisynergy: When Not to Mix

Some expansions actively fight each other. Avoid:

- **Too many timers.** *Horror Campaigns* (Dread Timer , Reality Fracture) + *Political Intrigue* (Mandate, Crisis) + *The Amaranthine Sea* (Weather Window, Patrol Net) = 6+ timers. Players cannot track that many. Pick 2-3 maximum per session.
- **Contradictory cultural lore.** The *Eastern Realms* and *The Salt Ledger* have different

versions of Aelinnel bell-customs. Choose one interpretation for your campaign and stick to it. Tell players “we’re using the *Eastern Realms* version.”

B.6 Practical Tools: The Expansion Integration Checklist

Before a session where you plan to use expansion content, run through this checklist.

B.6.1 Pre-Session (30-60 minutes)

1. **Select 1-3 expansions** to draw from. Write their names on an index card.
2. **Extract 1-3 mechanics** from each expansion. Write each mechanic as a single sentence on the card.
3. **Prepare one page of reference.** Print the relevant table (e.g., Seven Bell Court judging, travel timer sizes, talent list). Do not print the whole expansion.
4. **Note page numbers.** If you must look something up, know where it is.
5. **Check for conflicts.** Do any of your chosen mechanics use the same resource (e.g., both use Boons in contradictory ways)? If yes, pick one.

B.6.2 During Session (At the Table)

1. **Announce the new mechanic.** “Tonight we’re using the Seven Bell Court. Your duels will be judged on Form, Spirit, and Intent.”
2. **Demonstrate once.** Run a quick mock duel or skill challenge to show how it works.
3. **Let players opt out.** If someone doesn’t want to use a new subsystem, let them use the core rules instead.
4. **Keep a timer.** If a new mechanic slows play for more than 2 minutes, simplify it or drop it for the scene.

B.6.3 Post-Session (5 minutes)

1. **Ask:** “What expansion mechanic worked? What didn’t?”
2. **Note:** Write down which pages you actually used. Toss the rest.
3. **Decide:** Will you use this expansion again? If yes, put the relevant page in your GM binder. If no, archive it.

B.7 DM’s Cheat Sheet: Quick Reference by Page Count

If you have limited time before a session, use this triage guide.

Expansion	Read these pages	Skip these pages
-----------	------------------	------------------

Seven Bell Court	5-7 (judging table, Honor/Pragmatism)	Tournament logistics, NPC champion statblocks
Vhasia: The Knave's Regret	1-3 (the opening fiction), 25-27 (talents)	Full canton descriptions, duel history
Way of the Warrior	31 (talent quick reference)	Cultural warrior variants (unless a player is one)
Eastern Realms	13-14 (bell-tending, witness knots)	Travel decks (use only when traveling)
Witches of Fate's Edge	i-iv (first principles), 89-91 (Threshold working)	Deep hag lore, full talent trees
The Amaranthine Sea	9-11 (travel timers, inspection)	Fleet combat rules, ship statblocks
Horror Campaigns	5-6 (Dread Timer), 8-9 (breaking points)	Extended campaign timers (use only for long arcs)
Dragon's Lair	3-5 (lair generator), 21 (dragon moves)	Hoard generators, dragon stats (improvise Tier)
The Salt Ledger	Any single story (use as adventure seed)	The rest of the stories (save for later)

Magic Adjudication Quick Reference (GM)

Default Magic DV

Effect scope	DV
Cantrip (1 tag)	2
Combat spell (2 tags)	3
Ritual (small, 3 tags)	4
Ritual (large, dangerous tags)	5+

Free Casting (TAGS)

$$DV = 1 + \#tags \quad (\text{dangerous tags: } +2 \text{ instead of } +1)$$

Dangerous tags: Leap, Fold, Gate, Gravity, Create, Summon, Transmute, Animate, Transform, Dominate, Rewind, Resurrect.

Backlash: Spend SB from 1s. Severity by Position:

- Dominant: minor (noise, Fatigue 1)
- Controlled: moderate (Harm 1, Condition)
- Desperate: severe (Harm 2, scene shift)

Rites (Runekeepers & Invokers)

$$DV = \max(\text{ObligationCost} - \text{Spirit}, \text{Tier: Low}=1, \text{Standard}=2, \text{High}=3)$$

Obligation overflow: Exceed Capacity (Spirit+Presence) $\rightarrow$ *mark1Fatiguepersegment.Exceed2Capacity $\rightarrow$ +1Harm, Patronintrusion.*

Healing Magic

- **[HEAL] only:** Restores 1 Fatigue. DV 2. 1 action.
- **[HEAL] + another tag (Purify, Strengthen, Cleanse):** Restores 1 Harm. DV = 2 + number of tags, plus **+2 surcharge**. Requires two actions unless Push.
- **Ritual healing (Harm 2+):** Requires Extended ritual (timer), rare components.

Summoning

- **Call:** 1 action, spirit manifests.
- **Bind:** 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue.
- **Leash capacity:** Cap + Spirit segments. Tick when: spirit takes Harm, acts against nature, crosses a [WARD], summoner splits focus, rival contests control.
- **Boon Finesse:** Once/round, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 Leash tick.
- **Leash full:** Spirit acts once to its nature, then departs (or turns hostile).

Cantors (Songs)

- **Sing:** 1 action, resolves next turn. Roll Lore + Performance (DV 2–3).
- **Push:** Resolve immediately, mark 1 Fatigue, advance Corruption Timer by 1.
- **Corruption Timer :** Size = Spirit. When full $\rightarrow$ *bloom(gainbenefit&burdenfromlastpatron),resettoTier(m*
- **Resonant Rite:** Performance with 10+ witnesses $\rightarrow$ *mayfoundChorus(minorfollowerbenefit,Obligationto*

Patron Intrusions (when Obligation overflows or GM spends 2+ SB)

- Demand a quest (“Find my stolen symbol.”)
- Impose a cost (“Your next Rite costs double.”)

- Send an omen (“Candles burn blue; you feel watched.”)
- Summon a rival servant (“Another follower of Malachai is hunting you.”)

Common Magic Rulings

- **Countermagic:** [COUNTER] tag vs. DV = spell’s DV. Success cancels.
- **Dispel:** [DISPEL] vs. DV = effect’s Tier (1–5). On hit, effect ends.
- **Wards:** [WARD] vs. Outsider. DV = target’s Cap. Crosser adds DV to Leash.
- **Line of sight:** Required for most spells; without it +1 DV.

B.8 Adversary Templates

B.8.1 Generic Adversaries

Use these for filler encounters. No special traits—just core stats. Scale by adjusting Threat Level (see Table B.3). All use standard attack/defense as per Chapter 2.

- **Bandit Rabble** (Threat Level 1)
Stats: Body 2, Wits 1, Spirit 1, Presence 1 | *Skills:* Melee 1, Athletics 1
Flavor: “Desperate locals with rusty blades. They flee if half their number falls.”
Use: Random encounters, tavern brawls, distractions.
- **City Watch Recruit** (Threat Level 2)
Stats: Body 2, Wits 1, Spirit 1, Presence 2 | *Skills:* Melee 1, Command 1
Flavor: “Poorly trained but eager to prove themselves. Will call for backup if overwhelmed (alarm raises a 4-segment timer).”
Use: Urban patrols, gate guards, low-level enforcement.
- **Cult Novice** (Threat Level 1)
Stats: Body 1, Wits 1, Spirit 2, Presence 1 | *Skills:* Lore 1 (cult-specific), Sway 1
Flavor: “True believer, poorly trained. Will gladly die for the cause but breaks if shown proof their faith is a lie.”
Use: Guarding rituals, spreading propaganda, cannon fodder. On a Miss when trying to recruit or intimidate, they may flee or surrender (GM discretion).
- **Street Thug** (Threat Level 2)
Stats: Body 3, Wits 1, Spirit 1, Presence 1 | *Skills:* Brawl 2, Intimidation (Presence+Brawl)
Flavor: “Enforcer for a local gang. Favors cheap shots and overwhelming numbers.”
Use: Alley ambushes, protection rackets, gang warfare.
- **Guard Sergeant** (Threat Level 3)
Stats: Body 3, Wits 2, Spirit 2, Presence 2 | *Skills:* Melee 2, Command 1, Athletics 1
Flavor: “Veteran who has seen it all. Leads from the front and shouts orders.”
Use: Leader of a watch patrol, military outpost, or noble’s bodyguard.

Adjust all Attributes and Skills uniformly. For Threat Level 0, treat as flavor only (no combat threat). For Threat Level 3+, consider giving one simple trait from the archetypes below.

Table B.3: Threat Level Scaling

Threat Level	Stat Adjustment	Typical Use	PC Tier Match
0	−1 to all stats	Non-threatening flavor	Below PC tier
1	Base stats (as written)	Standard minions	PC tier −1
2	+1 to all stats	Tougher minions / elite	PC tier
3	+2 to all stats	Mini-boss equivalent	PC tier +1
4+	+3 to all stats & add one archetype trait	Major boss	PC tier +2

B.8.2 Archetypal Adversaries

Each has one thematic mechanic tied to existing rules. Use as recurring threats, scene-setters, or mini-bosses. Scale via Threat Level table.

The Iron Patriarch / Matriarch

Archetype: Ruthless leader of a family, guild, or corporation. Values legacy and control above all.

Stats (Threat Level 2): Body 2, Wits 3, Spirit 2, Presence 3 | *Skills:* Sway 2, Command 1, Lore 1 (family/guild)

Thematic Mechanic: *Legacy's Weight*

When the Patriarch/Matriarch would take Harm, they may immediately order a loyal subordinate (if present) to take the blow. Roll Wits + Command *vs. DV 2*. On success, the subordinate takes 1 Harm instead (armor applies normally). On failure, the Patriarch takes the Harm but gains +1 die on their next action (resolve fueled by desperation).

Flavor Hook: “They don’t fear death—they fear their life’s work dying with them. Every blow you strike feels like it’s aimed not at them, but at the empire they bled to build.”

Rules Tie-In: Uses opposed rolls (see Chapter 2) and Harm (see Chapter 2).

The Hollow Prophet

Archetype: Charismatic leader of a movement built on a lie (or partial truth). Believes their own deception.

Stats (Threat Level 2): Body 1, Wits 2, Spirit 3, Presence 3 | *Skills:* Sway 2, Lore 1 (doctrine), Deception 1

Thematic Mechanic: *Faith's Fragility*

When the Hollow Prophet successfully uses Sway to convert a bystander or reinforce a follower’s faith, they generate **1 extra Story Beat** (beyond any generated by 1s). However, if the Sway attempt **fails** (Miss), they gain a *Despair* Condition: −1 die to all Spirit and Wits rolls until they successfully persuade someone or gain 1 Boon.

Flavor Hook: “Their eyes glow with conviction as they speak—but when you catch their reflection in a dark window, you see only exhaustion and doubt. The lie sustains them... but how long until it cracks?”

Rules Tie-In: Uses Story Beats (??) and Conditions (see Chapter 2).

The Gearsmith

Archetype: Obsessed tinkerer, weaponsmith, or arcane engineer. Sees people as problems to solve.

Stats (Threat Level 2): Body 2, Wits 3, Spirit 1, Presence 2 | *Skills:* Craft 2, Mechanics 1, Brawl 1

Thematic Mechanic: *Improvised Countermove (Cost: 1 Boon)*

When the Gearsmith is targeted by an action (attack, skill use, etc.), the GM may spend 1 Story Beat (or 1 Boon from the GM's pool – see section 3.3) to invent a reactive device on the spot. The device negates the incoming action and imposes one relevant Condition (e.g., *Entangled*, *Blinded*, *Shaken*) on the attacker. The device is single-use and narratively described (GM improvises based on the scene). This ability can be used at most once per round.

Flavor Hook: “They don’t dodge your sword—they’re already calculating how to turn its momentum against you. That clang wasn’t a block; it was the sound of a spring-loading.”

Rules Tie-In: Uses Story Beats (??) and Conditions (see Chapter 2).

The Iron-Bound Rival (PC Mirror)

Archetype: Former ally, rival adventurer, or ideological opponent who mirrors the PCs’ path.

Stats: Match the PC’s highest two Attributes at their current rating. Match the PC’s two highest Skills at their current rating. Other stats default to 1 or 0 as appropriate.

Thematic Mechanic: *Anticipate Move*

When a PC declares an action targeting the Rival, the Rival gains +1 die to any defensive or opposing roll (e.g., dodging an attack, resisting Sway, countering a skill use). This bonus does not stack if multiple PCs act against the Rival in the same exchange.

Flavor Hook: “They move not like a fighter, but like a shadow of your own choices—always one step ahead of where you *think* you’re going, but never where you *are*.”

Rules Tie-In: Uses opposed rolls (see Chapter 2) and mirrors PC progression.

The Weeping Martyr

Archetype: Someone who has lost everything and fights with suicidal abandon.

Stats (Threat Level 2): Body 3, Wits 1, Spirit 3, Presence 1 | *Skills:* Melee 2, Endurance 2, Intimidation (Presence+Brawl)

Thematic Mechanic: *Blood Price*

When the Martyr takes Harm, they immediately gain +1 die on their next attack or physical action (pain fuels fury). Additionally, if they are reduced to Harm 3 (incapacitated), they may make one final attack as a free action before falling. This attack ignores all Position penalties and deals +1 Harm.

Flavor Hook: “They don’t even try to block your strike—they lean into it, grinning through bloody teeth. Every wound is another coin in a purse they’ll never spend.”

Rules Tie-In: Uses Harm levels (see Chapter 2) and the “roller-coaster” effect (see 3.2).

The Shadow Broker

Archetype: Information dealer, blackmailer, or spymaster who never fights fair.

Stats (Threat Level 2): Body 1, Wits 4, Spirit 2, Presence 2 | *Skills:* Subterfuge 3, Insight 2, Streetwise 2

Thematic Mechanic: *I Know a Guy* (Cost: 1 Story Beat)

Once per scene, the Shadow Broker may spend 1 Story Beat to declare that they have prepared for the current situation. They produce a minor but useful asset (e.g., a hidden exit, a bribed guard, a forged document) that grants the party (or their own allies) +1 die or improves Position by one step on a single roll. The GM narrates the asset and its limitations.

Flavor Hook: “You never see them draw a weapon. You only see the trap they set three scenes ago, the witness they paid off, the escape route you didn’t know existed.”

Rules Tie-In: Uses Story Beats (??) and Assets (section 3.4). The Broker rarely engages in direct combat; instead, they create advantages.

B.8.3 Using These Templates in Play

- **Generic foes:** Drop in instantly. Adjust Threat Level via Table B.3. No prep beyond naming them.
- **Archetypal foes:** Pick one matching your scene’s theme. Note their one mechanic. Use the *Flavor Hook* to guide narration.
- **Scaling:** If PCs are Tier III, treat Threat Level 2 as baseline. For major encounters, use Threat Level 3 or 4 archetypes.
- **No extra bookkeeping:** Mechanics reference existing rules—just apply them as written. The mechanic is the *only* thing to remember beyond core stats.

Design Philosophy: Generic foes exist to threaten through numbers and positioning (using core rules only). Archetypal foes add narrative depth via one self-contained mechanic that reflects their core theme—never requiring tracking beyond the encounter. All mechanics are verifiable in the core rules (see citations in the text).

Index

- Acasia, 114
- advanced techniques, 101
- Advantages, 22
- Aelaerem, 115
- Aeler, 116
- Aelinnel, 117
- arc, 16
- asset conditions, 141
- Assets
 - GM guidance, 31
- assist limit, 134
- backlash
 - GM guidance, 50
 - GM tools, 57
- Black Banners, 118
- Boons
 - GM guidance, 30
 - spending encouragement, 30
- boons
 - economy, 133
 - scarcity at high tiers, 92
- brittleness, 93
- campaign
 - setup, 79
- campaign pacing, 141
- campaign timers
 - examples, 141
- campaigns, 75
 - situations vs plots, 75
- cantor
 - GM, 60
- character arcs
 - obligation, 89
- clean success, 133
- Combat
 - Over-Stack, 22
- combat
 - grid, 136
 - mass, 136
- combat resources
 - GM guidance, 39
- complications, 83
- conflict resolution, 142
- consequences, 75
 - cascade, 76
- core loop, 15
- core philosophy, 9
- corruption
 - GM, 58
- Crown, 88
- Crown Spread, 79
- currency
 - GM guidance, 44
- custom content
 - high tier, 106
- Deck of Consequences
 - advanced, 102
- deck of consequences
 - interpretation, 139
 - procedure, 139
 - sample reading, 148
- decks, 139
- default settings, 15
- difficulty value
 - ladder, 133
- Downtime Log, 40
- DV, 18
 - inflation warning, 94
 - ladder, 18
- Echo Character, 40
- Ecktoria, 119
- elements of magic, 140
- epic tier, 92
- epilogue, 89
- examples
 - core loop, 24
- expansions, 150
- Experience Points (XP), 6
- exploration
 - hex, 136
- factions, 82

- advanced, 104
- loyalty scale, 141
- turn, 82
- Fatigue
 - GM guidance, 28
 - roller-coaster effect, 29
- Finale, 88
- flavor is free, 10
- follower actions, 134
- follower conditions, 141
- Followers
 - GM guidance, 31
- free casting
 - procedure, 140
- fronts, 82
- GM as player, 8
- GM guidance
 - adjudicating magic, 51
 - creative magic, 52
 - dangerous tag rulings, 54
 - healing, 55
 - magic philosophy, 50
 - scenarios, 67
- GM mindset, 12
 - core principles, 14
 - modularity, 8
- GM philosophy, 5
 - consequences, 5
- GM pitfalls, 15
- GM procedures, 12
- GM reference
 - magic, 65
- GM responsibilities, 87
- GM rulings
 - advanced, 109
- GM tools
 - overview, 6
- Golden Rule, 19
- harm
 - levels, 134
- hazards, 83
- hex keywords, 137
- inclusivity, 142
- Influence Timer , 34
 - GM advice, 34
- introduction, 5
- Invoker
 - Symbol friction, 108
- Legacy Conversion, 89
- Lines, 7
- Linn, 120
- lore compendium
 - use, 112, 131
- magic
 - dangerous tags, 53
 - GM guidance, 50
 - healing, 55
 - paths comparison, 140
 - range, 52
- meaningful growth, 6
- mechanics serve story, 5
- miniatures, 136
- miss, 133
- Mistlands, 121
- movement actions, 134
- mythic failure, 98
- mythic scenarios, 107
 - sacrifice, 107
- narrative first, 91
 - resources, 40
- narrative primacy, 5
- narrative time, 16
- Obligation
 - as story fuel, 76
- obligation
 - GM, 58
- other regions, 131
- outcome matrix, 133
- partial success, 133
- Patrons
 - active vs passive, 50
 - cross-Patron conflicts, 108
 - in character arcs, 89
 - terrestrial, 34
- player input, 77
- player sheets
 - as campaign fuel, 76
- player-GM contract, 9
- player-managed modules, 58
 - high tier, 108
- Position, 18
 - mechanics, 18
- position
 - descriptions, 133
- preparation
 - between-sessions, 69

- scenario, 68
- pressure engine, 14, 16
- psionics
 - GM, 65
- quick reference, 7, 132
- range bands, 134
- resolution cycle, 17
- resources
 - GM guidance, 27
 - philosophy, 27
- risk as drama, 6
- rites
 - difficulty value, 140
- rituals
 - components as devotion, 64
 - GM, 63
- rival factions, 63
- rival parties, 83
 - generator, 143
- round, 16
- safety tools, 7
 - script change, 142
 - X-Card, 142
- scenarios
 - running, 67
- scene, 16
- session, 16
- Session Zero, 9
 - handout, 149
- shared XP pool, 36
- Silkstrand, 122
- skill rolls
 - common examples, 138
- Story Beats
 - advanced, 101
 - as pacing tool, 101
- story beats
 - magic, 57
 - spending, 133
- Story Beats (SB), 6
 - example, 19
 - GM guidance, 20
- success with sb, 133
- summoning
 - GM, 59
- supply timer, 134
- Supply Timer , 27
- TAGS
 - dangerous, 53
 - list
 - dangerous, 53
 - measuring by narrative impact, 53
 - Ten Percent Rule, 9
 - Theona, 123
 - Thepyrgos, 124
 - thresholds
 - adjudication, 103
 - Tier IV, 92
 - Tier V, 92
 - tiers
 - campaign design, 77
 - timers, 75
 - advanced, 105
 - design principle, 76
 - GM guidance, 81
 - reality fracture, 107
 - visibility, 77
 - trackers
 - physical, 77
 - travel
 - GM guidance, 75
 - GM techniques, 84
 - travel timers, 135
 - Trusts, 36
 - turn, 16
 - Ubral, 125
 - upkeep, 135
 - Valewood, 126
 - Veils, 7
 - veteran GM guide, 10
 - Vhasia, 127
 - Viterra, 128
 - weaver of consequences, 5
 - X-Card, 7
 - XP
 - as currency, 44
 - costs, 135
 - Ykrul, 129
 - Zakov, 130